

PRICE \$10.99

THE

SEPT. 7, 2026

NEW YORKER



The New Yorker Magazine

[September 7, 2026]

- **Goings On**
- **The Talk of the Town**
- **Reporting & Essays**
- **Fiction**
- **The Critics**
- **Poems**
- **Puzzles & Games**

Goings On

- **Kacey Musgraves, Crossover Queen**

By Sheldon Pearce, Brian Seibert, Jane Bua, Rhoda Feng, and Richard Brody | Also: John David Washington plays a tech bro in “Disruption,” Samara Joy and Christian McBride perform at Central Park, Jacob Elordi’s stars in Ridley Scott’s latest movie, and more.

- **A Tasting Menu That Uses Every Last Scrap**

By Helen Rosner | At Cynthia, an emphasis on low-waste cooking yields a menu of thrilling abundance.

- **Three Books That Will Transport You**

By Katy Waldman | Be moved the old-fashioned way.

[Goings On](#)

Kacey Musgraves, Crossover Queen

Also: John David Washington plays a tech bro in “Disruption,” Samara Joy and Christian McBride perform at Central Park, Jacob Elordi’s stars in Ridley Scott’s latest movie, and more.

By [Sheldon Pearce](#), [Brian Seibert](#), [Jane Bua](#), [Rhoda Feng](#), and [Richard Brody](#)

August 28, 2026

In the past few years, country music has reëxerted its sway on the pop-music charts and the broader Zeitgeist they reflect, but the genre’s greatest crossover success story remains the Texas singer-songwriter **Kacey Musgraves**. Since her 2013 major-label début, “Same Trailer Different Park,” she has been a shaping voice of modern Americana, not just in the way her music marries rustic and cosmopolitan sensibilities but in its underlying progressive ideal. Clever, observant, and funny as hell, she is one of music’s sharpest lyricists, and a breakthrough in 2018, the kaleidoscopic disco-country masterpiece “Golden Hour,” expanded her creative world view, scaling up from small-town concerns to something more universal, winning Album of the Year at the Grammys in the process.



The country artist Kacey Musgraves swings through Madison Square Garden.

Photograph by Ramona Rosales / AUGUST

Musgraves’s subsequent albums have been sprawling in their search for meaning, and even more adventurous in the sonic pathways travelled to get there. “Star-Crossed,” from 2021, was a psychedelic divorce record that incorporated soft rock and dance music, while “Deeper Well,” from 2024, goes even more soft-spun for the songs of her Saturn return and its reassessed priorities, which included seeing the big picture. Her most recent album, “Middle of Nowhere,” is a homecoming, if not a full reset. Not only does its music scale back to the sounds of the country canon—bluegrass and Western swing, regional Mexican music such as *norteño*, and the Creole blues of zydeco, with plenty of acoustic guitar and pedal steel—it does so for meditations on how she defines herself as a woman and as an artist. Musgraves brings those conversations with her to the stage at [Madison Square Garden](#), on Aug. 31 and Sept. 1, as she continues her journey of self-discovery. —*Sheldon Pearce*



About Town

Dance

In 2001, the **Bill T. Jones/Arnie Zane Company** prepared a work that was scheduled to premiere, on a stage between the Twin Towers of the World Trade Center, on Sept. 12. The début did not happen, but, twenty-five years later, the company performs a new piece that reflects on that moment and all that has happened since. “Curriculum IV: Spin and Spin! Turn! Turn! Turn!,” the final offering of this year’s [River to River Festival](#), features a live score

by Samora Pinderhughes sourced from Nina Simone’s rendition of “Turn! Turn! Turn! (To Everything There Is a Season).” The free performances at Wagner Park also nod to the outdoor theatre’s presiding spirit, the Statue of Liberty.—*Brian Seibert (Robert F. Wagner, Jr., Park; Sept. 10, 12-13.)*

Classical

This has been a big summer for moviegoing—“The Odyssey,” “Minions 3,” “Jackass 5,” “Scary Movie 6”—and the **Met Opera** wants in on the action. It’s reigniting its [annual HD Festival](#), screening live recordings of recent operas. Did you miss the Met’s début of Gabriela Lena Frank’s “El Último Sueño de Frida y Diego”? They’ve got you. What about “I Puritani,” the first new production of Bellini’s bel-canto masterwork that the Met has put on in almost fifty years? Breathe easy. Have you always been afraid to sneak to the rest room during Wagner’s nearly five-hour “Tristan und Isolde”? No sweat: the festival splits it up into two movies, a day apart. You’ll just have to wait twenty-four more hours for that chord to resolve.—*Jane Bua (Josie Robertson Plaza; Sept. 2-7.)*

Off Broadway



Photograph by Emilio Madrid

The idea that “behind every great fortune is a great crime” gets a twist in Andrew Stein’s topical new artificial-unintelligence play, “**Disruption**,” in which a great fortune is about to be made through a series of moral crimes. Nick (John David Washington), a silky-smooth tech entrepreneur, invites three friends and their wives to invest in a new algorithm he’s developed, pitched as “Waze . . . but for your life.” Yet the unwitting guinea pigs are eerily reminiscent of what Daisy Hildyard calls “second bodies,” rather than ensouled beings. Their quiddities remain hazily drawn, snapping into focus only when required by Stein’s overdetermined plot; the rhizomatic spread of numbers across the stage floor—Zoë Hurwitz designed the set—reinforces that uncanny cybernetic quality.—*Rhoda Feng (Pershing Square Signature Center; through Oct. 4.)*

Jazz

As the [City Parks Foundation’s SummerStage](#) winds to a close, the concert series saves some of its best for last, pairing the singer **Samara Joy** with the bassist and bandleader **Christian McBride** to celebrate the seventieth anniversary of the historic jazz label Verve Records. A Bronx native and six-time Grammy winner, Joy is among the most expressive jazz performers working, her satiny and sumptuous voice deployed sparingly. McBride, a fixture of the scene since the early nineties, has collaborated with artists across the spectrum, including Joy, on his most recent album, “Without Further Ado, Vol 1.” They are joined by a group of other musicians, led by Mei Semones, in honoring “Getz/Gilberto,” the classic 1964 album by João Gilberto and Stan Getz.—*Sheldon Pearce (Rumsey Playfield in Central Park; Sept. 2.)*

Movies



“Filipinana” is set at a golf resort near Manila.

Photograph courtesy Kino Lorber

Exquisite style and confrontational substance fuse to startling effect in Rafael Manuel’s teeming début feature, **“Filipinana,”** which is set at a golf resort near Manila that’s a microcosm of modern political dysfunction. The story, which is told in comedically choreographed visual anecdotes, is centered on women who work there—caddies and so-called tee girls, whose underpaid labor puts them in close contact with wealthy, arrogant, and predatory men. The main drama involves a rural teen-age tee girl who recognizes the resort’s president as the potentate who evicted her family from their land. Rage stays wryly below the surface; Manuel sardonically delights in musical spectacles staged for guests, and the synchronized swinging of clubs at a driving range evokes the superficial charm of robotic lives.—*Richard Brody (Opening Aug. 28 at [Film Forum](#), nationally Sept. 4.)*

Movies

Ridley Scott brings admirable restraint to **“The Dog Stars,”** a post-apocalyptic drama set in Colorado in the near future, after a strain of influenza has killed most people. A mechanic named Hig (Jacob

Elordi), who lives at an abandoned airstrip with a fierce military veteran (Josh Brolin), pilots a small plane to the ghost town of Denver, where he fetches supplies and visits the house he'd shared with his late wife. In his travels, he encounters a father-and-daughter pair of ranchers (Guy Pearce and Margaret Qualley) and tries to make contact with other survivors. The heart of the film—despite gory confrontations with feral marauders—is the rebuilding of trust, the overcoming of grief, and the importance of vaccines; the science-fiction premise morphs sweetly into sentimental melodrama.—*R.B. (In wide release.)*

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [Take a walk on the moon](#)
- [It's as good as everyone says](#)
- [The 2026 Dogue winner is peak cute](#)

[Sheldon Pearce](#) is a music writer for The New Yorker's Goings On newsletter.

[Brian Seibert](#) has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2002. He is the author of "[What the Eye Hears: A History of Tap Dancing](#)," which won an Anisfield-Wolf Book Award. His writing appears in the New York Times and the New York Review of Books. A Guggenheim fellow, he teaches at Yale University.

[Jane Bua](#) is a member of The New Yorker's editorial staff who covers classical music for Goings On. Previously, she wrote for Pitchfork.

[Rhoda Feng](#), who received the 2025 Nona Balakian Citation for Excellence in Reviewing, has also written about theatre and books for Artforum, the Boston Globe, and the Times Literary Supplement, among other publications.

[Richard Brody](#), a film critic, began writing for The New Yorker in 1999. He is the author of "[Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard](#)."

<https://www.newyorker.com/culture/goings-on/kacey-musgraves-crossover-queen>

The Food Scene

A Tasting Menu That Uses Every Last Scrap

At Cynthia, an emphasis on low-waste cooking yields a menu of thrilling abundance.

By [Helen Rosner](#)

August 16, 2026



A meal at Cynthia is listed as six courses (seven with a Wagyu supplement, shown above), but some of them are suites of dishes built around shared ingredients.

Photographs by Matt Genovese for The New Yorker

*You're reading the Food Scene newsletter, Helen Rosner's guide to what, where, and how to eat. **Sign up to receive it in your inbox.***

At first, the most intriguing thing about Cynthia was that it made you work for it. Another upscale West Village restaurant in an ever-deepening sea of upscale West Village restaurants, Cynthia stood out by eschewing online reservation platforms in favor of old-fashioned e-mail. Send a note, wait for a reply, hope. I found this both intriguing and intimidating: the possibility of human rejection was far more daunting than a search result reading “No tables available for your selected date.” Fortunately for the anxious among us, and less fortunately for those still loyal to the dying rituals of interpersonal correspondence, Cynthia has recently moved to online reservations. A concession to scale? A move to

boost business? Either way, the path to booking a table is easier now, and—considering how overtly excellent I found Cynthia to be—that’s entirely a good thing.

The restaurant, which opened in May, is a co-production between the restaurateur Claire DuBois and the chef Sherry Cardoso. Cardoso has a blue-chip pedigree ([Per Se](#), [Brooklyn Fare](#)) but is best known, in the public imagination, for her star turn on the most recent season of “Top Chef,” in which she made it to the final three before losing, in a real nail-biter of a season finale. Cynthia is named for DuBois’s aunt, Cynthia Peck, the matriarch of the late Southern California stalwart Angelo’s and Vinci’s Ristorante, a red-sauce joint that she and her husband operated for decades. Unlike that spot, which was enormous and famed for a degree of raucousness, Cynthia is a tasting-menu restaurant, refined and notably tiny. You’ll likely brush elbows with your neighbors, and you’ll absolutely be able to eavesdrop on their conversation, though you might find yourself just too busy paying attention to the food, which is punchy, witty, and utterly thrilling.



A corn course has three parts: (clockwise from the top) corn posset with osetra caviar, corn ice cream with shaved foie gras, and corn with XO sauce over hunks of summer squash.

The meal is listed as six courses (seven, if you spring for a Wagyu supplement, eighty dollars for two), but what you're served is actually closer to a dozen, because several courses feature suites of dishes, built around shared ingredients and interconnecting elements. A corn course, for example, has three parts: first, a quenelle of corn ice cream, soft and summer-bright, set over ribbons of marinated summer squash, confettied with fluffy shaved foie gras and bits of nori. Next, kernels of corn stud a beurre blanc draped over faceted hunks of summer squash with sweetly charred edges. Last, and almost dessert-like, is an intensely concentrated corn posset, dense and rich as cream cheese, under a cloud of sheep's-milk-cheese foam and a dark dusting of the corn's burnt husk. The dish is finished with a blob of caviar—the good stuff,

platinum osetra. For once, in this caviar-obsessed town, a dish that justifies the use of roe by properly framing its delicate salinity.

Each of those corn preparations was entirely successful on its own; each could have served as a full course, a started-and-finished thought. I felt the same way about the lobster, which came in two parts: hunks of firm tail meat were served in a Thai-inflected red curry, intensely herbaceous and rich with coconut milk, and scattered with fresh-shaved black truffle; the more tender meat of the claw and knuckle was presented in a “taco,” with a tortilla made of pressed plantain, one of the menu’s many nods to Cardoso’s Brazilian upbringing. In the finale of “Top Chef,” one of Cardoso’s mentors warned her away from presenting multi-dish courses, lest one dish overshadow another. The only time this happened at Cynthia, though, was in the supplementary course of A5 Wagyu, a three-parter, in which a brisket-filled dumpling and a B.L.T.-inspired roulade of thinly sliced tongue both felt like drab afterthoughts compared to the main event: glimmering slices of rib eye, impossibly well marbled, served with creamy dollops of eggplant purée. Maybe the abundance just works better in a restaurant than it does at a judges’ table; there is an animalistic delight in being on the receiving end of so much thoughtful variety, even if, by the end of the proceedings, you may be approaching an Adephagian degree of stuffed.

Helen, Help Me!

[E-mail your questions](#) about dining, eating, and anything food-related, and Helen may respond in a future newsletter.

Cardoso’s approach also lends itself quite elegantly to another element of Cynthia’s culinary philosophy, an emphasis on low-waste cooking. Some ingredient scraps and stems are ferried off to the bar, where they infuse liquors or ferment into *tepache*. Others are stewed with aromatics and oil to make a riotous take on XO sauce, funky and inky and complex, which gilds the hunks of squash under their corny beurre blanc. Bits of pickled veg and

infused butters come with the bread course, and the Parker House-like bread itself is multicolored thanks to leftover bits of beet and ramp and carrot. Even the seeds strained out of lemon juice are pressed into service in a marmalade that's given to diners as a little take-home treat. This is sustainability theatre, a convoluted puzzle of ingredient inputs and outputs that is entirely unsustainable as a way to actually live—unless you have a kitchen staff and a room of paying customers. Still, it's awfully entertaining to see all the clever ways Cynthia pulls it off.

As at many tasting-menu restaurants, you'll receive your menu only at the end of your meal. To begin, instead, each diner is presented with a card printed with something between a manifesto and a poem: "There is no summer quite like a New York summer," it begins, and continues with a litany of the attributes of eggplant, tomato, watermelon, et al. Honestly, it's fiddle-faddle, self-serious and not nearly poetic enough; a meal that's this well executed doesn't need all that throat-clearing. In recent weeks, the restaurant has added an à-la-carte menu—it's available only at the bar, which takes up a third of the petite room. I won't argue the wisdom of that as a financial choice—can any restaurant survive these days if it doesn't offer a burger?—but it does risk dampening Cynthia's special, strange, sui-generis specificity. At the close of dinner, after all of those double and triple dishes, dessert arrives in the singular, and I don't need a poem to convey the beauty of its simplicity: a swirling scoop of watermelon sorbet served on top of coconut foam and crowned with cubes of cantaloupe and honeydew. I can see it, and taste it, right there on the plate. ♦

Helen Rosner, a staff writer at The New Yorker, has received multiple James Beard Awards, including one in 2025 for her [Profile of the food personality Padma Lakshmi](#).

<https://www.newyorker.com/culture/the-food-scene/a-tasting-menu-that-uses-every-last-scrap>

What We're Reading

Three Books That Will Transport You

By [Katy Waldman](#)

August 19, 2026



Illustration by Greg Clarke

This is the [What We're Reading](#) newsletter, featuring book recommendations from our writers and editors. [Sign up to receive it in your inbox.](#)

I'm going through a phase lately where almost everything reminds me of "[Adam's Curse](#)," by William Butler Yeats. The poem is about how our most worthwhile pursuits—things like art, love, and beauty—often seem to demand a measure of toil. Or, as a woman in the poem wistfully puts it, how "we must labour to be beautiful." The speaker reflects that "I strove / To love you in the old high way of love." He sounds tired from the effort.

Then I read my colleague [Hanif Abdurraqib's gorgeous essay](#) about our collective longing for inconvenience, in which he discusses a friend who "wants to fall in love *the old-fashioned way*," meaning without using a dating app. I thought immediately, "The curse!" Abdurraqib's point, though, appears to be that the curse might be a

blessing in disguise, or at least that our attempts to outrun the curse might be more cursed than the curse itself. (Yeats, proto-friction-maxxer that he seems to be, might agree: the poem ends on the image of a “hollow moon,” an emblem of empty, unsatisfying escapism if there ever was one.)

So when I was asked, by this newsletter’s editor, to recommend some “transporting” summer reads, I wanted, in the spirit of the curse, to highlight a few books whose transports can’t be separated from their “inconvenient” qualities: unconventionality, abstruseness, even unresolved emotional pain. I hope you love them in the old high way of love.

“Orbital,” by Samantha Harvey

Harvey’s novel centers on a group of six astronauts living in an international space station, hundreds of miles above Earth. No crisis hits, aliens don’t attack, the fuel supply is fine. Rather than a conventional setup-climax-dénouement plot, we get eerily domestic moments aboard the shuttle, affecting scraps of the characters’ memories, some of the most dazzling descriptions of light I’ve ever read—imagine Dante’s “Paradiso” with a secular overlay, as if space were simultaneously the seventh heaven and Earth’s untended back yard—and a sense of being out of history and time (“the whipcrack of morning arrives every ninety minutes,” Harvey writes). The novel—an astonishing work of humanism sheathed in an escapist premise—should be required reading for every faux-utopian tech stooge who wants to loot the planet so their A.I. systems can displace and replace people. (Not that I’m mad about it!)

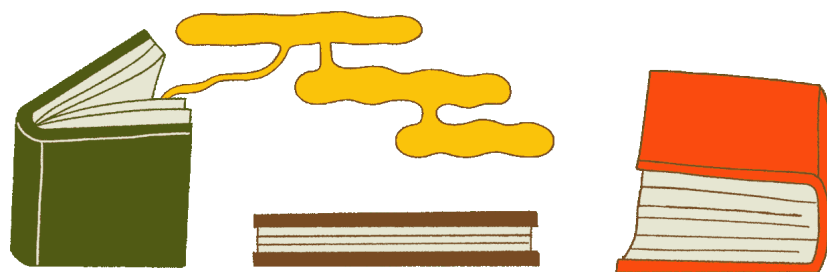
“The Sense of an Ending,” by Frank Kermode

My editor recommended this book to me after I pitched her a somewhat convoluted essay idea. She thought Kermode’s formal analysis of delay and catharsis in classic literary texts might be

useful. Not only was it *highly* useful (I abandoned the essay idea), it was thrilling, dense, complex, absorbing—and a real struggle to get through. I had to sit for a long time with individual sentences, in part because they demanded to be reality-tested against my own perceptions and in part because that’s what it took for me to understand them. Such deep concentration caused me to lose track of my surroundings—a true escape.

“A Truce That Is Not Peace,” by Miriam Toews

This book’s “inciting incident” is that, in order to participate in a conference, Toews has to answer the question “Why do you write?” Her mind returns to two formative events: the deaths, by suicide, of her father and sister, both of whom walked in front of trains. The experience of losing these family members, Toews shows, organizes her art, the way she is always hoping somehow, through language, to resurrect her loved ones, even as she insists she can’t. She expresses a preference for silence over false speech—a scorn for easy fictions is something she shared with her father and sister—but not over true speech, or true writing. Does this memoir, about some of the worst things that can happen to a person, offer escape? Sure—of the kind more commonly known as art.



Our editors and critics choose the most captivating, notable, brilliant, surprising, absorbing, weird, thought-provoking, and talked-about books. [Find your next great read »](#)

On Our Radar

Everybody's talking about:

- “[Life of M](#),” by Rachel Cusk, is among the most anticipated books of the moment. [See what our critic Becca Rothfeld has to say about it.](#)

Coming soon:

- Emma Cline’s “[Switzy](#),” which is long-listed for a Booker Prize this year, will be out on September 8th. Until then, read an excerpt [recently published in *The New Yorker*](#).
- John Green is back to fiction, with “[Hollywood Ending](#),” out on September 22nd. It’s about two actors cast in an Andy Warhol bio-pic.
- “[The True Confessions of First Lady Freeman](#),” by Deesha Philyaw, is centered on the wife of a megachurch pastor. It’s out September 29th.

P.S. Have you read all the books Barack Obama plans to discuss on [his new podcast](#)? 🎙️

*[Katy Waldman](#), a staff writer, has written about books and culture for *The New Yorker* since 2018.*

<https://www.newyorker.com/books/what-were-reading/three-books-that-will-transport-you>

The Talk of the Town

- **Mark Zuckerberg's Social Reckoning**

By Benjamin Wallace-Wells | The Meta settlement will force meaningful changes on Facebook and Instagram. It also reflects the degree to which public outrage is outmatched by the speed and size of Big Tech.

- **Where to Get Fire Outfits for Burning Man**

By Henry Alford | Heading to the playa like Paris Hilton and Mark Zuckerberg once did? Need a faux-fur coat or a secret stash pouch? The Burning Man Bazaar has you covered.

- **All Rise! Coyote Court Is Now in Session**

By Zach Helfand | In the new film “Coyote vs. Acme,” starring Will Forte, Wile E. Coyote demands justice from the company that keeps blowing him up. Here to weigh in is the personal-injury attorney Motorcycle Mike.

- **Jim Nollman's Orca-stra**

By Sarah Larson | The sound artist spent thirteen years playing guitar alongside singing whales in British Columbia. Now he's releasing their collaboration, on “Orcas' Greatest Hits.”

- **Dolly Parton for the People**

By Kathryn Schulz | She was commonly called the Queen of Country Music, but that is exactly wrong: she was democratic to her bones.

[Comment](#)

Mark Zuckerberg's Social Reckoning

The Meta settlement will force meaningful changes on Facebook and Instagram. It also reflects the degree to which public outrage is outmatched by the speed and size of Big Tech.

By [Benjamin Wallace-Wells](#)

August 30, 2026



Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photograph from Getty

When Mark Zuckerberg, the founder and C.E.O. of Meta, the company behind Facebook and Instagram, has tried to defend his business to the public, it's generally gone poorly. ("I think I'm actually well known to be sort of bad at this," the billionaire confessed, while giving testimony at a trial in February.) Confronted with leaked internal documents showing that Meta's products made body-image issues worse for one in three teen girls, and that many of them blamed Facebook and Instagram for

increases in over-all anxiety and depression, Zuckerberg dismissed his own company's findings as user "feedback." This winter, as a plaintiff's lawyer in Los Angeles presented him with extensive evidence supporting a link between Meta's social-media brands and the mental health of its teen-age users, Zuckerberg said, more than a dozen times, "You're mischaracterizing this."

Such episodes now look like clumsy moments in a decade of dissembling. Last Wednesday, Meta reached a settlement with the attorneys general of forty-seven states, who had sued it for illegally manipulating the attention of children. The settlement will cost the company, which didn't acknowledge wrongdoing, up to seventeen billion dollars, a striking figure. Even more striking is a detail reported by the *Wall Street Journal*: during the second quarter of 2026 alone, Meta spent more than two billion dollars on its legal defense.

The trial, held in Oakland, hinged on an argument that, even if social-media providers cannot be held responsible for the content that their users post—a protection established in Section 230 of the Communications Decency Act—they should be liable for the algorithms that shape what users see. Before the settlement, the plaintiffs had made a strong case. The states presented evidence that senior executives at Meta, intent on maximizing their company's growth, had repeatedly set aside concerns about what its products were doing to its youngest users. A former Meta engineer testified that he had e-mailed Zuckerberg data showing that the chance of a teen encountering violent or graphic content was between a hundred and four hundred times higher than what the company acknowledged publicly.

Beyond the financial penalty, Meta agreed to make measures that could, if spread through the industry, meaningfully change the experience of social media: Facebook and Instagram will remove the "like" count on posts, do more to verify that their users are at least thirteen years old, limit the service to two hours a day for

teen-agers, and restrict service entirely for those users during nighttime hours. There were signs, too, that the public pressure on Meta may yet continue. Florida's attorney general, James Uthmeier, stayed away from the lawsuit, arguing that it did not go far enough. After the settlement was announced, he released a statement saying, "We'll see them at trial."

The settlement was quickly compared to the tobacco lawsuits of the nineties, a moment of public clarity during which a ubiquitous product came to be seen as a scourge. But Meta, a trillion-dollar company increasingly invested in artificial intelligence, is so much vaster than RJR Nabisco, and the current settlement applies to only a single facet of its sprawling operations. There has always been an element of denial in the focus on Instagram's relationship with minors, when so many of the rest of us, of legal age, also scroll obsessively at weird hours. An unforgiving upcoming film about Meta, "The Social Reckoning," written and directed by Aaron Sorkin, ends with the January 6th riot at the Capitol, an event that had a lot to do with social media but not so much to do with kids.

It would be easier to view the settlement as a breakthrough in the public's relationship with technology if we, the public, did not keep making the same mistakes. The problem is speed. New technologies are being disseminated ever more quickly, and the machinery of politics and law delivers accountability at best intermittently, and then only at a painstaking crawl. It took more than a decade of worrying about the way teen-agers used Facebook and Instagram for a legal settlement to enforce a change in Meta's behavior. Meanwhile, the crypto industry was the largest corporate donor in the 2024 election cycle, and this year's midterms have been shaped by a voter backlash to A.I. data centers, which have cropped up across the country before the public has had a chance to weigh in on a technology that, as its own developers constantly warn, might be an existential threat.

The scale of private capital available to entrepreneurs has made the tech industry a particularly insular space. One story that the Meta settlement chased off the business pages was that of Leopold Aschenbrenner, a twenty-four-year-old former Columbia valedictorian who'd built a forty-five-billion-dollar hedge fund after making a bullish case for A.I. in a viral online essay. At parties, Aschenbrenner would tell friends that he planned to buy up the rights to faraway galaxies. In late July, when he failed to anticipate a tech downturn, thirty-five billion dollars of his investors' money vanished.

Zuckerberg has always been a less fanciful kind of founder. Like his products, he expands to fill a social container. In the Obama era, he and his wife launched a Bill Gates-style philanthropy that invested in medical research, education, and public health; these days, he's into mixed martial arts. (As the journalist Vincent Bevins has emphasized, social media itself followed a similar trajectory, in that what began as a tool to galvanize pro-democracy movements became useful to reactionary forces, too.) When interviewed about Sorkin's first movie about him, "The Social Network," Zuckerberg said that its creators had misunderstood him: "They just can't wrap their head around the idea that someone might build something because they like building things." But that formulation ignores the crucial matter of what those things do to the people who use them.

The social-media age may finally be waning—Facebook and Instagram chastised, investors looking elsewhere, even Donald Trump's Presidency, after an extended halftime break, now nearing its fourth quarter. But the relationship between tech and society has not really been altered, so different products continue to follow a familiar pattern: a cloaked and supercilious rollout, a sudden ubiquity, a panicked public response. Two decades on, we are still stuck in versions of Zuck. The week of the Facebook settlement, the cover of *Time* featured Sam Altman and Greg Brockman, two of the founders of OpenAI, making a defensive case for their product. The headline read, simply, "Trust Us." ♦

Benjamin Wallace-Wells began contributing to *The New Yorker* in 2006 and joined the magazine as a staff writer in 2015. He writes about American politics and society.

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/mark-zuckerbergs-social-reckoning>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

[Non-Essential Dept.](#)

Where to Get Fire Outfits for Burning Man

Heading to the playa like Paris Hilton and Mark Zuckerberg once did? Need a faux-fur coat or a secret stash pouch? The Burning Man Bazaar has you covered.

By [Henry Alford](#)

August 29, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

That vague daydream you have about going to Burning Man someday—the one where you emerge from the radical-honesty

workshop wearing nothing but patchouli oil and then proceed to writhe ecstatically on the desert floor until dawn—may need a little fine-tuning. After all, winds on the Black Rock Desert’s playa, or prehistoric lake bed, can reach up to seventy-five miles an hour and are loaded with enough alkali particles to burn the skin, and temperatures can range from a hundred and ten to forty. So you’re really going to expose your bare ass to some kind of thermally fluctuating, crust-forming Shake ’n Bake situation? Dude.

Nancy Marcus and her colleagues have you covered. Since 2013, Marcus has organized pop-up bazaars at which she and other designers sell clothes that they’ve designed or curated expressly “for the Burn.” Now in its fortieth year, Burning Man—which has attracted such unlikely pilgrims as Mark Zuckerberg, Paris Hilton, and Grover Norquist—was described by one longtime Burner as “a shantytown-trailer-park tailgate party.” But this summer’s Burner bazaar, held in SoHo, felt more like Mad Max, the Department Store. Nestled into a space the size of an airport Cinnabon, Marcus and thirteen other designers manned racks of clothes heavy on iridescence, leather, Day-Glo, and fake fur; the over-all vibe was, as one shopper put it, “very non-essential worker.” Marcus, in a lizardy, hand-painted skirt and bib, said that durability was an important aspect of designing for the Burn: “We build a city and we take it down, and we leave no trace. You can’t have sequins falling off your outfit.” She held up a pair of low-slung gold lamé pants to an older male customer, who enthused about the “dropped crotch.” Marcus encourages clients to buy clothes outside their comfort zone and to practice wearing them at home. Some purchase fourteen different outfits, one for each day and night of the festival.

One of Burning Man’s ten governing principles is radical self-expression, and the clothes complied. “It has a built-in assassin mask,” a designer named Ali Sardar said, of a mouth-level band of fabric emanating from the collar of a calf-length gray coat recycled from a vintage curtain (\$750). Sardar was wearing a topee, sunglasses, and a leopard-print shirt unbuttoned to the navel: the

playah on the playa. Jessica Ding, another designer, shyly said, of her leather holsters, “I have a high-femme warrior-queen aesthetic.”

Talk of the Town

Fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond



The Russian American designer Lunara Love, a Burning Man veteran, was mellower. (“I used to go like religion, like a church you can’t stop,” she said. “Then I came to my senses.”) She was selling swaths of wrinkled gauzy muslin and cotton fabric in neutral colors (\$200-\$300), just the thing to wear when cupping a stranger’s face in your hands and announcing, “I forgive you.” Love emphasized that a week of partying and art viewing on the playa can breed ferocity. “One time, I jumped ten feet down from an art car in platform shoes because I thought I was a cat,” she said. “Burning Man: safety third.”

A petite vender named Audra Rodriguez was selling tiny leather pouches—“for your herbs and powders and pills,” she explained. After Eva Bogdanova showed a preppy customer one of her minimalist “Adam” belts—essentially, a golf-ball-size metal ring attached to a narrow belt—the customer remarked that he had once been invited to a workshop called “The Nuance of the Pelvic Bowl.” She stared at him as if receiving instructions from outer space.

The designers were mostly united in their distaste for what are known on the playa as Sparkle Ponies. As Burning Man’s website describes them, “Often fashionably attired, they may have packed too many costumes and not enough radical self-reliance.” Love castigated “influencer girls who think they are queens and need to be served.” Marcus cautioned against “wedges that are too high” and “headpieces that are moving around and falling off the head.”

There was less consensus about the dust kicked up from the playa, which can be dense enough to cause whiteouts. “Embrace the dust,” Sam Lopez, a Peruvian designer, said, adding that the detritus left in the Sparkle Ponies’ wake—*MOOP*, or “matter out of place”—inspires his designs: “I think about my pieces *not MOOPing* out on bumpy bike rides.” A tall vender in leopard-print slacks wasn’t worried about what the desert might do to her full-length faux-fur coats. “When you’re done with the coat, you can just get rid of it,” she said. “Maybe at the airport.” ♦

Henry Alford, a humorist and a journalist, has contributed to The New Yorker since 1998. He is the author of the Joni Mitchell biography “[I Dream of Joni](#).”

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/where-to-get-fire-outfits-for-burning-man>

The Bench

All Rise! Coyote Court Is Now in Session

In the new film “Coyote vs. Acme,” starring Will Forte, Wile E. Coyote demands justice from the company that keeps blowing him up. Here to weigh in is the personal-injury attorney Motorcycle Mike.

By [Zach Helfand](#)

August 31, 2026

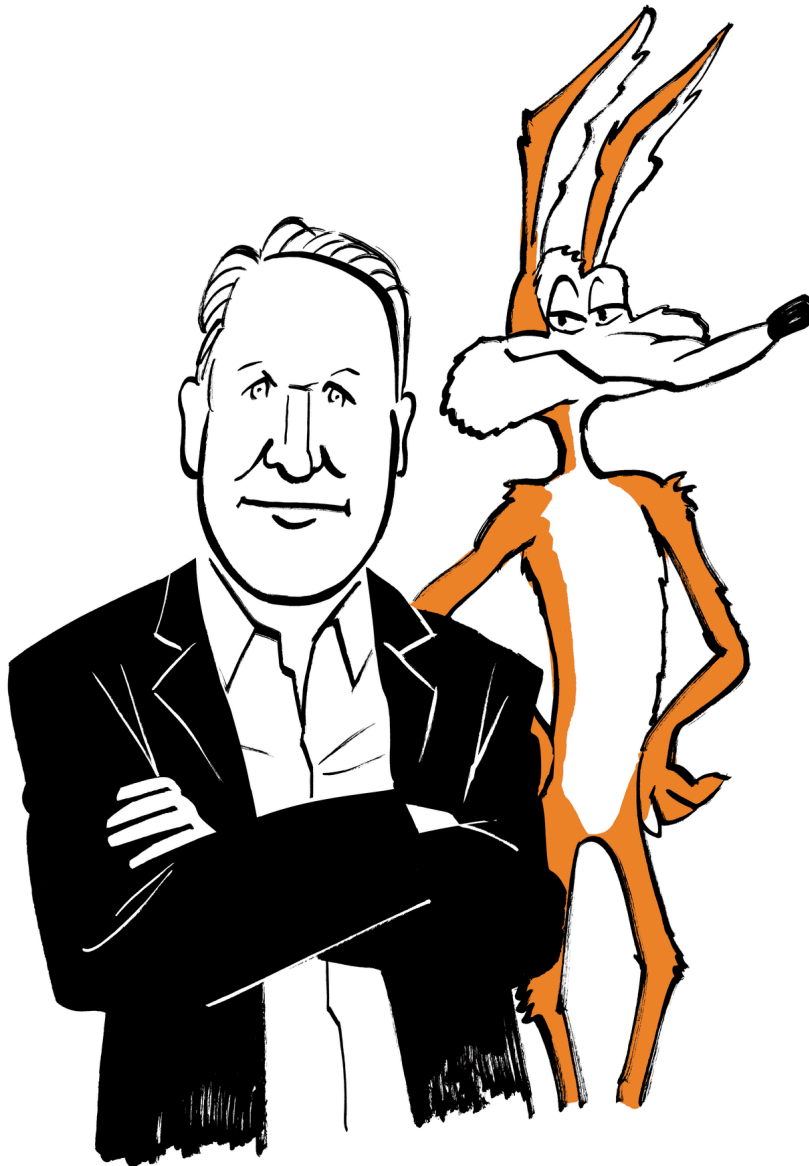


Illustration by João Fazenda

Oyez! Oyez! Oyez! All persons having business before this honorable court are admonished to draw near and give their attention, for the court is now sitting. Today, the court will issue a decision in the case Coyote v. Acme. A special judge has been drafted into service. He is the Honorable Michael Levine, a personal-injury attorney known to TV and radio audiences in the New York City and Long Island area as Motorcycle Mike. His chambers are in Islandia, on Long Island, with tennis trophies on the desk and an electric shoe buffer in the corner. Levine will hear the case on a break from deposition prep for a client who fell down a boat ramp at a marina.

CASE SYLLABUS: In the new film “Coyote vs. Acme,” based on a piece published in this magazine in 1990, Mr. Wile E. Coyote alleges that the Acme Corporation’s defective products, including rocket skates, dynamite, and a boulder catapult, caused him such injuries as severe burns, eye bulging, and dissection into three parts. His attorney is played by Will Forte. Levine considered recusal, on the ground that he kind of knows Forte’s father: “I’d go helicopter skiing up in British Columbia. We’d always stay at this lodge called the Monashees Lodge. To ski at the Monashees Lodge, you’ve got to be a pretty serious skier. And Reb Forte always stayed at the Monashees Lodge.” Recusal was declined.

SUBDECISION, ON THE FILM’S ARTISTIC MERITS: Levine held, “I was really conflicted about the coyote because he was likable and then he was not likable. At times, I could really relate to the coyote, and other times I thought he was just diabolical. Ultimately, I think the coyote was going after that roadrunner because it was just instinctually part of its chemistry. It couldn’t help itself, even though it was wrong.” Decision: not bad.

Talk of the Town

Fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond



ORAL ARGUMENTS: Acme could invoke the doctrine of foreseeable misuse. “There’s an argument that his use of the rocket shoes to chase a roadrunner was not foreseeable,” Levine said. On the other hand, he went on, “I think Acme knew the products were going to be used for nefarious purposes. They bear responsibility if they’re selling dynamite without knowing who the purchaser of that dynamite is. It wasn’t like the purchaser was a mining company. It was a goddam coyote.”

PRECEDENT: Are there any anvil-related *decisis* to *stare*? “Literally hundreds,” Levine said. “I’ll show you one.” He pulled up a video, in which a construction worker is standing on a steel beam, twenty feet off the ground, as another beam is hoisted via crane above his head. “My client is a union worker,” Levine said. “That I-beam, by the way? Sixteen thousand pounds.” Suddenly, something snaps, and the hoisted beam falls. It somehow misses the worker. But the crane fell on the beam he was standing on and knocked him to the ground. Levine shook his head. “People suffer,” he said. Rocket skates had precedent, too. “E-bikes,” he said.



*"Madeline plays strictly for her own amusement."
Cartoon by Edward Frascino*

PERSONAL BIASES CONSIDERED: Levine feels for the coyote. His line of work has taught him that danger lurks everywhere. "When I drive my car anywhere on Long Island, I'm, like, O.K., I sued that company over there, I sued that landscaper over there. That municipality? Sued them," he said. "I'll tell you a story. I'm driving to work seven years ago, in a really nice Porsche Turbo. I stop at a light. I wake up in the hospital four days later." A woman going sixty miles an hour rear-ended him and launched his car three hundred feet. "The police thought I was gonna die," he said. He had twelve broken bones and a bleed in his brain. His bowels were resected. He was back at work seventeen days later, without a spleen. "It's like an appendix," he said. "You can live without it."

JUDICIAL MUSINGS: "The attorney's advertising in the movie was really effective," Levine said. The key is to be short and memorable without being unserious. "It's really easy to remember 'Call Motorcycle Mike.' My firm advertised a little bit over the years, but if we advertise on TV as 'This is Rappaport, Glass, Levine & Zullo,' who the fuck's gonna remember that?" There are some exceptions, like Cellino & Barnes. "They had the jingle. And

Cellino & Barnes is a two-name firm, so it's not that hard to remember."

LEGAL ANALYSIS: "The coyote's got to have a theory of liability, and he's got to have severe injuries." The biggest question, jurisprudentially speaking, was whether the coyote's injuries warranted compensation. An incident that for others might be fatal—a free fall from a high bridge—affects the coyote for only a brief moment. "He is very resilient," Levine said. "He goes right back to his old habits. Maybe the damage was psychological, like P.T.S.D. But I think the jury's gonna say, Give me a break."

DECISION: "I don't believe you, coyote. You've got to have an injury. Otherwise, you're wasting my time." ♦

Zach Helfand is a staff writer at *The New Yorker*.

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/all-rise-coyote-court-is-now-in-session>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

[Dept. of Groove](#)

Jim Nollman's Orca-stra

The sound artist spent thirteen years playing guitar alongside singing whales in British Columbia. Now he's releasing their collaboration, on "Orcas' Greatest Hits."

By [Sarah Larson](#)

August 31, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

One evening in August, two hundred culture enthusiasts gathered on the rooftop of Nine Orchard, a hotel on the Lower East Side, to celebrate the release of the album "Orcas' Greatest Hits" and a rare New York appearance by its creator, the seventy-nine-year-old

sound artist Jim Nollman. “I’d also like to thank the orcas,” he said, after being lavishly introduced. Nollman is gray-haired and white-bearded, with a look of sharp-eyed affability, and he wore a lavender T-shirt illustrated with an orca-dominated seascape. On the album, he and collaborators jam alongside wild orcas, assisted by underwater microphones and thoughtfully positioned boats. Sharing the bill was David Rothenberg, a professor and a jazz musician who has improvised with collaborators including leafhoppers and humpback whales. The event was the penultimate this season in a series run by Nonhuman Teachers, a nonprofit offshoot of the beloved L.A. plant shop the Cactus Store. (“I did an event with them playing cactus music in California,” Rothenberg said.) The attendees were hip, all ages, and slightly giddy, ready to have whales blow their minds.

Earlier, Nollman, who lives in the San Juan Islands, in the Pacific Northwest, had admired the view—“I’ve never seen so many bridges from one room before”—and reflected on his career. He grew up in Massachusetts and attended Tufts, where, in a production of “A Midsummer Night’s Dream,” he disoriented the audience by making footstep sounds emanate from the ceiling. He studied Strindberg, Klee, and Cage, inspired by the idea of the trickster artist. In Chiapas, Mexico, he played a saxophone-shaped clay flute and got a neighbor’s turkey to gobble. Later, at a farm in the Bay Area, he recorded himself singing “Froggy Went a-Courtin,” with three hundred turkey sidemen. “I nailed it,” he said. The song became an underground hit, and he branched out: kangaroo rats, wolves (“pretty successful”), dolphins in Hawaii (“my first grant”). For the dolphins—“a challenge”—he bobbed in the ocean, playing a waterphone and a drum that he wrapped his legs around, making for a great photograph but a frustrating jam session. “I couldn’t hear them,” he said. “I think they could hear some of my drumming.” But people wanted more, and were willing to fund it. “Dolphins have a power that turkeys don’t,” he said. “So

I put together the world's first underwater recording studio, on a big boat."

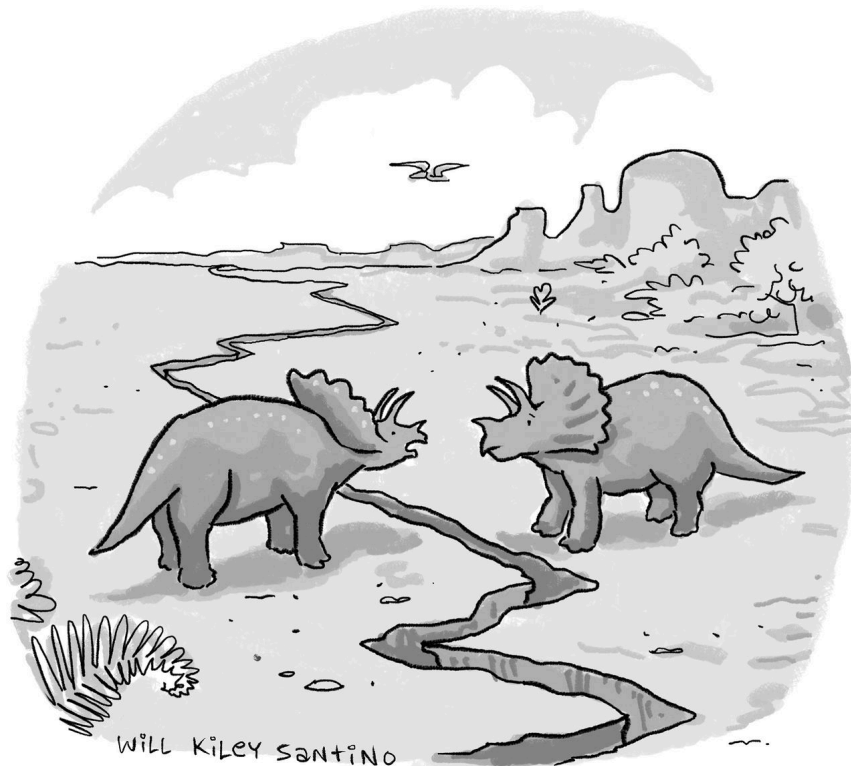
Talk of the Town

Fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond



This led to Nollman's life's work: music with orcas, in a place he called Orcananda. "We set it up in a little cove," he said. "We were extremely careful about not harassing them. If the whales wanted to interact, they had to come to us." He played electric guitar, and curious orcas approached. "We didn't hit Record until the orcas started singing," Nollman said. He kept the duets call-and-response, and invited "anybody with a good idea" to join—an old man chanting the Kaddish, three Tibetan lamas, "a whole family from Australia," a classical musician with a synthesizer. "I discovered early on that the orcas didn't care about human virtuosity," he said. "What they were interested in was a groove. They're interested in strong rhythms." Syncopation can inspire humans and whales alike. He continued, "One night, I started playing a James Brown riff, this 'diddle-iddle-it.' We somehow got the whales to dance with us and to be in the band, and they stayed for a long time." Another favorite is "The 47 Whale Raga," in which Nollman improvises around the song "Jhinjhoti" amid a super-pod of forty-seven orcas. "The beauty of a raga for this is that it's like a conversation," he said. "The drone is always there." In another song, "I made a kind of twelve-bar blues, and I got the

whale to make the chord change. You're on the one, and then you go up to the four on the fifth bar. The orca made that with me and then went back to the one again. I didn't expect that. I was just out there trying things, you know?"



"This will never work. We live on different continents."
Cartoon by Will Kiley Santino

Nollman made orca music for thirteen years, collecting some sixty hours of tape, which sat on a shelf until a recent connection with Smithsonian Folkways. He's glad to have "Orcas" out in the world. "Being the whale musician was a charmed life," he said.

At the event, before Rothenberg triumphantly clarinet-riffed with recordings of sperm whales and humpbacks, Joe Valle, of Nonhuman Teachers, interviewed Nollman, with career-retrospective audiovisual enhancement. Turkeys, kangaroo rats, dolphins, and, finally, the showstopper: a toothy, looming orca photo, an excellent guitar groove, and shrieky, exuberant whale song, lead vocals like helium squeaking out of a balloon. Outside, a fire-truck siren joined in. ♦

Sarah Larson, a staff writer, has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2007.

Postscript

Dolly Parton for the People

She was commonly called the Queen of Country Music, but that is exactly wrong: she was democratic to her bones.

By [Kathryn Schulz](#)

August 26, 2026



*Dolly Parton, April 1994.
Photograph by Timothy White / AUGUST*

Four score and three thousand songs ago, in the middle of a whopping winter storm, a sharecropper and his young wife brought forth upon this continent a baby girl named Dolly Parton. If you know the rest of this story, you know that it never gets old. Her parents, Avie Lee and Robert Lee Parton, had married at the respective ages of fifteen and seventeen. Dolly was the fourth of their twelve children, born in a one-room cabin on the banks of the Little Pigeon River, in Sevier County, Tennessee, and also born into the kind of poverty that meant the doctor who delivered her got paid with a sack of cornmeal and the kids wore the elastic from old underwear as hairbands. At six, she started singing in the church where her grandfather was the preacher. At seven, she began

playing a homemade guitar—later, also a jerry-rigged mandolin, constructed from the guts of an old piano she'd found in an abandoned chapel in the woods. By ten, she had landed a gig on the local radio station. Three years later, Johnny Cash strode onstage at the Grand Ole Opry and told the Saturday-night crowd, "We've got a little girl here from up in East Tennessee."

It was among the last introductions Dolly Parton would ever need. In the course of her long career, which was almost completely coextensive with her long but not long enough life, she produced some fifty studio albums, sold north of a hundred million records, won ten Country Music Association Awards and eleven Grammys, and got inducted into the Country Music Hall of Fame, the Gospel Music Hall of Fame, the Rock and Roll Hall of Fame, and the Songwriters Hall of Fame. If there were a Fame Hall of Fame, she would be in that, too.

Dismayingly, for those of us who are perpetually stuck on item three of our to-do list, all that barely begins to describe how Dolly Parton spent her days. She also starred in several movies, at least three of which are good; wrote or co-wrote a handful of memoirs, several children's books, a few cookbooks, and one novel; and created a sprawling business empire that made her into not only the most famous export of Sevier County but also its largest employer. To honor her father, who never learned to read, she started a charity, the Imagination Library, that sends a free book every month to roughly one in seven preschool-age American children. That would have been plenty; richer people usually do far less. But, when her home county was devastated by wildfires in 2016, she sent a thousand dollars a month for six months to every family that had lost a home, and, when the coronavirus came around four years later, she donated a million dollars to help fund the development of a vaccine. As her fellow country-music stars Montgomery Gentry once sang, that's a life you can hang your hat on.

Still, for all this, songs were always the heart of it. Dolly never learned to read music, but she could play just about anything with strings, plus the recorder, the harmonica, the saxophone, and even her own fingernails, permanently recorded in all their ninety-words-a-minute acrylic glory in those driving opening measures of “9 to 5,” that national anthem for the nation of women. She always said that she didn’t have the greatest voice, and, since the competition included Patsy Cline, Wynonna Judd, and Reba McEntire, that was true; nonetheless, hers was somehow the most distinctive in the business. It was a little trembly, a little breathy, good at all the girly stuff, but with a girder of light-gauge steel beneath it, like you’d slink away real embarrassed if you tried to mess with her. She was a dead-center soprano, but her emotional range was ample: she could purr, she could plead, she could growl, she could yodel, she could croon. She could even sort of belt, although a little daintily; compared with Whitney Houston’s “I Will Always Love You,” Dolly’s version sounds as delicate and sweet as Queen Anne’s lace.



Photograph from Bettmann / Getty

As for what she sang about: pretty much everything, at one point or another, but mostly hope, home, hardscrabble happiness, and the irresistible but absolutely exasperating nature of all men excepting Jesus. She sang true country-girl songs, where fishing poles rhymed with fishing holes; and seventies disco-pop, where the band *bwaaaaa-chicka-bwaa*-ed behind her vocals; and soaring gospel songs and boot-stomping bar tunes and even, pretty creditably, “Purple Rain.” She sang the world’s most joyful heartbreak song (“Why’d You Come in Here Looking Like That”) and the world’s most upbeat lament for a vanishing way of life

(“Applejack”) and the only Christmas song this Jew can tolerate come the December deluge of drummer boys: the achingly lovely “Hard Candy Christmas.” This is to say nothing of the aforementioned “I Will Always Love You,” in which, with meta magnificence, she turned her best career decision—splitting with Porter Wagoner, the collaborator who helped launch her to fame—into one of the world’s most enduring love songs. I hope and trust that about a billion people listened to it yesterday.

Even more than she was a singer, Dolly Parton was a performer, and her longest-running show was herself. Right around age twelve, she became, as Johnny Carson understated in a 1977 interview, “rather zaftig.” Presented by the culture with many mediocre options for how to handle her particular combination of looks, ambition, and gender, she chose one that was not on the menu, stepping into every insult that could possibly be used against a woman like her—dumb blonde, bimbo, trailer trash, whore—and tailoring them perfectly to her 40-20-36 frame. It was impossible to make her the butt of a joke, because she was always in on it, and her own quips were almost as famous as her songs: “It costs a lot of money to look this cheap”; “I’m not offended by dumb-blonde jokes, because I know I’m not dumb. I also know I’m not blond.”

All this was canned, of course, produced like a dazzling smile whenever the world demanded it. She knew both who she was and who she needed to be, and she played it all to a T, part Betty Boop, part Annie Oakley, part Abraham Lincoln. Those closest to her, including [Carl Dean, her husband of nearly sixty years](#), presumably knew some other Dolly, less rehearsed and likely deeper. The rest of us just got the surface, but who could feel cheated? The surface of Dolly was the point, like the surface of diamonds. I don’t just mean her physical self-presentation—the wigs, the clothes, the precarious heels and plunging necklines—although all of that was fabulous; in her prime, she could have made the head of Tiffany buy rhinestones. (She could also make other people want to try on her style: she once entered a Dolly Parton look-alike contest on the

sly and lost, to a man.) I mean that she understood, with canny acuity, that what she was selling was authenticity—that's what all country music is selling—but that the best way to sell it was through artifice. We are talking about a woman who purchased and then walled off her childhood home while simultaneously creating a fake version for the public to visit.

So, too, with herself. Dolly revealed everything, told anyone who asked about the wigs, the eyelashes, the boobs, the boob jobs. She had no shame and nothing to be ashamed of. She never tried to pass off everything ersatz about herself as the genuine article, which had the curious effect of making her seem entirely sincere. It helped that she embodied our national ideal of authenticity, from the one-room cabin on up to the self-made fortune; whatever phantasmagorical thing a Real American might be, there has never been one realer. The self she showed off was utterly armored and utterly disarming—and, boy, did the world go for it. I have never encountered anyone, of any age, race, class, gender, or taste in music, who didn't at a minimum admire and more often adore her—her songs, her movies, her moxie, her morals, which seemed so loose yet proved so deep and durable. She was commonly called the Queen of Country Music, but that is exactly wrong: she was democratic to her bones, of the people and by the people and for the people, the duly elected President of the United States of Americans.

Dolly always said that she wanted to die onstage, mid-song, but in the end she did herself one better. Her last public appearance was at the end of June, for the grand opening of a Tennessee truck stop newly named in her honor. Of all the musicians in the world—of all the *people* in the world—only Dolly could make that seem like the perfect way to bow out of the game. When I heard the news yesterday afternoon, I thought about a song she released at seventy, called “I’m Sixteen,” which isn’t about being that age but about feeling that age. It’s a classic Dolly number in that it brings to mind that gooey New York City street fare, the mozzarella: it is corny,

cheesy, delicious. Midway through, she sings, “It goes to show you’re never old unless you choose to be.” I believe it, or anyway I believe she believed it. In that sense, I am happy to report, the great Dolly Parton died young. ♦

Kathryn Schulz, a staff writer at The New Yorker covering books, science, and culture, won the 2016 Pulitzer Prize for feature writing. She is the author of “[Lost & Found](#).”

<https://www.newyorker.com/culture/postscript/dolly-parton-for-the-people>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

Reporting & Essays

- **[The Art of Leaping Out of Planes to Fight Wildfires](#)**

By M. R. O'Connor | Since the nineteen-forties, smokejumpers have been parachuting into remote parts of the U.S. to contain dangerous blazes.

- **[Susan Te Kahurangi King's Way of Seeing](#)**

By Laura Preston | At seventy-five, she may be New Zealand's greatest living artist.

- **[Anatomy of a Siege](#)**

By Emily Witt | Living through Operation Metro Surge, and what came after.

- **[The MAHA Custody Battle](#)**

By Ruby Cramer | A father wanted to vaccinate his children. Their mother didn't. Then the kids got sick.

[The Control of Nature](#)

The Art of Leaping Out of Planes to Fight Wildfires

Since the nineteen-forties, smokejumpers have been parachuting into remote parts of the U.S. to contain dangerous blazes.

By [M. R. O'Connor](#)

August 31, 2026

Smokejumpers are trained to count to five before deploying their parachutes.

Video by Andrew Gavin

During summer in parts of Alaska, the sun shines for more than two months straight. The endless days are punctuated by the appearance of gigantic thunderheads that, many afternoons, seem to boil up into the sky. They often bring torrents of rain and bolts of lightning that ignite fires. Fort Wainwright, a U.S. Army facility in Fairbanks, Alaska, houses about two hundred federal wildland firefighters. Roughly seventy-five of them, stationed at a group of unassuming buildings near an airstrip, are known as smokejumpers—firefighters who leap out of airplanes, parachute to the ground, and work to contain blazes in some of the most difficult and remote terrain in the country. Smokejumpers work from nine bases in the Western U.S.; they may fight a fire for a day or for several weeks. When a job is done, they often bushwhack to the nearest road or helicopter landing spot.

In June, on the eve of the summer solstice, there were thirty-four people on the “jump list,” which sets the order in which smokejumpers hustle onto outgoing flights. Their names were written on a whiteboard in “the box”—a central area of desks, computers, and maps that serves as the operational headquarters of the Alaska Smokejumper Base—along with runic notations indicating their roles and qualifications. Much of Alaska’s interior

was under a red-flag warning because of high temperatures, dry fuels, and strong winds. Everyone wondered when the “bust,” an explosion of lightning and new ignitions, would arrive. Jesse Olstead, a twenty-nine-year-old with shaggy brown hair, kept stopping by the box to check the jump list. He was No. 18 in line.

Olstead, who grew up in a logging community in Washington State, described smokejumping as “the best-kept secret I’ve ever seen.” He took a job as a firefighter during the summers when he was in college, and he eventually joined the Chena Hotshots, an élite firefighting crew at Fort Wainwright. When some of his friends became smokejumpers, he was intrigued. Smokejumper openings often attract hundreds of applications from experienced firefighters. Olstead submitted one, and he was selected to begin training in the spring of 2024.

In Alaska, it takes rookie smokejumpers five to six weeks to prepare for fire season. Roughly a third of them wash out. On Day One, rookies are given sixty-five minutes to hike three miles while carrying a pack that weighs a hundred and ten pounds. Other bases are said to make rookies run long distances across challenging terrain, or to spend sixteen hours digging firebreaks. “We put you in a bottle and shake you up and see if you’re going to perform,” Evan Burgess, a jumper in his sixth year, told me. Mimi Scissons, who rookied in the eighties, said that she washed out during a three-mile hike with a ninety-pound pack. “I totally broke down mentally,” she told me. She went through a period of heavy drinking before getting sober, trying again, and finally spending twelve seasons as the first Native American woman smokejumper. In some ways, the process echoes what an Army recruit would go through in boot camp. “Making it through that and not having an M16 on your shoulder is pretty sweet,” Nick Biedscheid, who trains rookies in Alaska, said.

Rookies ultimately have to master such challenges as flight dynamics, parachute malfunctions, and landing in dangerous

conditions. They complete at least twenty practice jumps of increasing difficulty; the last one requires landing in a half-acre zone surrounded by woods. A rookie who completes training is “beyond reproach,” Wally Wasser, who is known as the all-time Jump King because he parachuted to an unsurpassed three hundred and ninety-five fires, told me. “You would never, ever not trust that person.”

While Alaska’s smokejumpers waited for thunderheads to ignite fires, several of them worked in the loft, an airy room crammed with sewing machines and bolts of fabric on long tables. One was patching a parachute. Others were sewing gear out of black nylon. Outside, on the tarmac, jumpers drove forklifts loaded with cargo—firefighting tools, fuel, provisions—to waiting airplanes. In the box, jumpers gazed up at several large monitors that displayed maps and live weather updates. By 2:16 *P.M.*, lightning had struck more than seven hundred times. Yet the siren that calls smokejumpers to a fire, triggered by a small black button on the wall, had not yet gone off. (The button was decorated with the cover of the Chemical Brothers’ album “Push the Button.”)

When the siren sounds, the jumpers at the top of the list have two minutes to get their gear and start loading onto a “jumpship.” Smokejumpers can reach anywhere in mainland Alaska in less than two hours. Waiting for the siren, Burgess told me, is like a “slow adrenaline drip.” By 3:13 *p.m.*, another five hundred and sixty-four bolts of lightning had struck Alaska, but there was still no siren. Two jumpers were bent over a chessboard. Outside, a pilot sat near a plane, reading a copy of “War and Peace.” A barely perceptible tension built. By 4:41 *p.m.*, the number of lightning strikes across the state had surpassed two thousand, yet the button remained untouched. “All right, we should do it,” Keaton Shepherd, a tall smokejumper with reddish hair and a beard, suddenly said. “We need to make the sacrifice.”

Many smokejumpers worship a god they call Big Ernie. He is a kind of jolly Odin for whom the cardinal sins are entitlement, whining, and bragging. Big Ernie is said to maintain the modesty of his flock by squashing notions of grandiosity; he alone decides who gets a good fire, a bad fire, or no fire at all. The smokejumpers hatched a plan to appeal to Big Ernie's perverse sense of humor. "If you're ready, nothing happens, but if you're unprepared, you're definitely going out," Shepherd said. "Somebody go into a pack and randomly take something out."

Finally, at 7:19 *P.M.*, a ticker displayed a message: "*FIRE 232 REQUESTING JUMPERS.*" The jumper who was supervising the box that day, Joey Cowen, confirmed the request. Then another jumper walked over to the wall and pushed the button.

The siren let out a deafening wail, and eight jumpers sprinted to nearby racks of gear. They zipped up Kevlar suits and strapped on knee and shin guards. They dipped their arms through parachute harnesses and, laden with a hundred pounds each, rushed through a bay door. Firefighters who weren't yet being deployed lined the route to the tarmac, hooting and clapping and giving high fives. The jumpers climbed into the belly of a maroon-and-white jumpship as its propellers began to whir and then roar.

Back in the box, Cowen stood in front of the whiteboard and updated the jump list. Big Ernie had apparently been pleased. Shepherd had risen from No. 14 to No. 6.

"Did you take something out of your pack?" Cowen asked Shepherd.

"I did," Shepherd said. "A tent."

Cowen grinned. "That's why we're going!"

Twenty minutes later, the siren wailed again. A lightning fire had broken out near an elementary school in a small town north of Denali National Park. Olstead ran to his cubby, put on his jumpsuit and harness, and hurried across the tarmac to the waiting jumpship. The bust was here.

The history of American smokejumping began with a dare. In 1939, a crew assembled near Winthrop, Washington, to conduct what was described as the smokejumping experiment. The Soviets had begun parachuting to fires in the mid-thirties, but U.S. officials initially rejected the approach as too risky. “All parachute jumpers are more or less crazy,” Evan Kelley, a regional forester, wrote. “Otherwise they wouldn’t be engaged in such a hazardous undertaking.” The first jumps resulted in wrenched backs and injured knees. But the crew came up with solutions. After a parachutist in a leather aviator hat scraped his face bloody, they sent jumpers up in catcher’s masks and football helmets. When someone got caught in a tree, they trained jumpers how to get down with ropes.

Francis Lufkin, whose job was to climb into trees and retrieve parachutes, had been forbidden to jump out of planes by his wife. He had never even been in a plane at the time. But his fellow crew members challenged him to leap out of a Stinson, an aircraft with a propeller on its nose, so he suited up. When he got home, his wife knew what he had done by the funny smile on his face.

Lufkin went on to become the manager of the North Cascades Smokejumper Base, one of the country’s first, and stayed for decades. Back then, crews were made up of young Quakers and Mennonites who refused military service. “I didn’t believe in killing,” Elmer Neufeld, a conscientious objector from Kansas who worked under Lufkin, once recalled. “Now we got a job, not only can we do it, but it’s fun. . . . It’s a lot of hard work, so what?” Rookies often pretended to be older than they were. “I kind of fudged on my age, and it haunted me until my retirement,” Bill

Moody, who began fighting fires in 1956, when he was seventeen, told me.

Smokejumping fascinated the American public. In 1949, a TV broadcast showed four handsome jumpers parachuting onto the Ellipse in Washington, D.C. Jumpers starred in adventure books and inspired a G.I. Joe set that featured a tiny chainsaw. The job was obviously dangerous: jumpers impaled themselves on trees, cut themselves with tools, and broke their legs, ankles, and shoulders. (Just last year, one smokejumper fractured both feet in a hard landing, another fractured both legs, and a third broke a leg.) Thirty-two smokejumpers have died in the line of duty. Twelve of them, plus one former jumper, lost their lives in 1949 when the Mann Gulch Fire, in Montana, overran them. A film inspired by the tragedy, “Red Skies of Montana,” was made in the fifties, and the production built a seven-acre forest in Los Angeles at a cost of a quarter of a million dollars. It was set on fire for the cameras.



“Rumor is, he’s had ‘Baby Beluga’ stuck in his head for the past thirty-one years.”
Cartoon by Liana Finck

Gary Welch saw “Red Skies of Montana” as a teen-ager in Texas, where he worked as an oil-field roughneck. He and his two brothers all became smokejumpers. Welch broke his back during his second season, yet he returned to jump again the next year. He eventually became a banker, while his brothers chose careers as schoolteachers so that they could keep jumping every summer. “All of us always agree that it was the best job we ever had,” Welch once said.

The first woman to try to become a jumper, Deanne Shulman, passed the physical test in 1979. Nonetheless, she was disqualified because she weighed too little. She sought advice from Allen (Mouse) Owen, a legendary four-foot-eleven smokejumper who had previously got congressional waivers to fight as a marine in the Vietnam War. In 1981, after filing an Equal Employment Opportunity complaint, Shulman became a jumper. Owen sent her a congratulatory letter. Five days later, he died in a skydiving accident.

Since the start of the experiment, eighty-seven years ago, there have been about six thousand American smokejumpers. They have gone on to become priests, farmers, cowboys, coaches, painters, philosophy professors, nuclear engineers, Shakespeare scholars, Olympians, and diplomats. One member of the Alabama National Guard who escorted Martin Luther King, Jr., from Selma to Montgomery was a smokejumper. So was one of the first people to summit Mt. Everest via the treacherous West Ridge. A smokejumper helped draft the 1964 Wilderness Act. Another piloted the Apollo 14 mission to the moon. At least eight smokejumpers were suspected by the F.B.I. of being the infamous hijacker D. B. Cooper, who collected a ransom of two hundred thousand dollars and then parachuted out of a Boeing 727, never to be found. A remarkable number of these individuals share Gary Welch’s opinion that it was the best job they ever had.

The jumpship carrying Olstead taxied to the runway and took off into a sky filled with mammoth gray thunderheads. He and eleven other jumpers were squeezed together on canvas benches. The plane, a Dash 8 turboprop, was small enough that their boots were touching the cargo on board: several thousand pounds of chainsaws, hoses, pumps, rations, and other equipment, including a satellite phone and a trauma kit. After they jumped, the cargo would be “kicked”—parachuted down to the fire—so that the crew could be self-sufficient for days. On the way to the fire, some jumpers rested with their eyes closed. Olstead gazed out a window until he saw an impressive column of gray smoke. A door at the back of the plane was opened, and the combination of wind and engine noise made talking difficult. The jumpship circled the fire while the spotter—a smokejumper who oversees the mission from the air—leaned out the door to assess it. Lightning had struck between the town and the Clear Space Force Station, a radar installation that detects ballistic missiles. The fire already stretched across a hundred acres in a forest of black spruce and hardwoods.

Smokejumpers parachute out of planes in “sticks” that usually consist of two people. Each stick conducted a twenty-nine-step “buddy check,” inspecting harnesses and chutes. The spotter dropped three crêpe-paper streamers to estimate the wind drift. Finally, he signalled that it was time for the jumpers to come to the door. Three sticks leaped out in quick succession. Olstead and his partner were up next.

“Ready?” the spotter shouted. “Leg straps tight?” He told the pair to hook a cable called a static line to their drogues—miniature parachutes that slow and stabilize one’s fall before the main chute opens, preventing jumpers from somersaulting through the air or falling head first. The spotter yelled, “Any questions?” There were none. “We are on final. Get in the door.”

Olstead’s partner sat on the edge. The spotter stretched himself out of the door as far as he could, confirmed their proximity to the

jump spot, and told them to get ready. Then he slapped Olstead's partner on his right arm. The jumper flung himself out the door, hands on his lower back and knees bent in a crouched position. Olstead, close behind, dropped himself onto the edge. For a split second, he faced forward, into the sun. Then he leaped.

Olstead quickly accelerated to ninety miles per hour. He felt rain on his face and began to recite a five-second count. "Jump thousand!" He could see the tributaries of a river glinting gold down below. "Look thousand!" Above him, he could see the plane flying out of view. "Reach thousand!" With his right hand, he felt for the handle on his chest. "Wait thousand!" In the distance, his partner's parachute opened. "Pull thousand!"

Olstead yanked the handle to release his parachute and watched the red-white-and-blue fabric unfurl. The world went quiet and the raindrops stopped. Now he was floating between Heaven and earth. He reached overhead, pulled one of his parachute's steering toggles, and turned himself toward the column of smoke.

To the north of the fire, between a forest and a small dirt road, Olstead spied a green field—the jump spot. He could see the bright parachutes of jumpers who had already landed there. He arced to the right, facing into the wind as he approached. He tugged on the toggles to slow himself down. The ground rushed toward him; he bent his knees and let the balls of his feet hit first, falling forward in a fluid motion to distribute the shock across his body.

"Jumper O.K.!" he shouted.

His fellow-jumpers were already taking off their Kevlar suits and stuffing chutes into bags. The crew leader, the first person to parachute out of the jumpship, announced the plan: "We're going to take the right flank." The crew dispersed into the forest.

Most wildland firefighting crews work in strict hierarchical command structures. Smokejumpers, in contrast, are trained to be self-reliant and independent. Jim Veitch, a smokejumper who rookied in 1967, wrote that he once saw a “regimented hotshot crew” watching “in disgust as a milling mob of jumpers ambled off in seeming disorganization.” The smokejumpers’ strategy is to adopt whatever technique allows them to contain a fire as fast as possible. One jumper is famous for having smothered miles of flames with his jacket; in Alaska, jumpers have used spruce boughs and burlap bags filled with moss. “No one is telling you what to do or when to hike,” a second-year jumper—a “snookie”—said. “It’s like going from the military to a farm commune. The amount of structure is the opposite.”

Olstead has six different firefighter qualifications—he can lead wildfire crews, tourniquet a wound, and participate in helicopter missions, for instance—but today he cut line, a fundamental firefighting tactic that creates a gap in vegetation to stop a fire’s spread. The crew worked for five hours as flames punched up from nearby trees. Under the light of the midnight sun, Olstead and a partner used a chainsaw to remove brush. Helicopters arrived with water, and the jumpers directed the pilots via radio.

At 2 A.M., Olstead joined forces with a bulldozer that had been driven out to the site. Just beyond the flames, he hiked through thick forest, marking a trail that the dozer could follow. The machine uprooted trees in its path as though they were twigs, leaving behind a swath of earth that was bare all the way down to the permafrost.

By 3:30 A.M., the flames and smoke had mellowed in the wan light of morning. Two jumpers went scouting for a camping spot. The others soon joined them, set up tents, and slept for a few hours. At 7 A.M., the crew was up again, drinking coffee around a campfire. For the rest of the day, as planes and helicopters dropped water, Olstead worked the fire line with the dozer while others put out

spot fires with pumps and hoses. Several hotshot crews arrived and took over; vehicles came to pick up the smokejumpers. By evening, they were back at the base, on the jump list again.

My guide on the Alaska Smokejumper Base was Rod Dow, a seventy-eight-year-old retired smokejumper who once held the record for jumps onto fires. Dow, who has a white mustache and a baritone voice, rookied at the McCall Smokejumper Base, in Idaho, but spent most of his thirty-two-year career in Alaska. Federal officials had approved my visit after he'd agreed to accompany me. Dow had a knack for finding ways to get back to his former base. In 2019, when Alaska's fire season burned two and a half million acres, he volunteered for weeks of wrapping and strapping cargo; the base ultimately kicked eight hundred thousand pounds of supplies for wildfires.

While I was there, he again spent hours on the tarmac in front of thousand-pound loads of canvas-wrapped gear. A rotation of bluegrass, surf rock, and rap played over outdoor speakers. Dow stood with three tattooed and shirtless jumpers, weaving white paracord through hooks in the canvas and cinching it tight. The Alaska Smokejumper Base is said to be the largest civilian "paracargo" operation in the world. Only the U.S. and Russian militaries deliver more cargo by parachute. "We're like the FedEx for wildland fire," Robert Ordonez, a smokejumper of fourteen years and a paracargo specialist, told me. "Four-wheelers, boats, you name it—we'll figure out a way to put it on a pallet, same-day delivery."

Smokejumpers know so much about dropping people and things out of airplanes that the C.I.A. recruited them for operations such as the Bay of Pigs invasion, in Cuba, and the training of nationalist paratroopers in Taiwan. Starting in the nineteen-fifties, the C.I.A. covertly owned an airline, Air America, which supplied and supported the U.S. military in Asia. Smokejumpers kicked cargo destined for mountain villages in Vietnam, Hmong rebels in Laos,

and Muslim dissidents in China. (Back then, the joke was that if a smokejumper told you how he'd spent the off-season, he'd have to kill you.) In 1959, the Dalai Lama fled Tibet through the Himalayas; a smokejumper designed a special high-altitude parachute to drop three hundred thousand Indian rupees to his escape party. Johnny Kirkley, an ex-smokejumper, told me that he joined Air America in 1965. "We got hired to do that job because of what we did on fires," he said. "In smokejumping, you have to be spontaneous, and in war you gotta be the same way." Among the items that Kirkley transported in Southeast Asia were munitions, bags of rice, and live potbellied pigs wrapped in burlap bags. At least eight smokejumpers recruited by the C.I.A. were ultimately killed in action. One was taken as a prisoner of war in Laos and went missing while trying to escape.

When Dow arrived at the Alaska Smokejumper Base, in 1975, sixty-five men worked out of an airplane hangar that had been abandoned after the Second World War. It had no heat, no running water, and a single porta-potty. Murry Taylor, who jumped for twenty-seven seasons, many of them with Dow, compared the recruits to wild horses. "The rebels, they came to Alaska," he said. "It was guys from Vietnam and guys who couldn't fit with the authoritarian, do-what-you're-told deal in the Lower Forty-eight." The base became an unexpected source of innovation. Early on, the government issued wildland firefighters fire-resistant pants that were pocketless and uncomfortable. Alaska's jumpers took a vote and decided to strike. "We were the last people in the nation that were not wearing them," Dow told me. "We just had a meeting on the lawn and decided we're not getting on the plane. It fucking floored our boss." By the following year, the government was issuing improved fire pants with pockets, and they are still worn by wildland firefighters today. Dow and his crewmates were also the first smokejumpers to experiment with square-canopied parachutes, which increased maneuverability. They tested them by launching themselves into the air from carts pulled by speeding pickup trucks.

They sent their findings to Washington, D.C., and square chutes were eventually adopted by smokejumpers across the nation. “They assumed a lot of risk in pioneering that,” Burgess, the sixth-year jumper, told me. “It was some cowboy inventing.”

Burgess is a supervisor in the loft, where jumpers hunch over tables as they cut fabric. He taught himself how to use the software AutoCAD so that he could create his own patterns instead of outsourcing them. “It’s a very specific thing that we do,” he said. “That’s why we build all of it, down to our gear bags.” He showed me technical drawings and multi-page sewing patterns for parachute-deployment bags, harnesses, and jumpsuits. The patterns included detailed specifications for thread tension and stitches per inch. Hannah Kligman, who last year became the sixth woman to rookie in Alaska, described the way that smokejumpers approach communal tasks: “What needs to get done? What did I get trained in doing? Where can I fit in?” She called the rhythm of daily work monastic.

Dow watched as Nick Hampe, a jumper working in the loft, stretched a billowy, three-hundred-and-seventy-five-square-foot parachute onto a table, and began folding it. Rookies learn to pack parachutes by doing it twenty times, and having each one inspected. They jump with their twenty-first, which is jokingly called the death chute. Some smokejumpers eventually become senior or master riggers, certifications issued by the Federal Aviation Administration. (Togie Wiehl, an Alaska Native jumper who retired from the profession after twenty-nine years, told me that he read a master-rigger handbook so religiously that he grew self-conscious; he disguised it by taping a *Playboy* magazine cover over it.)

Hampe executed the sixty-one-step process of packing the chute from memory. At times, he got onto the table, using his arms and legs to muscle the silky fabric into intricate, origami-like folds. After an hour of work, he slipped it into a bag that measured

thirteen by fourteen inches. Once a jumper pulled the handle, the parachute would blossom like a flower. “Gorgeous,” Dow said. Hampe logged the chute in a database and deposited it on a shelf with dozens of others. “They’re all good chutes,” Hampe said. “I’ll jump with any of them.”

Dow told me that he kept travelling to Alaska to see if the “jumper attitude” lived on. Decades ago, he and some crew members had removed a fence, ferried in thirty truckloads of soil, and created a garden. To this day, smokejumpers grow asparagus, kale, cabbage, and potatoes there. They also continue to ride skateboards across the tarmac. And they decide almost everything via coin flip, including who will buy the day’s ice cream and who will wear a silly robe to the showers all season. In the seventies, Dow inaugurated an annual coin-tossing contest called the Big Flip; last year, a smokejumper won more than twenty thousand dollars. The sight of a thunderhead could still make Dow misty-eyed. “If they gave me an opportunity to go jump a fire right now, I would do it,” he told me.

It is not a given that smokejumping will continue to exist in the decades to come. America’s roadless areas, which jumpers specialize in reaching quickly, have been shrinking since 1939. Firefighters can access more places with trucks, or with helicopters that allow them to rappel rather than parachute onto difficult terrain. Meanwhile, as a result of warming temperatures and historic accumulations of trees and brush, wildfires have grown larger, more complex, and more unpredictable—requiring hundreds and sometimes thousands of firefighters. Increasingly, the wildfires that most urgently need suppressing ignite in the interfaces between rural and urban areas, places smokejumpers were not originally intended to go. Some smokejumpers believe that they are being sent to fewer fires than before, and fear that their profession could go extinct.

Already, they are in a period of tremendous change. For decades, jumpers in Alaska and Boise, Idaho, were employees of the Bureau of Land Management. Recently, however, they became employees of a new U.S. Wildland Fire Service created by the Trump Administration. Jumpers at the country's other seven bases work for the U.S. Forest Service; a feasibility study is under way to see if U.S.F.S. firefighters can also be moved into the new agency. It was rumored that smokejumpers might even become a test case for the consolidation, prompting speculation about shrinking budgets and potential base closures.



"I didn't mind the wait—this is what I do at home."

Cartoon by Nathan Cooper

In 2025, when the Department of Government Efficiency—*DOGE*—began identifying thousands of federal employees for cuts, it targeted numerous "forestry technicians," a broad category that included fire lookouts, fire-behavior specialists, and smokejumpers. One day, the Bureau of Land Management, which is part of the Department of the Interior, received a list of names from *DOGE* that included multiple Alaska smokejumpers. The B.L.M.'s fire leadership pointed out that any cuts were supposed to spare public-safety workers. The smokejumpers ultimately kept their jobs, but the episode incensed the Alaska crew. ("Smokejumpers are an integral part of the Department of the Interior's wildland firefighting organization," a spokesperson for the department said.

“The wildland fire workforce was exempt from recent downsizing efforts.”)

At the time, Sam Forstag, a fourth-year jumper, was the vice-president of a union representing eight hundred Forest Service workers in Montana. *DOGE* instructed the agency to fire about three hundred and sixty Forest Service employees in the state, including forestry technicians—cuts that Forstag considered senseless. Forestry technicians often work part time as firefighters; some make sure that smokejumpers get picked up after a long firefight. “They’re firing the lowest-paid, most efficient workers that we have in the federal government,” Forstag told me. Most smokejumpers start out earning about twenty-five dollars an hour, or thirty-eight dollars an hour for overtime. In April, 2025, Forstag criticized the cuts at a rally organized by Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez and Senator Bernie Sanders. Afterward, the office of the Secretary of Agriculture, which oversees the Forest Service, reportedly tried to have him fired. Forstag kept his job and jumped for another season, but he felt depressed and infuriated. “I remember thinking, We can’t let them get away with this,” he told me.

In January, at a dive bar in downtown Missoula, Forstag launched a House campaign for Montana’s First Congressional District. His initial campaign ad started with the sound of a siren. “When that siren goes off, you go,” he narrates. “Off to some wildfire ripping through a chunk of forest you’ve never seen. When you get there, you jump. Right now, the richest people in this country are trying to burn it all down so they can buy it all up.”

Smokejumpers are a politically diverse community. “If you’re a good smokejumper, you’re a good smokejumper,” Dan Helterline, a retired jumper in Montana and a staunch conservative, told me. “Doesn’t matter what your political views are.” Forstag is running as a Democrat, on a platform of economic populism and anti-corruption, but he touts endorsements from several Republican

legislators in Montana. He donated to four Republican campaigns in the recent past, and he argued that a liberal obsession with “processes and committees” was “part of why people have started to lose faith that government can actually do big things.”

Until recently, Forstag and five campaign staffers worked from his thousand-square-foot house. Conor Hogan, a smokejumper and Forstag’s best friend, took the summer off to work on the campaign, helping organize events and scouting a tree for Forstag to cut down, for a political ad. Because Forstag’s house is close to the Missoula airport, where local smokejumpers are based, they frequently heard jumpships taking off, carrying their fellow-firefighters. “We’re missing it a lot,” Hogan told me.

Hogan, who spends the off-season as a graduate student in fiction writing at the University of Houston, seemed to view smokejumping not only as a profession but as a world view. He has written that the establishment of America’s national forests was a triumph of conservation over corruption, of working-class values over corporate greed. He believes that smokejumpers and the land-management agencies they work for should not be seen as anachronisms but as models for public service. “What if we created a modern G.I. Bill, but instead of fighting overseas, young men and women were financially and socially incentivized to work on a fire crew, fuels crew, or trails crew?,” Hogan wrote in the trade magazine of the National Smokejumper Association. Some could be trained to conduct prescribed burns, which thin out accumulating fuel. “What might our society look like, decades down the line, if entire generations had spent three or four summers working in the woods?”

In “Young Men and Fire,” a nonfiction account of the 1949 Mann Gulch Fire, Norman Maclean describes smokejumpers as people who “love the universe but are not intimidated by it.” Maclean, who worked as a wildland firefighter as a teen-ager and considered becoming a smokejumper himself, said that his subjects possessed

an “it” inside them. “This ‘it’ is the something special within that demands we do something special,” he wrote. “ ‘It’ could be within a lot of us.” All smokejumpers have a way of explaining what compels them. Mike McMillan, who jumped in Alaska for seventeen years, laughingly described smokejumpers as “benevolent narcissists.” Sandy Ahlstrom Romero, the first woman to go through rookie training in Alaska, applied for the job after a man at a party predicted that she’d wash out if she tried; she compared the experience of overcoming sleep deprivation, pain, stress, and danger to spiritual training. “There’s no knowing what’s going to come,” she said. “You have to give up expectations.” Mel Tenneson, another former Alaska jumper, told me that he sometimes parachuted to places so beautiful that he’d hike for hours instead of sleeping. Wasser, the all-time Jump King, remembered floating to the bottom of a five-hundred-foot-deep canyon, in southern Utah, where he saw cliff dwellings that Ancestral Pueblo people had made some thousand years ago. “It’s sometimes scary and sometimes awe-inspiring,” James Baker, a smokejumper in his fourth year, told me. “But you’re always experiencing it with these people. It’s like this group processing of sublime phenomena.”

As the bust continued in Alaska, work on the base accelerated and intensified. Dozens of additional smokejumpers arrived from across the country. In the box, the jumpers in charge of operations played logistical chess on the whiteboard, moving jumpships between Fairbanks and a “spike base”—a far-flung temporary outpost—to the west, in Galena. Names cascaded up and down the jump list. At the height of the bust, a hundred and sixty-one smokejumpers fought fires across the state. Bill Cramer, a smokejumper of thirty-seven years who had risen to chief of the Alaska Smokejumper Base, parachuted to fires like everyone else. He has always been amazed at the way smokejumping defies hierarchies; whoever is at the top of the jump list is typically the incident commander of the fire. Sometimes his crew leader was a

second-year smokejumper. “I’ve never found an equivalent system anywhere on the planet,” he told me. “We intentionally give people responsibility early, and it creates an organization where you have a ton of people that are ready to step forward.” Cramer was fifty-six, and he was facing mandatory retirement in the winter.

Jumpers often parachute with something special—often a small luxury such as a frozen steak or some olive oil—in a pocket of their suits. Cramer jumps with a stuffed toy pig. One of his four daughters gave it to him after a co-worker died, in 2000, owing to a parachute malfunction. On July 3rd, the pig made its hundred-and-forty-ninth jump, to a fire on the Seward Peninsula that Cramer and another jumper worked to contain. A helicopter transported them to Galena, a hundred and fifty miles away, and he and eleven other jumpers were swiftly dispatched to a fire in the Yukon-Kuskokwim Delta, near the Alaskan town of Aniak. Shortly before midnight, the crew beat out a fifty-acre fire that was smoldering delicately through lush green tundra. The sky was peach and violet. They walked through wildflowers as wisps of gray smoke pooled around their legs.

The firefighters made camp at two in the morning, reclining on the pillowy grass, and ate dinner around a flickering campfire. The next day, they were dispatched to a place called Selawik, near the western coast. A fire had started in a dump and was spreading toward a solar array. Wildland firefighters don’t usually fight fires that are igniting hazardous materials. But Cramer has spent his career teaching jumpers that there is a time to bend every rule. “If you don’t use your judgment, you are putting lives at risk,” he told me. They beat out the flanks of the fire as smoke from burning trash permeated their hair and their clothing. They halted the head of the flames just a hundred feet from the solar panels.

When I talked to Cramer two days later, the crew was still working to secure the fire using pumps, hoses, and helicopter bucket drops. They were sleeping in shifts in the gym of a local school. The town

was mourning a child who had recently died by suicide, and the jumpers passed the funeral in the streets. Cramer was having trouble patching his yellow fire shirt fast enough to cover all the new holes. The days and nights felt increasingly surreal. “I feel like I’m on a vision quest,” he told me.

Carl Gidlund, who rookieed in 1958 in Missoula, once professed that the bonds he felt with his fellow-jumpers surpassed those that he forged during the Vietnam War. At least one smokejumper has been cremated in a jumper T-shirt. In 2024, on a flight from the former Siskiyou Smokejumper Base, Tom (Troop) Emonds tossed the ashes of a friend, the late jumper Gary Mills, out of the plane. Cramer carried the ashes of his predecessor, a base manager named Al Dunton, in a jumpsuit pocket during his hundred-and-ninety-ninth fire jump. The crew had to outrun a fire tornado—but, for Cramer, what was most memorable about that day was that he wound up on the edge of a lake at twilight, gazing out at bull moose and listening to loon calls as he spread Dunton’s ashes.

Cramer, who sometimes listens to Metallica while driving his truck, is one of the few smokejumpers on the base with a crewcut. When I visited his office and asked about the future of smokejumping, he was surprisingly hopeful. His father and his two brothers were smokejumpers; he trusts that today’s generation will not be the last. “I’m not naïve to the external threats, but I wish I was a rookie today,” he told me. “I’m so jealous. I think smokejumping is going to be so much better and more effective twenty years from now.” To explain why he felt this way, he pointed to the jump list, which was just outside his office. Every individual on it possessed numerous qualifications: a single plane full of jumpers is likely to include people who can command entire divisions on megafires, organize air attacks, conduct a prescribed burn, operate a bulldozer, or build maps on a computer. Fires are becoming more complex, but smokejumpers are ready. “It’s Tuesday—what do you need? An archeologist? We got one,” Cramer said. Fire archeologists are experts in protecting important

sites from wildfires. “We have this incredible pool of skilled and motivated humans,” he went on. “The complexity actually works in our favor.”

At most bases, the jump list is set in the spring. Whoever completed the most jumps the previous year reaches into a box and pulls out the name of the season’s first jumper. That jumper pulls out a second name, and so on, and from the list flows all the serendipity of the fire season. The jump list has determined that sisters and even twins will jump out of a plane together. In 1992, Karen Dorris Morrow and her husband were assigned to a two-person fire crew in the wilderness. Nine months later, their son was born. “I definitely jumped a few fires pregnant,” Morrow told me. “And I loved the job so much I jumped another three summers.”

Rookies begin the season at the bottom of the list. They flip coins to see who among them will be first to jump to a fire, and they are not considered smokejumpers until they do. In 2026, the winner of the rookie coin toss in Alaska was twenty-four-year-old Daniel Kehoe. “I’ve never won a flip in my life,” he told me. “I was, like, ‘This is great, it’s gonna be a great season.’ ” After three weeks with no opportunity to jump, Kehoe spent a day off visiting family. While he was gone, all the other rookies were sent out to fires. In the days that followed, Kehoe suited up and loaded onto a jumpship three separate times only to have the mission cancelled at the last minute.

Before the bust, Kehoe was at the bottom of the list—No. 52. He was at risk of becoming one of the few rookies to go an entire season in Alaska without jumping to a fire. Everyone suspected that Big Ernie was up to mischief. But on June 20th, when the fires began to break out in earnest, Kehoe’s fortunes seemed to shift. The siren blared again and again; one load of jumpers and then another took off into the skies over Alaska. As the clock ticked down to the end of shift, at 10 *P.M.*, Kehoe’s name ticked upward. At 9:54 *P.M.*, only one jumpship remained on the tarmac, and the

siren went off for a final time. Cramer and Dow helped the jumpers put on their harnesses. When Kehoe was ready, he rushed out the bay door, high-fiving everyone along the way. ♦

M. R. O'Connor has contributed to The New Yorker since 2015. She is the author of “[Ignition: Lighting Fires in a Burning World](#).”

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/the-art-of-leaping-out-of-planes-to-fight-wildfires>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

[Letter from Auckland](#)

Susan Te Kahurangi King's Way of Seeing

At seventy-five, she may be New Zealand's greatest living artist.

By [Laura Preston](#)

August 30, 2026



King drew prolifically for decades, then stopped. What made her start again?

Photograph by Jake Mein for The New Yorker

By the time I arrived in Auckland, winter had descended. The North Shore beaches were raw and windswept, the seaside shops vacant. As I opened the gate of a home that I had arranged to rent, the landlady appeared in an open window. What, she asked, had possessed me to come all the way from New York at this time of year? I told her that I was visiting Susan Te Kahurangi King, the artist who grew up down the road. “Don’t reckon I’ve heard of her,” she said, and disappeared behind a curtain.

The Kiwi sensibility, like the flightless kiwi bird, is funny, bashful, and a bit forlorn. Some New Zealanders admit embarrassment at living so far away from everything—the real world, they suspect, is

happening elsewhere. But life on an island also inspires a scrappy, home-town camaraderie. A native who finds fame abroad is sure to return a national hero. It is therefore surprising that so few New Zealanders know of King, who, at seventy-five, may be the country's greatest living artist. King has work in the permanent collections of the Philadelphia Museum of Art and *MOMA*; the artist KAWS, a collector of folk art, told me, "They're some of the best drawings. Period." Jerry Saltz, the art critic for *New York*, has compared her to Willem de Kooning. In 2019, when a suite of King's drawings was shown at Andrew Edlin Gallery, in Manhattan, the critic Sanford Schwartz wrote, in *The New York Review of Books*, "Were I the head of a drawings department at a museum, I would make a pitch for the purchase of all of them."

King's career has had a curious shape. She made her first important works in the nineteen-fifties, when she was very young. During the next thirty-four years, she drew prolifically; then, sometime around her fortieth birthday, she stopped. Her family recalls that she spent the next sixteen years at home watching television. In 2008, she started to draw again. It was only in this second phase of art-making that the world noticed what she was up to. Artists and curators saw pictures of her work on Facebook, and in 2009 Peter Fay, a collector in Sydney, arranged for her to have a show. It was King's first solo exhibition, and her first time on an airplane. She was fifty-eight years old.

Critics pointed out King's affinities with Pop art. In the sixties, artists such as Roy Lichtenstein and Peter Saul had plundered lowbrow visual culture for elemental materials. At the same time, on a remote mountain in New Zealand, a little girl was running similar experiments, sublimating the language of cartoons into a supple personal vernacular. King is the governor of teeming underworlds, where pig-faced people are tickled, fondled, and poked; ducks in diapers are sucked down the drain; and "Looney Tunes" characters endure ludicrous dental work. Even as a child, she was relentlessly reinventing her style. At ten, the drawings

were bold and clean, like tattoo flash from an alien planet. In her teens, they turned dark and minerally—she chiselled the paper with her pencil, filling it edge to edge with melancholy landscapes and anarchic towers of bric-a-brac. In her twenties, the compositions began to rise and fall on the page like ocean swells. Humanoids march down the paper in suspended motion, like Marcel Duchamp's descending nude, and condense into agate bands of color. Some wear bathing suits; some wear stilettos; others have meat grinders for heads. They crush through middens of surreal debris: propeller hats and bunny ears, bull noses with brass rings, a famous mouse's gloves signing farewell. The drawings are terrifying, hilarious, lewd, and ornery. King's eyes gather the world's hodgepodge, and her hand records with a sensitivity that can come only from fondness. Remarkably, she does not plan her compositions or use an eraser. "The image has already been born," Phong H. Bui, the publisher of *The Brooklyn Rail*, told me. "All she has to do is follow it."

It's a riotous œuvre. In counterpoint stands the artist herself, who does not read, write, or speak. This is one reason that she is not more famous. The promotion of her art depends entirely on other people. She cannot give an interview or tell you what her drawings mean. The only way to get to know her, besides looking at her work, is to be next to her in a room. And so I found myself in Auckland.

If you want to meet King, you will first have to meet her sister Petita Cole, a compact woman of sixty-six, with round cheeks and a laugh that could knock down a set of bowling pins. Cole is King's manager, communications director, and registrar. She has more energy than most, on less sleep than advisable—helpful, given that gallerists in other hemispheres ring her at "unearthly hours." Two of five bedrooms in her home, in Auckland, now hold her sister's drawing archive. A third bedroom is for King to sleep in. King lives an hour away, in the city of Hamilton, with another sister, Wendy,

but travels to Cole's about once a month to spend time with her old work.

Cole invited me over during one of these visits. As she led me down a hallway, she told me that she had been up since dawn, when she awoke to the sound of King in the next room, drawing in the dark. Cole had risen from bed, turned on the light by her sister's desk, then left her alone.

Now King remained at the same desk, still as a mountain. Only her left arm moved. She drew serpentine lines on a creased piece of paper. For every mark on one side of the crease, she made a similar mark on the other. Her pencil produced a soft scrubbing sound, filling the room with a sedative rhythm. In the course of seventy years, King has generated a staggering number of drawings—perhaps twenty thousand, though no one has done a precise count. Cole has spent the past two decades organizing the drawings in binders. She showed me to a row of shelves and told me to pick any binder I wanted. I chose one at random and was ushered to another bedroom, where I sat on the bed.

The works in my lap were dated 1962. My eye landed on a jalopy with entomological headlights, flatulent exhaust, and tires so fat that you could serve them with coffee. In another drawing, a Cubist mess of igloos and sandcastles lay in a heap. I did some math. This was the art of an eleven-year-old girl. I sensed a presence in the hallway. King walked into the room with impersonal frankness and sat on the bed beside me. Though she faced away, her mouth formed a faint smile. Her eyes darted around, and I felt that she was pleased, maybe as curious as I was to review what she had made all those years ago.

King has a broad face, a mop of salt-and-pepper hair, and crinkly, bright eyes that are hard to catch, as she is expert at dodging the gazes of others. She is around five feet tall but gives an impression of largeness. When I first met her, I was struck by what seemed like

a staunch constitutional abstention: King does not emote, does not participate in group activities, and does not broadcast an inner life. I soon learned that this was not to be mistaken for a lack of inner life. Her personality is gigantic, but it's detectable mostly in her eyes, which are sometimes bewildered and other times ablaze with a teasing, wicked humor. She does not communicate with gestures or devices. ("Too set in her ways," Cole said.) Besides sneezes and occasional grumbles, she does not make much sound at all. Cole's husband, Bryson, who has known King for half a century, told me that he's heard her laugh once, in 2008, when he dropped his dinner on the ground.

On the day of my visit, King drew until the afternoon, then got up, put on her glasses, and hovered by the front door—her way of saying that it was time to go out. The three of us piled into Cole's car. Cole apologized that she could not offer me the passenger seat; King enjoyed looking out the window but would not turn her head if she were riding in the back.



*King does not plan her compositions or use an eraser. “The image has already been born,” Phong H. Bui, the publisher of The Brooklyn Rail, says.
Photograph by Jake Mein for The New Yorker*

We drove to the Auckland Zoo. Cole had recently completed treatment for ovarian cancer and had lost all but a few strands of hair. She improvised a hat using an old fur collar that had belonged to her grandmother and a head scarf that her son had worn in a Bible play. “We mustn’t scare the kiddies,” she said. King wandered the grounds at a funereal pace. She wore a bucket hat and sunglasses, held a walking stick in one hand, and hooked her free arm behind her back, like a scrupulous exam proctor. She stared

down the nose of a New Zealand longfin eel that hovered in its tank like a thick black ribbon.

When we crossed a footbridge, Cole urged us to look down. “Crocodiles, Susan! The big ones kill and eat people.” King smiled. “Reptiles and her own exhibitions,” Cole said. “The two guarantees.”

It is hard to say much about King’s self-concept as an artist. For most of her life, she had little contact with the art world. She drew, it seemed, for personal reasons. Still, the people around her appreciated her work, and this likely motivated her. In a photograph from 1965, she poses in the back yard with one of her drawings and projects serene, quiet pride. In her long period of inactivity, she was sullen, anxious, and withdrawn. Her work’s recognition by international curators and her decision to start drawing again were more or less simultaneous events. Afterward, King’s family noticed a change in her demeanor. “The light came on,” Cole said. King tends to diminish herself physically, curling her shoulders in a dramatic hunch. At exhibitions, however, she stands up straight.

King was born in 1951 in Te Aroha, about two hours’ drive from Auckland. During the water-cure craze of the late nineteenth century, Te Aroha was a thriving spa town. Some thirty thousand tourists visited annually to soak in the mountain’s mineral springs and sip from a geyser of warm fizzy water. By the mid-nineteen-fifties, most of the spas were defunct, and Te Aroha had diminished into a sleepy hideaway, a place, perhaps, for getting a tire fixed on the way to somewhere else. A single highway splits the town in two, then bends around an alluvial plain, past tumbledown sheds and herds of cattle that drink from Victorian bathtubs dragged to pasture.

King’s parents, Doug and Dawn, spent the first year of their marriage in a canvas tent, as they could not afford a house. Doug

worked as a car mechanic in town. On the wall of the tent, he hung a handmade sign:

POLYLINGUISTIC RESEARCH INSTITUTE

Principal: Douglas G. King (Research Philologist)

Doug was passionate about photography, Disney comics, mountain climbing, and Jesus, but most of all he loved the Maori language, which he had picked up while working as an itinerant sheepshearer in the countryside. He took the name Takarangi and taught a Maori-language course at night. Though he joined a *marae*, a Maori religious gathering place, he remained a devout Christian. It disturbed him to think that the people he most admired were going to Hell, so he translated the Bible into Maori and distributed evangelical tracts in the community.

King was a “happy, lovable child,” Dawn later wrote, in a case history for her daughter’s medical file, “not spoiled, never grizzly, full of life and vigour.” Then, when King was about three years old, she changed. Her speech became jumbled. At night, she bumped her head against the headboard and sang nursery rhymes in loops. She had bursts of rambunctious energy followed by catatonia. Doug, in a letter to his mother-in-law, recalled that in church she’d sit frozen in the pew, “staring into space, not moving, arms folded up front like wings, holding her purse in the air.”

Around the same time, King was overcome with wanderlust. She would ride her tricycle for miles down the main road before anyone noticed her absence. Her parents often pinned a note to her shirt so that local taxi-drivers could bring her home. Once, in the winter of 1955, she vanished into the nearby bush, prompting a police search. Late in the evening, she turned up at a stranger’s house, shivering and covered in scratches, having crossed a dense wilderness on her own. By then, the Kings had five children, and Dawn’s attention was divided. Within a week of the incident, King was sent to live in

Auckland with Dawn's mother, Myrtle Murphy, who could supervise her around the clock.

Murphy was a diminutive, formal woman of Irish birth who never finished grade school but had a great appetite for learning. She made lists of collectible stamps and coins, and of ships in Auckland harbor, and spent many afternoons photographing the construction of the Auckland Northern Motorway. When her unfathomable granddaughter showed up, she found a new outlet for her curiosity. "Not a word all day," Murphy wrote in her diary. "Eyes all queer." Murphy kept a log of words spoken or attempted. "Said 'bang, balloon, pig, broke,' " she wrote. "Tried to say 'spider, listen, crooked, cake.' " King seemed stranded in a faraway world, tortured by a discomfort that no amount of affection could soothe. "She would almost break my neck with the way she would press her forehead against my face, as if relieved to do it, poor lamb," Murphy wrote.

Murphy soon realized that King was more attentive than she appeared. Give her a pencil, and familiar images would spill forth: lanterns from the wharf, Donald Duck, snowdrops like the ones that she had helped her grandmother arrange in a vase. King seemed indifferent to the world, but she was scrutinizing its forms and its illusions. And though she acted aloof, she was in fact eager to connect with others. "At 11:30am I gave her pencil and paper," Murphy wrote. "She drew carefully and tried to tell me what; even stood up and put one leg backwards, trying to describe what she was drawing each time, her face full of expression."

King stayed with Murphy for six months, then returned to her parents in Te Aroha. In the years that followed, King made frequent visits to Murphy's house, often for long stretches. Murphy took King all over Auckland: to the Farmers department store, to see a live cockatoo and a clockwork elephant; to Walker's pet shop, to see white rabbits; to Parnell Baths, where King gazed at the striped

umbrellas and diving boards. All of this showed up in her drawings. The world went in, and pliant, playful interpretations flowed out.

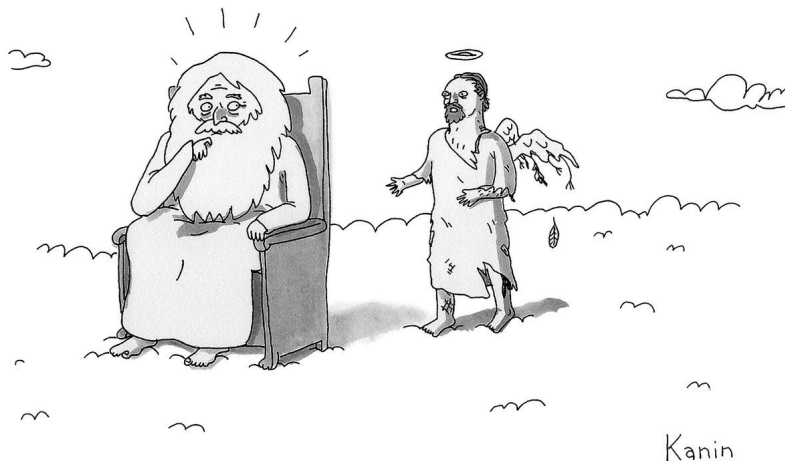
The drawings, for Murphy, were a riddle. How could King draw with such aptitude and still struggle to talk? During one stay in Auckland, Murphy took King to have her head X-rayed. No tumor, the doctor reported, but King was unlikely to live a normal life. “There are institutes for such children,” he said, and recommended one in the town of Levin, two hundred miles away. During the appointment, Murphy brought out a dozen drawings. (“Some extra good!” she later wrote to Dawn.) The doctor showed little interest, but he kept them anyway, and never gave them back.

The family continued to search for answers. King’s parents brought her to a palm reader, a homeopath, a chromotherapist, an iridologist, and a chiropractor, who suggested that King had “a few bones out of place.” They wrote to the Paul Devante Academy of Grapho-Analysis. (“The Trail You Leave in Ink Reveals a *GREAT TRUTH*,” an advertisement read.) At one point, Doug gathered scraps of King’s clothing and sent them to a spiritualist in Whanganui. The man, who referred to himself as Reverend Spencer, replied with this assessment: “The chief cause of Susan’s trouble is the fact that her head is in what we call a ‘Cosmic Circle.’ ” He had located the cosmic circle above King’s bed. “When you have moved the bed, you will find a change coming over her for the better,” he wrote. “You do not need to worry. She will be okay.”

Time passed, and King’s words grew fewer. The King family grew larger. By the seventies, Dawn and Doug had twelve children, and still no explanation for their eldest daughter’s condition. The household was crowded and lawless. Amid such chaos, it was easiest to let King do what she wanted—sit in the corner and draw. On trips to the beach, she would find a stick and drag it through the sand, and the family would go up a hill to look down on the pictures, which were many yards across. As in early childhood,

King preferred solo adventures. Sometimes her family lost sight of her, and when they noticed she was gone she would be neck-deep in the ocean, with the waves lapping her chin. The last documented words she spoke, around 1961, at age ten, were “dead, dead, dead.”

During my next few days in Auckland, I fell into a routine. I’d arrive at Cole’s around nine in the morning, look at drawings until Cole summoned me for lunch, then return to the archive and stay until the sun went down. Cole played benevolent librarian, popping in from time to time to show me things of interest. She brought in a stack of religious pamphlets that Doug had printed in the family basement. On one page, tiny, antlike sinners tumbled down a cliff toward perdition. Cole wondered if such images had influenced her sister. Next, she brought in a bundle of pencils that King had used in her youth. King had sharpened them in her own eccentric way: not just at one end but at both, hacking down the wood with a kitchen knife to expose a long rod of lead, then gouging into the lead where it met the wood to produce a tip that flared like a club. “No one else sharpens pencils like that,” Cole said.



*“We have to stop letting all dogs into Heaven—people are getting mauled.”
Cartoon by Zachary Kanin*

In nearly every drawing, Cole could point to a motif and explain its real-world referent. The Fanta mascot peers out from a pantry door

—the same pantry door that was in the house in Auckland where the Kings moved in 1960. An interplay of right-angled lines is a handrail in the yard of the I.H.C. School, the center for disabled children where King was enrolled at age nine. Some of the pictures pose questions. What if you had a face on the sole of your foot? A faucet growing out of your forehead? Others are testing grounds for activities that the real world forbids. King drops elephants through the air, erects wobbly Towers of Babel, lets characters run amok with depictions of her own pencils, and then summons a hand with a knife to clear a clean space on the page.

The drawings survive because of the family’s archiving instinct, but that instinct sometimes resulted in mutilation: many have been folded, cut up, and pasted into scrapbooks. One day, Cole paged through an album whose acidic glues caused her particular anguish. “I call those birdified people, or peoplefied birds,” she said, of a few fragments. I admired a troll with toothpicks for a beard who looked as if he were made of caviar. “Look how cronky this guy is!” she said, pointing to a clown from Hell. “And a big floppy penis in the middle of it.”

I had seen King’s work in person once before, at the 2022 Outsider Art Fair in New York. Her drawings hung beside pieces by Henry Darger, Bill Traylor, and James Castle—canonical artists in the genre. “Outsider art” is the English equivalent of “art brut,” a term coined in the nineteen-forties by the French artist Jean Dubuffet, to describe the works of children, prisoners, and psychiatric patients. Dubuffet had grown disenchanted by what he called the “fallacious parade” of highbrow art; in the unschooled, the ostracized, and the vulnerable, he found a more authentic spirit. Eighty years later, the mainstream art world has assimilated “outsider art” as a marketing category. It has become a shorthand for artists who are self-taught or who exist outside the usual cultural byways, but the term is not otherwise descriptive. The curator Lyle Rexer, who has written on the genre’s vexations, points out that most art-world isms—Cubism, Impressionism—were created by artists to describe their

working principles. “Outsider art,” on the other hand, refers not “to the art but to the status of those who make it.” The works of Darger, Traylor, Castle, and King have little to do with one another except that their makers were marginal, and even the conditions of their marginality vary: Darger was institutionalized as a child, made unusual noises and gestures, and lived his later years as a recluse; Traylor was born into slavery; Castle was the profoundly deaf child of subsistence farmers.



Petita Cole has spent two decades archiving her sister's vast body of work, along with many of the real-life objects she has drawn.

Photograph by Jake Mein for The New Yorker

Outsider art thus sustains a frustrating paradox. It ventures to include while also fencing out. It seems to marvel that great art could come from somewhere beyond common experience, when the most pervasive cliché of the art establishment is that the artist is a nonconformist. The term suggests supernatural gifts despite formal ignorance. King's mastery, in fact, comes from years of intense, self-directed study, even if much of the study has developed on envelopes, bits of cardboard, and other scraps. "It's mind-blowing how serious her drawings are, and mind-blowing how unserious her materials are," the New York gallerist Phillip March Jones, who represents King in the United States, told me. (A solo show of her work, curated by Jones, is now on view in Los Angeles, at James Fuentes Gallery.)

King's indifference to orthodox formats enables formal mischief. The drawings are often double-sided, with no discernible up or down. She searches for imperfections in the paper and allows them to influence her line. Sometimes, when drawing in a notebook, she bears down with so much pressure that she inscribes the page beneath. She'll turn the page and let the grooves prompt the next picture. Paper is a joke with many punch lines. I came across a small scrap that she had reinterpreted as a jail cell. Bugs Bunny jams himself against the edge and grits his teeth in agony. Another scrap pulls off a different gag: King had filled it with a tiny but proportional composition, as if she'd shrunk down a large drawing for a doll-house wall. In one work, a trompe-l'oeil page corner lifts to reveal a world beyond. "You feel like you're seeing something unfold in real time," the gallerist Robert Heald, who represents King in New Zealand, said. "Works spill into other works. Any one work is a sample of the larger thing. You're just dipping in and out."

King attended the I.H.C. School until she was twenty-nine years old. Initially, it was a good place for her. Her teachers enjoyed her drawings and left her alone to make them. There were psychiatrists on staff, but none remained at the school long enough to get to

know King or offer an answer for why she didn't speak. In 1965, when King was fourteen, one psychiatrist recommended a stay in Ward 10, the inpatient psychiatric floor at Auckland City Hospital, so that doctors could get to the bottom of it.

Some weeks later, when Dawn visited King in the ward, she found her daughter sitting outdoors in the sunshine. The weather was hot, but King was dressed in several wool sweaters, sweating profusely. It appeared that she had not been bathed. Dawn learned that the staff had withdrawn all personal care as part of King's treatment plan. They theorized that King could talk but was simply refusing to do so. If they stopped assisting her, the reasoning went, she would have to articulate her preferences. Thus began a game of attrition. King didn't ask to bathe, so they did not bathe her. She did not say what foods she wanted, so they did not feed her. She did not tell them when she was menstruating, so they let her bleed through her clothes. Because drawing was another form of communication, they took her materials away.

When Cole described this episode to me, sixty years later, she spoke with fresh bitterness. "They thought, If she wants something, she can bloody well ask," she said. Cole rummaged through an archival box and pulled out a notebook that was no bigger than a business card. Murphy had smuggled it into the ward for King, who had filled each page with a miniature composition: an emaciated bird, a demonic Donald Duck leering from bed, a reclining male torso with an erection. Later, Murphy secreted it home.

King went back and forth to Ward 10 several times, and these institutionalizations marked the beginning of a dark period for the family. In 1970, the fourth King sibling, Irene, died of leukemia, at sixteen years old. Ten years later, their brother Bernard, a gentle, soft-spoken botanist, developed schizophrenia, and their mother became consumed with coordinating his care. By this time, the I.H.C. had introduced a work program in which students performed repetitive tasks for a few cents an hour. King was no longer

allowed to draw; instead, she spent her days hooking rugs. The wool fibres irritated her eyes. When she drew at home, the repetitive motions of the rug workshop carried into her pictures. She filled pages with tight, agitated coils. By the mid-nineties, she'd left the I.H.C., and stopped drawing completely. She spent much of her time in the living room, expressionless, "like a shadow," Cole said. The family packed King's drawings in boxes and suitcases, which they stowed in closets and in a crawlspace under the house.

One day, during my visit, Cole used a step stool to access a small cubbyhole in a high corner of a bedroom wall—a sort of illogical nook that seemed preordained to house some private, upsetting object. She excavated several journals the size of phone books. "Mum's repertoire-izing," she said. Dawn had had a lifelong interest in homeopathy and spent hours obsessively detailing her children's ailments. She covered every inch of every page with her tight script, then covered the pages with Post-it notes, illuminating the illuminations:

What's it all about *SUSAN Looks Sad*
eyes puffing under
SO What's it all about?

In 2008, a friend of the King family, the filmmaker Dan Salmon, began making a feature-length documentary about King called "Pictures of Susan." Salmon wondered if King could be persuaded to draw again, and Dawn agreed to try. She set out paper and pencils on a worktable by some windows that overlooked the bush. Aware that King did not tolerate disorder, she left little messes around the materials—a dish towel draped over a chair, for example. The hope was that King would pause to tidy up the area, then pick up a pencil. When that didn't work, Dawn stencilled shapes onto white paper. Maybe King would want to fill them in.

For a long time, nothing happened. But then, in Dawn's journal:

June 08

Susan STARTS TO DRAW again

“It wasn’t incy-wincy,” Cole said. “It was *boom*.” The new drawings weren’t representational like the old ones; they were abstract and weblike, even cartographic. Just as before, King made them in great numbers.

Meanwhile, Cole had been pulling old drawings out of suitcases to remind King of what she used to do. Once the drawings were out of storage, it seemed wrong to put them back. More sensible, Cole thought, to file them in plastic sleeves. None of the pieces had titles, so she assigned them numbers and instituted a system. As she organized the works, she noticed patterns. Characters—both known and invented—had recurrent cameos.

At the house, Cole sat at her office computer and read some of the categories in a database that she’d designed. “I need to make sure the information is user-friendly so that if I’m hit by a bus or whatever it’s not all lost,” she said. We skimmed part of the list together: *CRUTCHES*, *CONCRETE MIXERS*, *HAT PINS*, *GROIN CLUTCHER*, *HINGED EYEBALL*, Indication of *PAIN* or *INJURY*, *ICEBERGS* and *IGLOOS*, *HAIRY CHIN*, *CALIPERS*, *COLLAPSED GELATO*, *FEET* or *HEAD* in *PAPER BAG*, *FEMALE NUDE*, *FOGHORN LEGHORN*, *EARTH MOVING MACHINE*. There were certain objects in the drawings which only family members would recognize. Cole had noticed the legs of their dining table and the Bakelite switches in Murphy’s house. She remembered a ceramic turtle that had sat on a shelf. In the fifties, its head broke off—a notable event. And there, in one of King’s drawings, was the same turtle, with its head missing.

Doug died in 1998, Dawn in 2018. As Cole packed up her parents’ home, she uncovered more of the objects King had drawn. “Come, I’ll show you my bitty bits,” Cole said. She led me to the living room, where there were several cabinets of clutter. Her collection

includes a leather worker's rotating hole punch, a wishbone, bedroom slippers with pompom toes, Murphy's silver teaspoons in the various shapes of the twelve apostles, an old-fashioned rubber enema, a portable FM radio that looks like the Bassett's Liquorice Allsorts mascot, a frilly white bathing cap, a cereal-box prize from the sixties called the Flex-O-Link. Virtually any object with a connection to King's past was worth keeping. She showed me a photo of Eileen Joynt, a neighbor who knew King as a child, and a dish of small, beige minerals, which Cole gathered and placed in my hand. "Eileen Joynt's gallstones," she said.

Not everything that King draws is identifiable. For years, Cole was mystified by a small, beanlike object with stripes which lurked in the background of certain drawings. The bean didn't resemble anything obvious, but seemed important; King drew it frequently. Cole made a bean from polymer clay, sanded it smooth, and applied stripes with a pencil. She went through the archive and found every instance of the bean, then made each one a precise clay double. In time, she had seventeen. She gave the beans to King, who rolled them around in her palm.

Cole's archive is always growing, especially now that King has got her second wind. KAWS likes to send gifts in the mail—limited-edition figurines, an art book, and, recently, a Christmas card, which King improved with meandering lines. When I visited Auckland, Cole was preparing for a show in New York, at Ruttkowski;⁶⁸ which would pair King's drawings with works by the German artist Philip Emde. Emde paints portraits of stuffed animals made by the German company Steiff. Cole went online, bought Steiffs by the piles, and lined the shelves of King's bedroom. That was her way of putting the artists in conversation.

Back in 2009, when King's gallerists first talked about selling her work, most of the King siblings rejected the idea. No one could know for certain what King wanted, and the siblings didn't feel that it was within their authority to decide, so the family took a cautious

approach. The work showed in Sydney and in Wellington, but none of the drawings were offered for purchase. *Not* selling was also a choice with consequences, though. Cole recalled how, at the close of those early shows, the drawings were removed from their frames and returned to Auckland, to be put back in their cupboards. “Does that really honor them?” she asked. The family’s stance shifted. In 2013, the curator Chris Byrne and Marquand Books presented King’s work at the Outsider Art Fair in Paris, and all the drawings on view sold.



King at the Auckland Zoo, which she visits frequently. “Reptiles and her own exhibitions,” Cole says.

“The two guarantees.”

Photograph by Jake Mein for The New Yorker

The last time that King had earned money for art was in 1973, when the International Society for Mentally Handicapped Children included two of her drawings in a charity exhibition. The pieces sold for three pounds. Now she was receiving checks for thousands of dollars. The family did not know where to put the money, or how it should be taxed. They consulted an accountant, who told them that King needed a court-appointed property manager; this required a doctor to confirm her disability. King saw a psychiatrist, and at the age of sixty-four was given a diagnosis of autism-spectrum disorder.

Cole sees the diagnosis as merely clerical. King was the same person before and after, even if her behaviors became less mysterious. The important consequence was that she could keep her money in a trust. Money from sales meant better materials and the chance to travel, and it allowed Cole to quit her job as an elementary-school art teacher to manage King's studio. Cole did worry that curators might overemphasize the diagnosis, that King would no longer be an artist but an autistic artist, and therefore a symbol of something—resilience, perhaps, or liberation through creativity. King's gallerists maintain that her work should be considered on its own terms. "King's neurodiversity is the least interesting thing about her," Jones, the New York gallerist, said. Cole told me that once, when King's work was included in a group show whose only common theme was disability, King had acted visibly miffed.

Three months after my visit to Auckland, Cole and King travelled to New York City for the show with Emde, which was called "Playdate." A day ahead of the opening, Cole arranged for Emde and King to spend some time together. They decided to visit the Bronx Zoo, and I drove the three of them there.

The zoo was deserted in a late-summer heat wave. Emde wandered ahead while King lagged behind at her usual tempo, which is uncommonly slow but projects incongruous urgency. They saw an

Andean condor, its wings spread wide as a canoe. The gorillas lazed in their pen like picnickers on a lawn. One paced at the edge of the enclosure, and then, in a swift, warlike motion, hurled a clod of dirt toward the glass, where it exploded with a bang. The onlookers shrieked and leaped back. King did not flinch.

At the opening reception for “Playdate,” King spent a long time in front of Emde’s largest work, scanning it as if committing it to memory. Cole hovered nearby. Some visitors wanted to speak to King but weren’t sure how. A few whispered close to her ear, others talked loudly at a distance. Some addressed Cole as if King weren’t there. The best way to talk to King, I had decided, was to look at her drawings with her and describe what you see. I noticed that whenever I did this my sentences would steadily simplify, becoming recitations of nouns, then syllables, then noises. Eventually, I’d go silent, and we’d just look together.

At 8 P.M., the gallery was still full. Though King wore no watch, some inner clock told her that the show was over. She stood by the entrance and waited. That was fine, the stance seemed to say, those strangers and their talking. But now it was time for something else. Cole opened the door, and King pressed into a graffitied alley, smiling at walls defaced with names, emblems, and old, ecstatic gestures. ♦

Laura Preston began contributing to The New Yorker in 2022.

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/susan-te-kahurangi-kings-way-of-seeing>

[A Reporter at Large](#)

What Happened in Minneapolis

Living through Operation Metro Surge, and what came after.

By [Emily Witt](#)

August 31, 2026



A former Assistant U.S. Attorney described the ground plan in Minnesota: “They were, like, ‘Occupy Minneapolis like it was Falluja.’ ”

Photographs by Philip Cheung for The New Yorker

Michael Cavlan had settled into a routine of patrolling his neighborhood by car most mornings when, early on January 7th, he received an alert on his phone informing him about Immigration and Customs Enforcement activity near his house in Powderhorn, in South Minneapolis. The previous day, the Department of Homeland Security had announced that it was sending two thousand immigration agents to Minnesota to take part in Operation Metro Surge, a campaign of mass detention and deportation that the Trump Administration advertised as the largest D.H.S. undertaking ever. Cavlan, a salty, gray-haired nurse and union steward, is a first-generation Irish American; in 1969, his Irish Catholic parents, inspired by the U.S. civil-rights movement, had moved the family

back to Northern Ireland to participate in its push for independence. Since the surge began, on December 1st, Cavlan had joined other Minneapolis residents in monitoring the presence of federal agents in town—“Just being there and making sure *ICE* wasn’t doing anything illegal,” he told me.

On the same morning, a short drive away, a therapist who asked to be identified as Bre was also patrolling, having woken up to an alert on her phone about *ICE* activity at her daughter’s former elementary school. “I put clothes on, and I drove straight to the school,” she told me. By the time she got there, the *ICE* agents had left, but she noticed a telltale convoy of S.U.V.s with tinted windows speeding down the street and decided to follow them.

Bre arrived at the intersection of Thirty-fourth Street and Portland Avenue, where she saw a group of *ICE* agents standing around as a crowd of people shouted at them. A woman’s body lay on the ground, surrounded by paramedics, and a man—a doctor, Bre later found out—was screaming. “He said, ‘They pointed a gun at me! They wouldn’t let me take her pulse!’ ” Bre recalled.

She noticed that the woman’s clothes had been cut off so that the paramedics could perform CPR. The sidewalk was icy, and the woman’s skin was exposed to the cold. “Her underwear was bloody,” Bre said. “I thought, Is this a miscarriage?” Unsure of how she could help, Bre left for an appointment. “I didn’t know until later that afternoon that she was one of us, and that she died,” she said. Cavlan, who had arrived there around the same time, knew exactly what he was seeing. He notified the Signal group that had sent him the initial alert. “I said, ‘Hey, dispatch, this is Irish. I’m here at the scene. *ICE* has shot somebody.’ ”

A few hours later, Bre would learn what happened the way nearly all of us did, through video. Renée Good—a thirty-seven-year-old mother of three and an American citizen who was, like Bre and Cavlan, monitoring *ICE*’s presence—tries to maneuver her Honda

to leave the area after an agent tells her to “get out of the fucking car.” An agent in front of the car shoots Good multiple times, first through the windshield and then through the driver’s-side window. (“Fucking bitch,” he says afterward, in a video recorded on his phone that was released later.) The Honda continues down the street and crashes into a parked car, as Good’s wife, Becca Good, who was recording the altercation, runs after it.

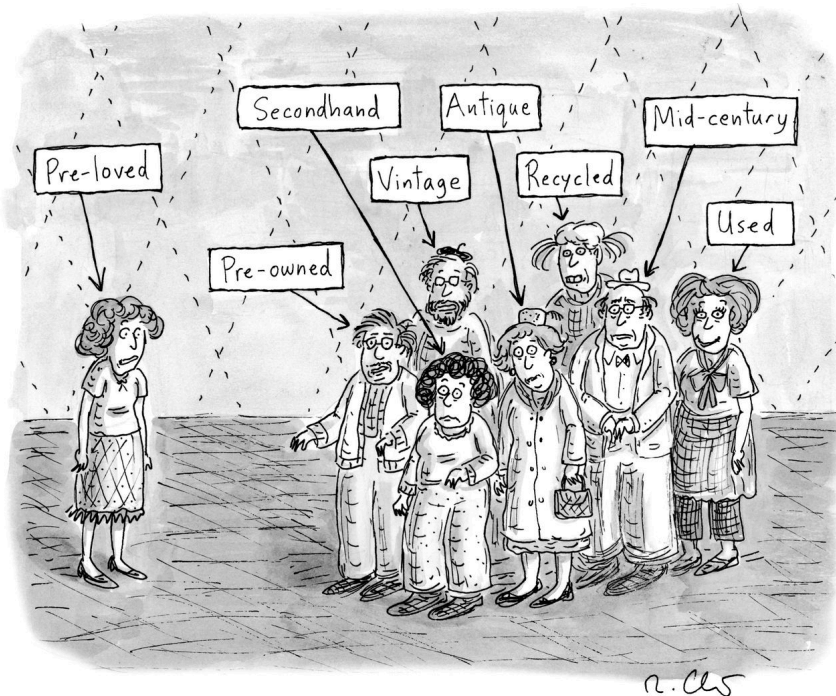
Renée Good’s biography defied easy political categorizations: she was raised Christian in one of the most conservative cities in the country and had started a new chapter of her life in one of its most liberal. She grew up in Colorado Springs, in a community that Becca Hainsworth, who was friends with Good as a teen-ager, recalled as “very military-heavy, very religious-heavy.” Both were enthusiastic members of a Presbyterian Church in America youth group called Village Seven; Good was an occasional soloist on the worship team. “She had one of the most beautiful singing voices I’ve ever heard in my life,” Hainsworth said.

Good married her high-school boyfriend, Justin Sheppard, in 2009; he joined the Air Force, and they had two kids before divorcing in 2015. In her thirties, while pregnant with her third child, Good studied English as an undergraduate at Old Dominion University. Her second husband and the child’s father, an Air Force veteran named Timmy Ray Macklin, Jr., died in 2023, a few months after the two broke up.

Renée and Becca Good started their relationship that year, and, according to public records, Renée took Becca’s last name in the fall. The couple moved to Minneapolis from Kansas City in 2025. “I guess they made the decision that if Trump won the election, they were going to get out before the inauguration,” a former neighbor told the *Kansas City Star*. They settled in a neighborhood with a supportive network of queer families. In one of the only public statements she has made since Renée’s killing, Becca Good spoke of “a strong shared sense here in Minneapolis that we were

looking out for each other.” She continued, “Here, I had finally found peace and safe harbor. That has been taken from me forever.”

The agent who killed Good, Jonathan Ross, had worked for *ICE* since 2015, after previous stints in the National Guard and Border Patrol. In June, 2025, Ross was dragged by a vehicle driven by a Cuban immigrant whom he was attempting to arrest. (The driver, Roberto Munoz-Guatemala, was later convicted of a felony charge for assaulting a federal officer.) By midday on January 7th, members of the Trump Administration were arguing that Ross had acted in self-defense. Posting on Truth Social, the President said that Good “violently, willfully, and viciously ran over the ICE officer”; Vice-President J. D. Vance called her a “deranged leftist”; and Stephen Miller, the White House deputy chief of staff for policy and Trump’s homeland-security adviser, described Good’s interaction with Ross before her death as “domestic terrorism.” (D.H.S. has continued to claim that Good “weaponized her vehicle” and attempted to hit Ross.)



Cartoon by Roz Chast

“This is literally one of the most docile, kind, sweet, empathetic, shy people I know,” Hainsworth said. She told me that, after she’d

found out that Good still had a pulse when the paramedics arrived, she watched the video of the shooting “five thousand times over.” “I know Renée,” she said. “I know her facial expressions. I know what her face looks like when she’s scared, and she’s scared.” I asked her why she had watched the video so many times, and she started to cry. “I just didn’t want her to be alone, you know?” she said.

In Minneapolis—which had exploded into destructive mass protests following the murder of George Floyd by a police officer named Derek Chauvin in 2020—officials scrambled to prepare for a potentially similar response to Good’s killing. Joe Thompson, then a senior official in the Minnesota U.S. Attorney’s office and one of the city’s few intermediaries between the local and federal governments, requested that immigration agents pause enforcement activities while the shooting was investigated. For several hours, it appeared that they had. Then, in the early afternoon, Jacob Frey, the mayor of the city, gave a press conference during which he told *ICE* agents to “get the fuck out of Minneapolis.” Not long afterward, two dozen Border Patrol agents descended on Roosevelt High School as class was getting out, prompting a confrontation in which the agents deployed pepper spray and arrested four people, including a teacher. (A D.H.S. spokesperson said that the agents had been pursuing a U.S. citizen who was “actively trying to impede operations.”) Minneapolis public schools cancelled classes for the rest of the week.

Frey told me that “get the fuck out” was not, as he put it, “in my talking points” for that day, but he stood by his speech. “People think of it as purely a message to *ICE* and the federal Administration,” he said. “But it was also a message to my constituents, because they need to know that there is a government on their side.” Some locals on the ground, however, felt let down. “The elected officials abandoned us,” Cavlan, who regularly volunteers as a street medic and has run for Senate as a Green Party

candidate, said. “Mayor Frey, what was his big thing? He said ‘fuck.’ ”

By evening, a memorial had been set up at the site of the shooting. Bre quietly joined the vigil. “I didn’t talk to anybody,” she said. “I just kind of cried in the crowd with everyone.”

Tim Walz, the governor of Minnesota, told me that he’d spoken with Kristi Noem, the Secretary of Homeland Security, on the day of Good’s death. She and Walz had been fellow-congresspeople from the Upper Midwest; Walz recalled exercising alongside her at the Capitol gym. “I had a very heated conversation that ended with me saying, ‘Well, I hope you can sleep well tonight, Kristi,’ ” he told me. “And she said, ‘I certainly will.’ ”

In the following days, as Minneapolis processed its outrage and grief, Trump deployed another thousand agents to the state. On January 13th, he posted on Truth Social, “FEAR NOT, GREAT PEOPLE OF MINNESOTA, THE DAY OF RECKONING & RETRIBUTION IS COMING!”

I arrived in Minneapolis, the city where I grew up, the next day, and was eating a cheeseburger at a bar as news broke of another *ICE* shooting. So this is how it will be now, I thought. I drove to the site, on Twenty-fourth Avenue North. Tear gas drifted through the air, punctuated by the sound of flash-bang grenades. The temperature was in the teens, and the streets were banked with ice. A few dozen protesters in parkas and assorted Carhartt winter apparel were standing in front of a line of masked and armed federal agents, who were guarding the house where the shooting had occurred.

The next morning, D.H.S. issued a press release with an account that was later found in court to have been fabricated. The government’s story, about “criminal illegal aliens” assaulting agents with a snow shovel and a broom, seemed almost quaint in its

seasonal details. Security-camera footage and forensic examination by Minnesota's Bureau of Criminal Apprehension eventually showed that an agent named Christian Castro, who had been pursuing a car driven by an immigrant named Alfredo Aljorna, shot Aljorna's roommate Julio Sosa-Celis, a Venezuelan immigrant, through the closed front door of their house. Sosa-Celis, who had Temporary Protected Status that allowed him to live and work in the U.S., was shot through the leg; the bullet lodged itself in the wall of a child's bedroom. (A D.H.S. spokesperson said that the agency had unknowingly relied on false testimony from two officers when preparing the press release; the officers were placed on administrative leave.)

Ten days later, another American citizen, Alex Pretti, was shot and killed by federal agents in Minneapolis, followed by a similar pattern of attacks and denials by federal officials. A government strategy was emerging: immigration agents using excessive force; officials casting blame before the facts were fully known; the government stalling investigations. After the third shooting, however, the American public's incredulity about the official narrative became hard to ignore. Trump's approval ratings tanked, and the *ICE* surges into American cities were replaced by less conspicuous methods. By that point, nearly four thousand of Minnesota's immigrants had been detained, and the operation was costing taxpayers an estimated eighteen million dollars each week. The human—and moral—cost was far higher. In January, when Jonathan Ross killed Renée Good, the government's treatment of local opposition to its immigration agenda still had the power to shock the country. In fact, her death marked the beginning of a new reality. *ICE* and C.B.P., two federal immigration agencies with law-enforcement wings, were now operating like militarized forces in the hearts of American cities, seemingly empowered to shoot and kill U.S. citizens with a posture of impunity.

The Trump Administration initially framed Operation Metro Surge as a crackdown on fraud. When Donald Trump took office in

January, 2025, the Minnesota U.S. Attorney's office was in the process of securing convictions in a years-long investigation into a nonprofit called Feeding Our Future, which had stolen two hundred and fifty million dollars in pandemic-era federal-aid funds through false billing. The probe, which was first made public in 2022, had since widened to include autism clinics, adult day-care centers, and other recipients of Medicaid dollars. The ringleader of the scheme, who was recently sentenced to forty-one years in prison, was a white American named Aimee Bock, but a majority of the more than seventy people convicted were Somali Americans. "We had this huge problem, and we were grappling with it," a former Assistant U.S. Attorney who had worked on the case told me. "And suddenly it's being used not even for political reasons but just for, like, racist reasons."



"O.K., that should fix the leak."

Cartoon by Jared Nangle

In mid-November, *City Journal* published an article by Christopher Rufo and Ryan Thorpe claiming that there were ties between the defendants and the Somali Islamic extremist group Al Shabab, and that some money from remittances sent back to Somalia had ended up in terrorists' hands. Right-wing pundits such as Matt Walsh began discussing the fraud as a failure of cultural assimilation. "Somalis have nothing to do with America or its culture or its history," he wrote in one post. (A key source for the *City Journal* article later described the claims of aiding terrorism as "poetic

license”; Joe Thompson, the lead prosecutor in the Feeding Our Future case, said publicly that there was “no indication” it had ever happened.) On November 21st, Trump, citing the existence of “Somali gangs,” posted on Truth Social that he would rescind Temporary Protected Status for Somalis in Minnesota. A couple of weeks later, he described Ilhan Omar—the four-term Democratic congresswoman from Minneapolis who came to the U.S. as a refugee from Somalia—as “garbage.”

Many of the Minnesota officials and activists I spoke with were not all that surprised when the federal government launched the surge in December. “Trump has said a lot of really abusive, horrible things about the Somali community,” Keith Ellison, Minnesota’s attorney general, told me. “It was an inevitable situation.” At first, the *ICE* agents focussed their deportation efforts on Somali businesses and neighborhoods, but the Administration had overlooked one crucial fact about the vast majority of the Somali community in Minnesota. “These are American citizens. They’re here legally. They got here on Delta,” Jacob Frey told me. “Once the agents realized that,” he continued, “they diverted their attention to Latino people and Southeast Asian people and everybody else.”

Over all, Minnesota has a relatively small number of undocumented immigrants, around a hundred thousand people. But the motive behind Operation Metro Surge may have been something else entirely. “I think Donald Trump just hates that he lost Minnesota three times,” Tim Walz told me. “He personally hates our progressive policies, and they decided that Minnesota was going to be a target, and it escalated from there.” Still, as David Wilson, a local immigration attorney, observed, “I just don’t think all of us really at the time saw the scale of it coming, or how committed they were to the bit.”

Luis Argueta, Jr., the communications director of Unidos MN, a Minnesota immigrant-rights organization, said the initial rumor

was that the Trump Administration would be sending a hundred agents. “And we’re freaking out,” he told me. “We’re, like, ‘Oh, my God, one hundred agents!’ ”

The first agents to arrive from out of town seemed poorly trained to handle local opposition. Minnesotans who recorded videos of *ICE* arrests were threatened with Tasers, pepper-sprayed, shoved to the ground, or arrested. The agents would make disparaging comments—in declarations submitted in an A.C.L.U. lawsuit, a Somali American U.S. citizen who was taken to the Bishop Henry Whipple Federal Building, where *ICE* had set up its headquarters, said an agent had told him that “Somalis drained Minnesota” and “should go back home”; another observer stated that, when he’d blown a whistle, he had been asked, “Are you getting raped right now? Is that a rape whistle?” There were signs, too, that agents might not be responsible with their firearms. On December 18th, an agent accidentally discharged his gun in a hotel room, hitting the headboard of a bed in the room next door. On December 21st, another agent fired shots at a Cuban national after he’d fled arrest. (D.H.S. claimed that the man had hit two agents with his car and that the shots had been fired in self-defense.)



Natalie Ehret, a former attorney and a self-described suburban soccer mom, founded Haven Watch, which offers support to detainees after their release from custody.

The day after Christmas, a conservative YouTuber and self-described independent journalist named Nick Shirley released a video that would go on to amass almost a hundred and fifty million views. In it, he drives to about a dozen publicly funded Minneapolis child-care centers operated by Somali Americans. Some appear to be empty and closed; at others, the people answering the door deflect Shirley's demands for information about enrolling a fictional child named "Joey." Trump Administration officials promoted the video, and Noem posted that Homeland Security Investigations agents were "on the ground" looking into day-care centers. (A state agency later visited nine of the centers in the video and found that they "were operating as expected," but, in

April, federal agents executed search warrants at twenty Minnesota day cares suspected of fraud; one day-care owner featured in Shirley's video was charged in the Feeding Our Future case and has since pleaded guilty.)

Before the surge, the regional *ICE* office had a hundred and ninety staff members overseeing five states; over the course of January, about three thousand agents passed through the St. Paul field office, more than the ten largest Minneapolis-St. Paul metro-area police forces combined. They were joined by another thousand agents from C.B.P., including a large contingent from Border Patrol, led by their “commander-at-large,” Gregory Bovino. The deployment of Border Patrol officers to the interior was unique to the surges, which began in Los Angeles in June, 2025, and the officers had become known for their volatile behavior in urban environments. A former Assistant U.S. Attorney described the ground plan in Minnesota: “They were, like, ‘Occupy Minneapolis like it was Falluja.’ ”

Good's killing soon became the biggest news story in the country—one poll found that eighty per cent of registered voters had watched video footage of it—but the Administration blocked attempts to investigate the case. Mary Moriarty, the county attorney for Hennepin, which encompasses Minneapolis, told me that her office had initially discussed a joint investigation with the U.S. Attorney's office, the F.B.I., and the Minnesota Bureau of Criminal Apprehension, as was typical. Then, according to Moriarty, the B.C.A. was informed that there would be no coöperation and was denied access to evidence. “We were told that that came from the Administration,” she said.

Within a week, Todd Blanche, then the Deputy Attorney General, announced that no criminal civil-rights investigation into Good's killing would take place. Department of Justice sources leaked to the press that the department was instead, in a chilling turn, planning to investigate Becca Good, Renée's wife, for a potential

charge of assaulting, resisting, or impeding a federal officer, and to look into her ties to activist networks that monitored *ICE* agents. The prospect set off a wave of internal turmoil: six lawyers from the Minnesota U.S. Attorney's office who'd reportedly been tasked with the investigation resigned. These included members of the office's upper management and Joe Thompson, the lead on the benefits-fraud case that was the ostensible reason for the surge in the first place.

By then, the government's priorities were already familiar to local prosecutors. Andrew Winter met me one slushy morning in February at a Caribou Coffee in South Minneapolis. Winter had retired from the Minnesota U.S. Attorney's office in August, 2025, several months before the *ICE* surge began. A tall man with a laconic Midwestern affect, he was a career civil servant. "I've never worked in the private sector," he told me, with evident pride.

Winter said that the emphasis on immigration enforcement had started early in Trump's second term. Initially, there was the executive order that Trump signed in February, 2025, declaring that he and the Attorney General would now provide "authoritative interpretations of the law" that the rest of the executive branch had to follow. Winter's office soon saw a marked rise in requests to build illegal-reentry cases, in which deported immigrants who return to the U.S. are tried in U.S. criminal court instead of simply getting deported again. Winter described the ensuing "pressure campaign" as "aggressive and overt." The message, he said, was "We're doing business differently because *ICE* has this new authority in town."

There were other changes as well. Winter was the section chief for national security, overseeing cases involving assaults on federal officers. "In the old days, this would be an area where we, as prosecutors, would use our discretion," Winter told me. As quotas for immigration arrests increased that spring, he was asked to press felony charges for even minor aggressions against agents. "If the

Administration heard about it, they'd be, like, 'You have to charge everything,' " the former Assistant U.S. Attorney in the Minnesota office told me.

Winter recalled that he had been told, in the early spring of 2025, to bring a felony assault charge in a case where an *ICE* officer was left with "a visible welt but not grievous injury" after the arrest of an immigrant who was a convicted felon. "It was just kind of part of the wrestling match," Winter said, of the welt. He tried to argue that the case wasn't worth the effort: "I'm, like, 'I get to call this ball,' and they're, like, 'No, you don't.' "

Winter acquiesced, he told me, saying, "All right, let's investigate the shit out of this thing." As he interviewed witnesses, "more questions were raised than were answered about what exactly happened," as he put it. Winter doubted that a grand jury would side with *ICE*. "I made my pitch," he said, "and the upshot of that meeting was 'Yeah, you know what? Misdemeanor sounds good.' " He started filing the paperwork only to learn that the detainee had been deported weeks before. The entire investigation had been a waste of time. "It was very emblematic," Winter said. "It was such a nothing burger. This is stupid shit for the chief of national security to be spending his or her time on."

Then came the surge. As *ICE* agents took to the streets and clashed with residents, the pressure to charge activists with assault grew. On January 12th, Gregory Bovino held a call with U.S. Attorneys in Minnesota in which he reportedly expressed anger about their restraint on the issue. But many people in the U.S. Attorney's office had been seeing the confrontations firsthand and thought that some claims of assault might have been exaggerated. It was a pattern that had been established in other cities: the news site *Block Club Chicago* found, in a review of incident reports released by court order after the *ICE* surge in Chicago, in the fall of 2025, that "agents regularly counted a single action by a civilian—such as kicking a tear-gas canister back at agents—as multiple assaults, one

for each agent present, regardless of whether an included agent was actually impacted.” In one such report, a single tear-gas cannister kicked back was recorded as forty-four assaults.

The government’s tactics met their limit in court, however, in part because *ICE* and C.B.P. field officers had little experience collecting evidence or building cases for prosecutors. “State and local police officers are good witnesses,” Bruce Nestor, a defense attorney in Minneapolis, told me. But an *ICE* agent is “not really used to doing investigations, or even making written reports,” he said. “They’re normally just grabbing individuals who are in their database as someone lacking lawful immigration status.” Nestor represented five U.S. citizens who were charged with felonies for assaulting federal immigration agents during the Minnesota surge. Four of the cases have been dismissed, and the fifth is scheduled to be dismissed in December. “That’s really unique to me in my experience in federal court going back thirty-four years,” he said.

Immigrants who were denied bond hearings began challenging mandatory-detention policies in federal court through habeas corpus, under which the government must legally justify a person’s detention. More than a thousand habeas petitions were filed in Minnesota courts between December and February (compared with only seventy-three habeas petitions during the previous year). With the loss of staff and the flood of cases, the D.O.J. had to bring in outside legal assistance, often lawyers from the military, *ICE*, or other government agencies.

“The system sucks. This job sucks,” Julie Le, who was one of the new hires in the U.S. Attorney’s office in Minnesota, said in court in early February, after a federal judge asked why the government had not followed judicial orders to release detained immigrants. “Sometimes I wish you would just hold me in contempt, Your Honor, so that I can have a full twenty-four hours of sleep.” Le, who came to the United States as a refugee from Vietnam at fourteen, had transferred to the U.S. Attorney’s office from *ICE*,

where she had represented the government in immigration court. Her first day at her new post, January 5th, coincided with the second wave of federal agents arriving in Minneapolis; the U.S. Attorney's office, she later told me, was "drowning" in habeas petitions and consistently being defeated in court. Other government lawyers avoided being transferred to the overworked office—"They don't want to put their names on losing cases," she said. (Le lost her job after her February comments.)

Minnesota judges began issuing opinions against the government. One order prevented federal agents from moving detainees out of state within seventy-two hours of being arrested; another demanded that the government return confiscated belongings to released detainees. The Trump Administration tried to portray the criticism as politically motivated. After Patrick Schiltz, the chief judge of the Minnesota federal district court, threatened to call in the acting director of *ICE* to explain why the government had not complied with nearly a hundred court orders during the surge, a D.H.S. spokeswoman described Schiltz as "just another activist judge who is clearly more concerned about politics than the safety of Minnesotans." Schiltz, a sixty-five-year-old Duluth native and a devout Catholic, had clerked under Antonin Scalia and was appointed to the federal bench by George W. Bush. "I take solace in the fact that he did not live to see me branded as a progressive activist judge," Schiltz said, of Scalia, at an event at the American Enterprise Institute in February. "It came as a surprise to me. It probably would have come as a surprise to him as well."



A U.S. Border Patrol agent holds a protester during a confrontation with federal agents in a Minneapolis neighborhood on January 21, 2026.

Within a few weeks, the number of court orders ignored by the government had reached two hundred. Schiltz issued a rare public rebuke after Daniel Rosen, the U.S. Attorney for Minnesota, argued that his office “didn’t deserve” the criticism it had been getting from the district’s federal bench. “What those attorneys ‘didn’t deserve,’ ” Schiltz wrote, “was the Administration sending 3,000 ICE agents to Minnesota to detain people without making any provision for handling the hundreds of lawsuits that were sure to follow.”

In March, the Eighth Circuit Court of Appeals sided with the government on the issue of mandatory detention, limiting the use of habeas petitions in Minnesota going forward, even as appeals courts in other districts have continued to rule the policy unconstitutional.

After Good’s death, Bre’s commitment to monitoring federal agents by car, which activists called “commuting,” became all-consuming. “I was in the chats all the time,” she told me. “I would wake up and fall asleep with my phone in my hand.” One day, her teen-age daughter, on the way to choir practice, witnessed *ICE* detaining

someone outside her bus; Bre sent her children to stay with relatives in the suburbs. She was aware that protesters were under surveillance. “My face was scanned all the time,” she said, referring to facial-recognition software used by federal agents through their phone cameras. Agents would lead activists who were following them right back to their own homes, Bre told me. “I was really fearful that something would happen to me,” she said.

As federal agents increasingly used chemical irritants on crowds, Michael Cavlan began spending less time patrolling and more time treating people who’d been hurt. He recalled a post that he’d made at the time: “It was, like, ‘Today I was pepper-sprayed twice and I was teargassed twice. It must be Tuesday.’ ” Memories of the Troubles resurfaced. “I know that smell,” he said, of the tear gas. “It wasn’t as bad as in Northern Ireland, but it wasn’t too far away from it.”

At the height of the surge, Minneapolis resembled a place hit by a hurricane: donated groceries piled in driveways and church parking lots, waiting to be distributed to people afraid to leave their houses; citizens wearing safety vests and whistles standing in groups outside local businesses and schools. At one elementary school I visited, some forty per cent of the student body had stopped attending class in person.

The immigrants arrested were picked up outside their places of work, while bringing their kids to school, at the bus stop, at the grocery store, at the laundromat. Ordinary citizens were often left to deal with the aftermath. One observer told me about witnessing the snatch-and-grab detention of a Hispanic man: *ICE* had abandoned his car in the middle of an intersection. (Witnesses sometimes call such vehicles “ghost cars.”) “It was smashed in on one side,” she said. “And his phone was on the floor of the car, and his wife was just sobbing on the line.” The observer parked the car while trying to speak to the detainee’s wife in Spanish. “There isn’t even time to let them grieve. It’s just, like, ‘All right, sorry that

your loved one got taken. When do you want to get the keys from me?’ ”

Kristi Noem had promised, as she put it in a two-hundred-and-twenty-million-dollar ad campaign promoting mass deportation, that, “if you come here the right way, your American Dream can be as big as these endless skies.” But it became clear that even immigrants who had followed every legal pathway were still at risk of getting detained. On January 9th, D.H.S. had launched a pilot program called Operation *PARRIS* (for Post-Admission Refugee Reverification and Integrity Strengthening), targeting the more than five thousand refugees in Minnesota who had not yet received green cards. Asylum seekers were also taken into custody; Alison Beckman, a senior clinician who works on the policy team at the Center for Victims of Torture, a pioneering institution that offers clinical care, told me that the center’s clients had stories of detention “strikingly similar to the ones that they tell us about what happened to them in their country—a group of masked men throwing you in a car, taking you somewhere, holding you, not telling you what’s happening.”

The detained were often quickly moved out of state. Those who managed to secure release under habeas corpus brought back accounts of harrowing, disorganized odysseys through an ad-hoc mass-detention bureaucracy. Jorge (not his real name), an Ecuadorian national in his fifties who has lived in Minnesota for more than two decades, told me that he had been flown all the way to the Guayaquil airport before *ICE* realized he’d been granted release. The plane continued to its next destination, in Peru, then returned to the U.S., while Jorge remained chained up on board. “It was twenty-eight hours in shackles,” he said. Around three weeks after his bail was posted, he was finally released in El Paso, Texas, without his phone or wallet, which *ICE* had lost. A refugee from Eritrea named Daniel (not his real name) was similarly ejected onto the streets of El Paso, after being flown there in chains. “I don’t even know where Texas is,” he told me. Daniel had arrived in the

United States with permission a year and a half before the surge, but he was detained for a “reinterview.” When he was released, a week later, it took him nearly thirty hours by train and car to get back to Minneapolis. Shortly after returning home, he received his green card in the mail.

According to *ICE* data, more than seventy-five per cent of the people arrested in Minnesota during the surge had no criminal history. Manuel (not his real name) lives with his wife and two sons in a sleepy northern suburb of Minneapolis, in a white split-level house a block from a park. The family came from Mexico in 2021, crossing the border through the desert. “I could see a better future for my kids here,” Manuel told me. When we spoke in the furnished basement of his home this spring, pieces of black foam with which the family had covered the windows during the surge still hung over a sill lined with houseplants. Manuel, who has a painting business, was detained by *ICE* one morning in mid-December, in what he believes was a random stop based on his appearance, as he pulled up to a Sherwin-Williams paint store to buy supplies. He spent most of the next two months in the Campbell County Detention Center, a jail in northern Kentucky that contracts with *ICE*, living in a cell with eighty-six other people. The shower water was scalding; the meat in the food smelled off. “You had to hold your breath to eat it,” Manuel said. (A spokesperson for D.H.S. said in an e-mail, “Any claim that there are subprime conditions at ICE detention facilities is FALSE.”)

In February, Manuel passed through detention centers in Indiana and Louisiana on his way to El Paso; he was expecting to be sent back to Mexico. But, unbeknownst to him, his wife had successfully filed a habeas petition, and he was put on a plane back to Minnesota. Manuel doesn’t speak English, and didn’t understand that he was being let go until he was released from the Whipple Building into the cold. “Thank God I met these good people who helped me and had a car waiting warm outside,” he said, of volunteers from a group called Haven Watch, who got Manuel an

Uber back to his house that night and, in the weeks that followed, assisted his family with groceries, unpaid back rent, and connections to legal services.

Haven Watch was launched after a woman named Natalie Ehret and her sons attended protests at the Whipple Building one night. “My older son noticed two girls wandering in the cold with no coats, and they didn’t have a phone,” Ehret told me. He offered to let them sit in his mother’s car and use her phone to call relatives. Ehret then went back to the Whipple Building to help other newly released detainees. “Initially, it was just me and my husband,” she told me. “When word spread, it became this massive effort with dozens of people.”

Detainees were frequently held for weeks or months; some had lost their leases, their belongings, and their jobs. “When they’re releasing people, it’s never free and clear,” Ehret said. “They’re wearing ankle monitors or under an order to self-deport.” (Both Jorge and Manuel were granted only a temporary reprieve until an immigration judge decides their cases.) When we first spoke, in February, Ehret was about to take a man to a doctor’s appointment. He had jumped from a roof in an unsuccessful attempt to evade arrest. “He broke an ankle and shattered his other foot,” Ehret said. “*ICE* made him walk on his feet for days, which did more damage.”

Ehret, a self-described suburban soccer mom, had been an attorney, but left the workforce a couple of years ago to care for her older son, who was in treatment for brain cancer. Her youngest son was still in middle school. She remembered the height of the surge as being like “trying to drink from a fire hose.”

Haven Watch has raised \$2.5 million to support detainees after they are released from custody, but there were many others like Ehret in Minneapolis: a group of parents who raised more than six hundred thousand dollars to assist immigrant families at their children’s

elementary school; a thirty-year-old actor named Sulia Rose Altenberg, who helped distribute more than a million dollars in rent relief; John Wilson, the C.E.O. of a biotech firm called Wilson Wolf, who donated twenty-nine million dollars to rent-relief efforts.

Minneapolis has long been a civic-minded metropolis, where even the choice of vegetation on highway medians can become the subject of extended public debate, in a state with a history of protest going back to the nineteenth century. The Great Northern Railway strike of 1894, organized by the union leader Eugene Debs, helped rail workers fight for better wages; the Teamsters strike of 1934, in which two Minnesota strikers were killed by police, paved the way for the passage of the National Labor Relations Act the next year. And the American Indian Movement originated in Minneapolis in 1968, establishing community patrols to monitor police who were harassing Native American groups. Each movement left behind a network of activists. During the surge, the most important of these turned out to be those founded during the upheaval that followed George Floyd's murder, when residents gathered in nearby parks to organize block associations led by captains.

After Good was shot, less than a mile away from where Floyd had been killed, these block associations set up vital new alert systems and patrols to monitor *ICE* activity using long-established group chats on Signal. As federal agents stormed the streets, they encountered a system of rapid communication on the ground, and thousands of people who had received training as legal observers.



Kayla Schultz, a twenty-five-year-old who works in health care and witnessed Alex Pretti being killed by immigration-enforcement officers, photographed in her home, May, 2026.

In mid-February, the city of Minneapolis made a preliminary estimate that the cost of the surge on the local economy had been more than two hundred million dollars. To keep businesses afloat, Minnesotans held video-game live-stream fund-raisers and organized “cash mobs” to descend on struggling local restaurants. There were symbolic actions as well. The ICE OUT! Minnesotan Ice Fishing Rally, on Lake Harriet, had sloppy joes and themed beer koozies. A coffee shop called Modern Times temporarily rebranded itself as Post Modern Times and switched to a donation-only model so that it wouldn’t have to send revenue taxes to the government. “We are done making money for the fascists that occupy our city,” the owner wrote on social media.

Ehret told me that institutional support was minimal; the Red Cross had offered her group some care packages with blankets, but, she said, “we had nowhere to put them.”

The volunteers had a growing awareness that the federal government was eager to prosecute individuals who opposed their policies. “I was using apps to make phone calls and making sure

my address wasn't listed anywhere," Ehret said. "My dad's, like, 'I lay up worrying about you every night.' "

On January 24th, Kayla Schultz woke up and decided to go commuting in her neighborhood. Schultz, who is twenty-five, works in health care and at the time had a second job as a bartender. "My life is very calm and peaceful," she told me. "I have a little orange cat, and he's kind of my little guy." She had begun volunteering, she said, because she "saw too many videos of people getting kidnapped. It was complete lawlessness—children and mothers and fathers and grandparents just getting taken off of the streets without any investigation."

Schultz got started a little earlier than usual that Saturday morning. "It was my friend's one-year-old's birthday party, and I wanted to get a couple hours in," she told me. She was driving her regular loop through Whittier—a neighborhood of immigrants, working-class families, young professionals, and students who attend the Minneapolis Institute of Art—when word came in over Signal about a confrontation just two minutes away.

Schultz drove up as a group of agents was arresting an anti-*ICE* observer in the middle of the street. The agents "kind of had them on the ground," she said. (The person, Wynnne Savageford, would later describe being tackled, dragged face down, and handcuffed.) Schultz leaned on her horn. An agent threatened to arrest her for honking. "I don't listen to illegal orders," she told me. "Basically, I told him to fuck off." A car coming from the other direction started honking, too. The agent "punched the moving car," Schultz noted, so Schultz yelled something about "who was doing the illegal things here." Her window was cracked open an inch. "He got all up in my face and screamed at the top of his lungs, 'You fucking cunt!'"

Just when it seemed that the agents were packing up, Schultz heard a commotion. In the video she recorded from her car, two women

in winter coats can be seen confronting an agent by a doughnut shop called Glam Doll. The agent begins herding them toward the other side of the street. “Things started to get violent,” Schultz said. “And then, within minutes, things just devolved into pepper spray.” She watched as agents pushed three observers—the two women had been joined by a bearded man in a tan coat—directly in front of her vehicle. In her video, the man steps between the agents and one of the women. An agent douses him at close range with pepper spray. “And that,” Schultz said, “is when they dogpiled Alex Pretti and shot him.” He was shot ten times in five seconds.

Pretti, a thirty-seven-year-old nurse who worked in the intensive-care unit of the local Veterans Affairs hospital, died from his wounds. Jesus Ochoa and Raymundo Gutierrez, the agents who fatally shot him, had been deployed to Minnesota from C.B.P. units in Texas. In the hours following Pretti’s death, the Trump Administration stuck to its usual script. Pretti had been carrying a permitted weapon, which remained holstered during the exchange; another video appears to show an agent removing it from Pretti’s belt moments before he was killed. But, within four hours, Stephen Miller described Pretti as a “would-be assassin” and a “domestic terrorist”; Kristi Noem claimed that Pretti, while “brandishing” a weapon, had “attacked” agents; and Gregory Bovino said, “This looks like a situation where an individual wanted to do maximum damage and massacre law enforcement.”

Videos taken that day from multiple perspectives, however, show Pretti being held on the ground and an agent pepper-spraying him before pulling out his gun and shooting him point-blank. In another video that went viral, Stella Carlson, the woman filming, starts yelling over and over, “What the fuck did you just do?” She pleads for an ambulance. “You’re fucking killing us!” she finally shouts.

After the shooting, Schultz found herself in the driver’s seat of a car facing what she described as a “bunch of really anxious, trigger-happy agents.” She told me, “I can’t remember being

intentional about almost anything that I was doing other than checking at least twenty times that my car was still in park.” The agents ordered her to leave. The shooting had happened so close to her front bumper that she had to put her car in reverse to get out. She tried to do so carefully, in order “not to make anyone so nervous that they felt like they had to kill me,” as she put it. She drove less than a block and then pulled over. “Just because—what do you do?” she asked. “Go home after that?”



Michael Cavlan, a registered nurse and a volunteer street medic who was at the scenes of both Renée Good's and Alex Pretti's killings, photographed at George Perry Floyd Square on the anniversary of Floyd's death.

At the moment of the shooting, Bre was already on her way to the scene, responding to one of the same Signal alerts about agents in

the area. It was the second time that she showed up in the immediate aftermath of a shooting in a month. “I could see E.M.S. arriving and starting to do first aid on him,” she said.

Locals gathering at the site of Pretti’s murder were stunned and furious. “I ceased to be me,” a Whittier resident, who asked to remain anonymous, told me. She and her friends were shouting at the agents. “I just kept saying, ‘How can you live with yourself?’ ” Bre told me that, even as agents started flooding the scene, she saw one group bundle into a Jeep Wagoneer and drive out.

The calls to 911 that morning document residents’ growing frustration with local law enforcement. Federal agents began unleashing rubber bullets, flash-bangs, and tear gas on the crowd. “There’s bombs going off,” a caller reports, referring to the flash-bangs. “You guys gotta get down there.” The operator reassures the caller that there are responders at the scene. “I’m not seeing anyone,” the caller tells her. “It’s Afghanistan. This is insane.”

Michael Cavlan was there as federal agents filled the frigid morning air with tear gas; rinsing people’s eyes in subzero temperatures was ill-advised, so he set up a triage area inside the bathroom of a restaurant called the Copper Hen. He believes that law enforcement jammed cell service; his calls and texts home wouldn’t go through. “I’m male, I’m a nurse, I carry,” he told me, meaning that he had gone there armed. When he finally arrived home that afternoon, his wife was frantic. “She thought it was me,” he said.

A few days later, a video emerged of Pretti kicking the back of an *ICE* vehicle in an earlier altercation. “Alex Pretti’s stock has gone way down,” Trump wrote. At the same time, more information began to emerge about Pretti. He had grown up in Green Bay, Wisconsin, where he was a Boy Scout and sang in the Green Bay Boy Choir. Colleagues at the V.A. attested to his commitment to his profession. “I want the world to know they murdered a fucking

amazing guy,” a doctor named Dimitri Drekonja, who worked with Pretti, told me. Pretti was an avid mountain biker, and the two had been planning to go biking together once the weather turned warm. “He was a super-competent nurse,” Drekonja said. “He would tell you exactly what was going on, what he was worried about, to give you a very succinct assessment, which I always appreciated.” On January 24th, Pretti’s parents, who learned about their son’s death that day through the media, had released a statement. “Alex was a kindhearted soul who cared deeply for his family and friends and also the American veterans whom he cared for as an ICU nurse at the Minneapolis VA hospital,” they wrote. “The sickening lies told about our son by the administration are reprehensible and disgusting.”

That night, a candlelight vigil for Pretti was held in Whittier Park, as temperatures remained below zero. On January 30th, more than a thousand people gathered on Lake Bde Maka Ska to spell out a giant S.O.S.

Operation Metro Surge continued for several more weeks, but in retrospect Pretti’s fatal shooting prompted the beginning of a retreat. Several Republican senators called for an investigation into his death and defended his Second Amendment right to carry a gun, as polls continued to show public opinion turning against Trump on his handling of immigration, one of the key issues on which he had successfully campaigned in 2024.

In late January, the Administration sent Tom Homan, Trump’s newly appointed “border czar,” to Minnesota to take over operations. “You could almost feel it de-escalating the minute that he came in,” Chris Madel, a Republican candidate for governor of Minnesota who’d dropped out of the race over the Party’s management of the surge, told me. “He was literally one of the only adults in the process,” Madel said, of Homan. “And I count Republicans and Democrats among the children.” Bovino, the face

of Border Patrol's aggressive strategy in Minneapolis, was sent back to California.



*“Now, can you remember which cup I trapped that wasp under? Because
I
can’t.”*

Cartoon by Ali Solomon

Tim Walz told me that he'd received a call from Trump that week. “He was just flabbergasted, saying, ‘What’s wrong with Minnesota?’ And of course I said, ‘Not a damn thing,’ and then he proceeded to tell me how it worked so well in Louisiana, and I proceeded to tell him, ‘You didn’t shoot people and execute them in the streets in Louisiana.’ ” (“We, actually, seemed to be on a similar wavelength,” Trump posted on Truth Social after the call.) Walz received a follow-up call from Susie Wiles, Trump’s chief of staff, a sign to the Governor that the Administration was “trying to figure out how to get out.”

On February 12th, Homan held a press conference at the Whipple Building. A bald and somewhat jowly man wearing a sober gray tie patterned like graph paper, he put on his reading glasses and declared that Operation Metro Surge would be ending, and that most of the out-of-state agents who had come to Minnesota would be sent home. “The Twin Cities and Minnesota in general are and will continue to be much safer for the communities here because of

what we have accomplished under President Trump's leadership," he said. The Administration's goals for mass deportation, he added, had not changed. He told protesters to tone down the "hateful rhetoric," saying that, if they didn't like what *ICE* was doing, they could "go protest Congress."

In the weeks that followed, many of the operation's main characters left office. Kristi Noem was ousted as Secretary of Homeland Security; Corey Lewandowski, a top D.H.S. adviser, also departed. (The awarding of federal contracts by him and Noem is now under investigation.) Bovino retired. Pam Bondi, the head of the D.O.J., lost her job, reportedly more for her handling of the Jeffrey Epstein files than for the legal morass that resulted from the surge in Minnesota; Trump nominated her deputy, Todd Blanche, who had announced that there would be no investigation into Good's death, to succeed her.

I had returned to New York in late January, but a few days after Homan's speech I flew back to Minneapolis. A wet snow was falling as I drove into town, snarling rush-hour traffic. Reminders of the surge were still everywhere: posters honoring Good and Pretti were plastered over billboards and on telephone poles; businesses had signs on their front doors forbidding *ICE* agents from entering. In Mercado Central, a mini-mall of Latino-owned businesses on Lake Street where I ate posole in a near-deserted cafeteria, flyers advertised a GoFundMe to help save the venue from closure. Across the street was the shuttered former home of In the Heart of the Beast Puppet and Mask Theatre, a place I had gone as a kid each spring to make papier-mâché costumes for the theatre's annual May Day Parade, a local neo-pagan ritual dating back to the seventies which has always been a little hard to explain to outsiders. Now the theatre was marked with black spray paint that read "*ICE SMALL DICK ENERGY!*"

With the number of agents in town reduced, residents tried to restart their lives. Bre helped set up support groups for people who

had been present at the scene of Good's or Pretti's death, including some, like her, who had been at both; her hope was to maintain the ties they had formed, because, she told me, "this isn't over." Those who had witnessed the violence wondered if there would be any kind of legal consequences. The D.O.J. had announced at the end of January that there would be a federal investigation into Pretti's shooting, but had offered few specifics since then. "I have doubts that it's gonna go anywhere, or be allowed to go anywhere, by our government," Kayla Schultz said. ("This matter remains under active investigation," a spokesperson for D.H.S. told me.)

Jonathan Ross, the agent who killed Good, reportedly continues to work as an *ICE* agent in another jurisdiction. Jesus Ochoa and Raymundo Gutierrez, the agents who shot Pretti, were placed on administrative leave. D.H.S. has still not officially named the agents responsible for either killing. "We've been asking them these very simple questions since the beginning—'Who killed Alex?' They won't tell us," Steve Schleicher, an attorney representing the Pretti family, told me. He added that the family has "basically been ignored by the feds" and has never been contacted by them. "They murdered our child," Susan Pretti, Alex's mother, recently told ABC News. "People need to be held responsible when they murder people in this country. Period."

In the absence of federal cooperation, Mary Moriarty, the Hennepin County Attorney, told me that her office had created a public portal to collect evidence and testimonies from witnesses. She is also pursuing other cases of misconduct by *ICE* agents during the surge. On April 16th, she charged an *ICE* agent from Maryland named Gregory Donnell Morgan, Jr., with two felony counts of second-degree assault for pointing a gun at two citizens on a highway a couple of miles from the Whipple Building.

According to court records, Morgan was hired in the fall of 2025 and deployed to the surge in late January. Ryan Pacyga, Morgan's Minneapolis-based attorney, told me, "*ICE* has these guys rent

vehicles, like you and I would go to Avis or Budget, and drive them up here.” Pacyga argued that Morgan had been operating in a “hostile environment,” without the tools of a law-enforcement officer, such as sirens, an intercom, or floodlights, and that he had been scared. “If you were an *ICE* agent and you’re told, ‘Get up here in a rental vehicle’ and ‘This is a really dangerous area,’ wouldn’t you be scared?” he asked. He suggested that Morgan was being used as a “test case” for state prosecutors considering bringing charges against federal officers for their actions in Minneapolis. “All eyes are on this one,” Pacyga said. “I feel a little bit like he’s a political prisoner, if you will, or a pawn in a much larger battle between two opposing movements, and he’s just caught in the middle.”

On May 18th, Moriarty’s office charged Christian Castro, the Texas-based *ICE* agent who’d shot Julio Sosa-Celis through a closed door and claimed that he was attacked, with second-degree assault and with falsely reporting a crime. He was arrested later that month, in Texas, but was released from jail on August 27th, after Greg Abbott, the governor of Texas, refused to extradite him back to Minnesota, a decision upheld by a federal judge. Whether the federal government allows the state to subpoena federal witnesses, such as the agents involved in these cases, may indicate how any charges against the officers who killed Renée Good and Alex Pretti might proceed.

“J. D. Vance has repeatedly said that federal officers or agents have absolute immunity, and that’s simply not true,” Moriarty told me. “The law is that if somebody—and it doesn’t matter who they work for—violates state law in Minnesota, we certainly have the right and the jurisdiction to charge.” The standoff between the state and the federal government that this could create, she acknowledged, is “complex and really kind of unheard-of.”

In July, after months of failed negotiations, the federal government turned over evidence from the Good and Pretti shootings to

Moriarty's office, including, she said, body-cam footage, interviews with agents, and Good's vehicle.

"We are making very good progress on these cases, particularly Pretti right now," Moriarty told me. "We want to make sure we get this right."

As Tom Homan had promised, the end of Operation Metro Surge did not curtail the Administration's campaign of mass detention and deportation. In June, Republicans in Congress approved another seventy billion dollars in immigration-enforcement funding, which did not come with any of the accountability measures proposed after the Minnesota surge, such as requiring judicial warrants for home entries, restricting agents from wearing masks, or making body cameras mandatory. Speaking in front of photographs of Good, Pretti, and Liam Conejo Ramos, the five-year-old wearing a bunny hat whose detention made national news in January, Tina Smith, the senator from Minnesota, asked Congress if it had forgotten "the great damage done by this rogue, dangerous, secret police force" and criticized "the complete failure to agree to even the most basic guardrails on *ICE*, the same kind of guardrails that your local police department agrees to live by every single day." In July, the government detained more than forty-nine thousand people, the highest monthly total of Trump's second term. The same month, *ICE* agents shot and killed two more people, both in their vehicles: Lorenzo Salgado Araujo, an undocumented Mexican immigrant who had lived and raised a family in Texas for more than thirty years, and Joan Sebastián Durán Guerrero, a Colombian living in Maine who had a three-year-old child. (A D.H.S. spokesperson said that both shootings are being investigated.)

In April, I visited the Fort Snelling Immigration Court, which is housed inside the Whipple Building and serves Minnesota and the Dakotas. The court observers I met there, who have run a monitoring project since 2017, told me that it is increasingly difficult for anyone to get legal status. "We have such a long frame

of reference of how it used to function,” Amy Lange, the manager of the project, told me. “How proceedings unfolded, how our laws were implemented, what procedures and protections people were afforded. And then we just saw it all explode.” In a courtroom, I watched as a judge repeatedly informed immigrants seeking asylum that they would likely not qualify. “Just because something bad happened to you, that’s not persecution under the law,” he said.



“Every minute he’s in college will break my heart and cost us six dollars.”
Cartoon by Paul Noth

The newest judge at the court, hired by the Executive Office for Immigration Review, is an attorney named Nathan Hansen, who had no previous experience in immigration law; the *Minnesota Reformer*, a local news organization, reported that, in 2024, Hansen deleted more than a hundred thousand social-media posts about subjects such as Pizzagate and the “Haitian invasion of Ohio.” Earlier this summer, news broke that D.H.S. would reopen a shuttered jail owned by the private-prison contractor CoreCivic in Appleton, Minnesota; it will serve as a sixteen-hundred-bed detention center to support the *ICE* field office in St. Paul. After a

national push by *ICE* to convert warehouses into detention centers received widespread public backlash, the reopening of private prisons, many of which were shut down after the Biden Administration largely banned them in the federal system, has become a more discreet way for the government to expand its detention capacity. At least sixteen such facilities have started up again since 2025, with potential plans for more in North Carolina and Oklahoma, among other states.

Meanwhile, under the pretext of preventing fraud, the federal government has repeatedly withheld funding to Minnesota, freezing, for example, nearly two hundred million dollars of Medicaid spending for the state in July. The government has also investigated Tim Walz, Jacob Frey, and Keith Ellison for conspiring to impede federal immigration enforcement; subpoenas demanding information from them were blocked by a federal judge earlier this summer. The D.O.J., too, has kept its sights on Minnesota. It has sought to gain access to the state's voter-registration databases under the pretext of a criminal probe into ostensible noncitizen voters. It has also aggressively targeted activists. By the end of February, it had charged thirty-nine people in connection with an anti-*ICE* protest at Cities Church, in St. Paul, on January 18th. (The case is ongoing.) The D.O.J. has also charged more than forty Minnesotans with impeding or assaulting federal officers. As of July 30th, at least nineteen of these cases have been dismissed, in some instances after sworn affidavits by agents were directly contradicted by video footage or other evidence. "It is without a doubt in the court's mind," a federal magistrate judge said, that one agent "did not have any personal knowledge of the events described in the affidavits that he submitted to the court."

Emmett Doyle is a burly and bearded union carpenter and musician in Minneapolis who writes and performs folk music about the struggles of the working class. His instruments include a balalaika and a penny whistle, and his website shows him onstage wearing a kaffiyeh, a canvas Carhartt jacket, and a baseball cap that reads

“Class War Veteran.” Doyle has long offered his musical services at picket lines and protests in Minneapolis, but before the surge began in Minnesota he had stepped back a little, feeling what he described as “activist burnout.” He told me, “I was just working as a carpenter, playing open mikes, and trying to set myself up for the next stage of my life.”

That changed after Renée Good was killed. Doyle went to the site of her shooting that morning. “Like a lot of the rest of the crowd, I was shouting at the *ICE* agents, you know, calling them murderers,” he said. He noticed at one point that he was standing on red-stained ice. “I realized later that after Renée was shot someone had dragged her from her car to perform CPR, and I had actually been standing on her frozen blood for a significant part of that morning.” Doyle began patrolling the streets of his neighborhood and wrote a series of surge-related protest songs, including his most popular, “Dick Blizzard,” about a day that protesters threw dildos at agents outside of the Whipple Building.

On Tuesday, June 16th, Doyle was sitting in his car, typing the address of that day’s job into his phone, when a dozen or so armed federal agents suddenly swarmed his vehicle. “They’re pulling me out, and I’m confused as hell,” he said. He was one of fifteen people charged that day with federal crimes in Minneapolis, including conspiracy to impede or injure a federal officer, in part through the use of rapid-response networks and Signal chats.

On the way to the federal courthouse, Doyle recalled, the agents asked him where he got his tattoos. “I go, ‘Look, guys, I’m entirely certain that if I tell you who did my tattoos she’ll never ink me again.’ ” One of the agents told Doyle that he liked punk bands, such as Slipknot and Korn. The questions became more leading, with the agents inquiring about the activist scene. “It was all an attempt on their part to elicit information from me,” Doyle said.

At the courthouse, he was locked in a cell, where he started singing Irish Republican jail songs. A request was shouted from a cell down the hall for “Dick Blizzard.” “I hear this chorus of laughter and all these voices, and I realized, ‘Oh, I know that person, and I know that person,’ ” Doyle said. “They selected just a cross-section of, like, mostly rank-and-file union organizers and artists, musicians,” he added. “It did seem like they disproportionately targeted queer people, but also, you know, it’s Minneapolis. We’re, like, the queerest city in America.”

For all his jocularly, the charges against Doyle are serious, carrying a potential sentence of six years in prison. Among the groups taking credit for the arrests was Joint Task Force Vanguard, a D.O.J. initiative to target groups that promote “anti-Americanism, anti-capitalism, and anti-Christianity,” as Trump put it in a memorandum last fall. Doyle had tracked the cases of activists charged with federal crimes for protests at Broadview, an *ICE* facility in Chicago; the charges have since been dismissed. He also followed the trial that recently convicted eight people of providing material support to terrorists and other charges related to an anti-*ICE* protest at the Prairieland Detention Facility, in Alvarado, Texas, during which a protester shot and wounded a police officer; the defendants, whom the D.O.J. referred to as “Antifa terrorists,” were sentenced to a combined four hundred and fifty years in prison, the government’s first major success in prosecuting what it has begun calling “far-left extremism.”

Still, Doyle’s arrest took him by surprise—the surge had ended months earlier, and he had not been one of the hundreds of U.S. citizens arrested at its height. In the government’s indictment, Doyle is described as passing out, from the back of a U-Haul rental van, shields decorated with the Palestinian flag or the words “*ICE* Out” during a protest at the Whipple Building. During a training for activists, he was said to have called using shields a way of “fighting with the fascists rather than just going at them just chest to chest.” He is also named as the live musical act at the tenth-

anniversary party of the Ray Rainbolt Memorial Shooting Club, a local organization described in the indictment as an “Antifa affinity group” that offers L.G.B.T.Q.-friendly firearms training.

Most of the fifteen people named in the June 16th indictment have been released and are awaiting trial. The Administration seems intent on prosecuting widely used protest strategies—such as blockades outside federal buildings, which are typically charged as misdemeanors—as violent crimes against the government. “It’s an attempt to use an antiterrorist framework that’s been used by the government abroad against political opponents at home,” Gabe Van de Water, another one of the arrestees, told me. Federal agents picked up Van de Water at a gas station as he was on his way to his first day of work at a delivery company. The indictment notes that he helped plan and fund-raise for a March 1st protest at the Whipple Building in which demonstrators blockaded a nearby street. “They want to call us extremists,” he said.

On July 16th, the State Department hosted a “Ministerial on the Resurgence of Political Terrorism,” during which Stephen Miller described “radical leftists” as “enemies of civilization” and “deformed.” “Here in the United States,” he said, “we have taken the necessary and essential action of formally recognizing left-wing violence as a form of political terrorism.” In grand-jury hearings, the government alleged that participants in the conspiracy against immigration enforcement in Minnesota included the A.F.L.-C.I.O., the Democratic Socialists of America, and a Minneapolis bike shop called the Grease Pit.

Doyle sees his arrest as evidence of the government’s fundamental misunderstanding of the resistance in Minneapolis. “They seem to think that there’s this cancerous little cell, and that if they cut it out then all the people of Minneapolis will go back to, you know, passively accepting jackbooted thugs in our streets,” he said. He thought that agents had acted in an unwarranted militarized fashion. “I think a huge part of fascism is performative violence.

It's the aestheticization of brutality, and it goes hand in hand with the broader logic of Metro Surge, which was 'Flood the streets of this notoriously rebellious city'—you know, the place of the 2020 George Floyd uprising—'with just the most violent, unhinged, brutal officers in Trump's private army,' and then have the whole nation watch as they brutalize us. And what they got instead was the whole nation watched as Minneapolis stood up and showed the country how to resist them."

On July 24th, six months after Alex Pretti's death, his mother posted on Instagram to mark the anniversary. "No-one has been held accountable, no apologies, not a single phone call from any government official, hospital personnel, or the Mpls police dept.," she wrote. "How does one live knowing that I have no power to change what has happened?"

The city has sought catharsis in its own ways. This year's May Day Parade ended, as it does each year, with a ceremony before a small lake in Powderhorn Park, where puppeteers celebrate the return of spring. This year's ceremony also reenacted the winter's grief: a family hiding in their house; cardboard *ICE* agents; puppeteers with whistles; the deaths of Good and Pretti. I know, as someone who has lived away from Minneapolis for many years, that outsiders might see all this as idealistic; I also know how deep the sincerity goes.

"We live out the world as we want it to be, not as it is," Sulia Rose Altenberg, the organizer of a rent-relief fund, told me, of the culture in Powderhorn, where she grew up. "We're, like, 'What if we lived in a utopia where puppets drove civic action?' "

During a stretch of warm days this spring, I saw Minneapolis residents sprawled out in the sun in the city's many parks. Baseball season had started again, and the anti-*ICE* posters plastering downtown now incorporated the Twins logo. I stopped at the memorials for Renée Good and Alex Pretti, still maintained in the

places where they had died. Good’s had a sign that said “I’m not mad at you, dude”—a paraphrase of her last words to Jonathan Ross before he shot her. Pretti’s had a banner. “Rest in Power, Alex,” it read. “Any Righteous Person Would Have Done the Same.” ♦

Emily Witt is a staff writer at The New Yorker. Her memoir “[Health and Safety](#)” received the Los Angeles Times’ 2025 Christopher Isherwood Prize for Autobiographical Prose.

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/what-happened-in-minneapolis>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

[American Chronicles](#)

The MAHA Custody Battle

A father wanted to vaccinate his children. Their mother didn't. Then the kids got sick.

By [Ruby Cramer](#)

August 31, 2026



Michael Lee Horrocks believes that, during the pandemic, Leah Stelly went down a TikTok rabbit hole and never came out. “I feel like I’m living in crazy town,” he said.

Illustration by Keith Negley

On a Thursday evening in April, at a date and time that had been determined by a family-court judge, Michael Lee Horrocks drove to his ex-wife’s house, in the eastern panhandle of West Virginia, to collect their three children for the start of spring break. It was a ten-

day holiday, longer than the usual weekends that he had been granted under the terms of his custody agreement. Michael, who is thirty-four, had come to think of himself as “the fun parent.” He drives a Harley-Davidson Road Glide and, online, goes by Kneepatch, a persona that he styles with graphic tees, chunky mixed-metal rings, and an arm of American-traditional tattoos. That weekend, he planned to take the kids to a monster-truck show. Michael had been married to their mother, Leah Stelly, for nine years, until the previous spring. Now he saw her only when they handed off the children. Most of these exchanges happened quickly, in a tense near-silence. But, other times, the pickups became hostile. When Michael and Leah did fight, it was usually about the kids’ medical care.

That day, Michael had received a call from the nurse at his eldest child’s school. Keith, who is eight, appeared to have a bad case of pink eye. The nurse told Michael that she couldn’t get hold of Leah and that Keith needed to see a doctor as soon as possible. Michael lived in a city called Charles Town, more than an hour away, and he wasn’t supposed to pick the kids up until 6 *P.M.* He imagined that Leah had been treating the pink eye with a natural home remedy, because, as he later told me, “she’s all holistic” and “has, uh . . . what did she call it? A ‘crunchy mom’ outlook.”

At the pickup, Keith looked worse than Michael had expected. “His whole eye was swollen up, almost out of his head,” he said. His middle child, Donnie, who is five, also had watery eyes. His daughter, Star, who is four, seemed fine. By then, Leah had received antibiotics from Keith’s primary-care provider. For Michael, this was another source of concern. The kids saw a physician assistant, rather than a pediatrician. Michael believed that this had to do with the fact that many doctors refuse to see unvaccinated children. Keith, who had been ordered by a judge to start public school in January, had received some of his standard immunizations, including shots for measles, mumps, and rubella. But Donnie and Star were unvaccinated.

Leah had undergone several transformations in her life—shifts that she described to me as “awakenings.” One of them had led her to the belief that vaccines were dangerous, and to a broader world view that aligned with the Make America Healthy Again movement. Her particular *MAHA* leanings were laced with a kind of freethinking, hippie spirituality. She believed that she had manifested her daughter into existence and that Star’s arrival, via home birth at 2:22 *p.m.* in 2022, was a sign for 222, an “angel number” in numerology signifying alignment and cosmic timing. She dressed in vintage seventies clothing and wore her hair long, in ringlets. Online, she had posted about Robert F. Kennedy, Jr., “b!g ph@rm@,” and living a “non-tox” life style, and recorded lessons for her eleven thousand followers on divine femininity and receiving messages from the universe. In her videos, she rings herself in fuzzy golden light and talks in a wispy Southern accent. The word “*TRUTH*” is tattooed high across her neck, like a choker. Below that, on her sternum, is a fine-line rendering of the Seed of Life, a sacred geometric symbol.

Michael did not share Leah’s *MAHA* sensibility, but he was no liberal scold. He had nonspecific theories about the pandemic, telling me that it “duped a lot of people in a lot of different ways,” and he had refused the *covid* vaccine. He liked to take the kids to McDonald’s, even though—or possibly because—he knew that it drove Leah crazy. The first time we met, in the parking lot of a West Virginia chain called Tudor’s Biscuit World, he wore a graphic T-shirt that said “*Fuck Your Mask*” across the back and was chain-smoking Marlboro Black Reds. The kids were tucked in by his side, still sleepy from staying up the night before watching TV. Star meowed at me by way of greeting. They were sweet and polite children. Later on, as we talked, Michael received a pointed TikTok from Leah about exes who try to put you down when, really, they’re just jealous of your aura. Michael watched for a few seconds, then swiped away. “I’m burnt out on Leah,” he said. “I don’t go clicking on her stuff.”

Michael and Leah lived much of their lives online. To varying degrees, they'd both become microinfluencers. As Kneepatch, Michael maintained a Facebook page about biking, with a following of almost fifty thousand. During the week, he worked as an underground-petroleum-tank specialist, doing installations and repairs at gas stations across the mid-Atlantic. The nickname was a nod to this work: the job required him to kneel on the concrete, "opening up manholes and shit," which wore holes in his jeans. Kneepatch shared real-time updates about his bike trips and his personal life. "Like 'The Osbournes,' " he said, referring to the reality show about Ozzy Osbourne and his family. Kneepatch's fans knew about his divorce; his new girlfriend, Brianna; the time his bike broke down in Las Vegas; the sunset in Ohio that made him believe in God; and the running sex jokes he made about feet, with pictures of himself giving Brianna a pedicure or smoking a cigarette held between her toes. His followers were also acquainted with Michael's three children, who featured prominently in the Kneepatch adventurescape, sometimes riding with him on his Harley, outfitted in tiny helmets.

Several months before spring break, Michael had appealed his custody agreement. In addition to more time with the children, he wanted to control their medical care. Specifically, he told me, he wanted his kids to receive the same basic vaccinations that he had received when he was a child. He was especially worried about Donnie, who had spinal muscular atrophy, or S.M.A., a progressive genetic disease that weakened his muscles and left him vulnerable to respiratory infections.

That weekend, at the monster-truck show, Michael gave Keith a pair of sunglasses with mirrored lenses, to cover his swollen eyes. They hung back from the crowd, Star in a cowboy hat, Donnie in a miniature wheelchair. "Everything was fine," Michael said. "The kids had a great time."

By Wednesday, though, all three children were sick. They didn't want to get out of bed or eat, and their skin felt hot to the touch. On Friday, eight days into spring break, Michael was at work when he received a text from his mom, who was babysitting, with a picture of Donnie. He had a rash of flat, red blotches on his face and body. Michael thought it could be chickenpox, but when he sent the picture to Brianna, who had kids of her own, she told him that it wasn't a normal rash. "I've seen every rash a child can get," she told me. "I have never seen that." Michael took the boys to urgent care. Both were found to have respiratory issues and fevers of a hundred and one.

The urgent-care nurse was the first person to say the word "measles" to Michael. "I was, like, 'Holy cow, are you serious?'" he said. By 9 *p.m.*, Donnie was being seen by a doctor who described his symptoms as "textbook measles." The medical staff administered a nasal swab. The results would take several days. They could still come back negative. But Michael had already latched on to the idea that Donnie was sick—and that one person was to blame. He texted Leah, informing her that a doctor was "confident" Donnie had measles. It was only a matter of time before they would have a confirmed diagnosis, he said. Public-health officials were being notified. Keith had a faint rash—possibly a breakthrough case. Star was also showing symptoms. "We are heading home and will be monitoring all three closely," he wrote. "Given Donnie's SMA and the ages involved, we are taking this very seriously."

It is difficult to map what kind of person might one day become "vaccine hesitant." There is a wider sensibility at play. It might be awakened by a Facebook parenting group, a particular aesthetic on Instagram, a church, a homeschooling community, a wellness influencer, a detox protocol, a curiosity about the ingredients in our food, a distrust of government, or the raw force of postpartum anxiety. Any of these entry points might lead to a feeling, deep in the gut and affirmed by countless strangers on social media, that

something is poisoning our bodies and that it is up to us as individuals to wrest back control.

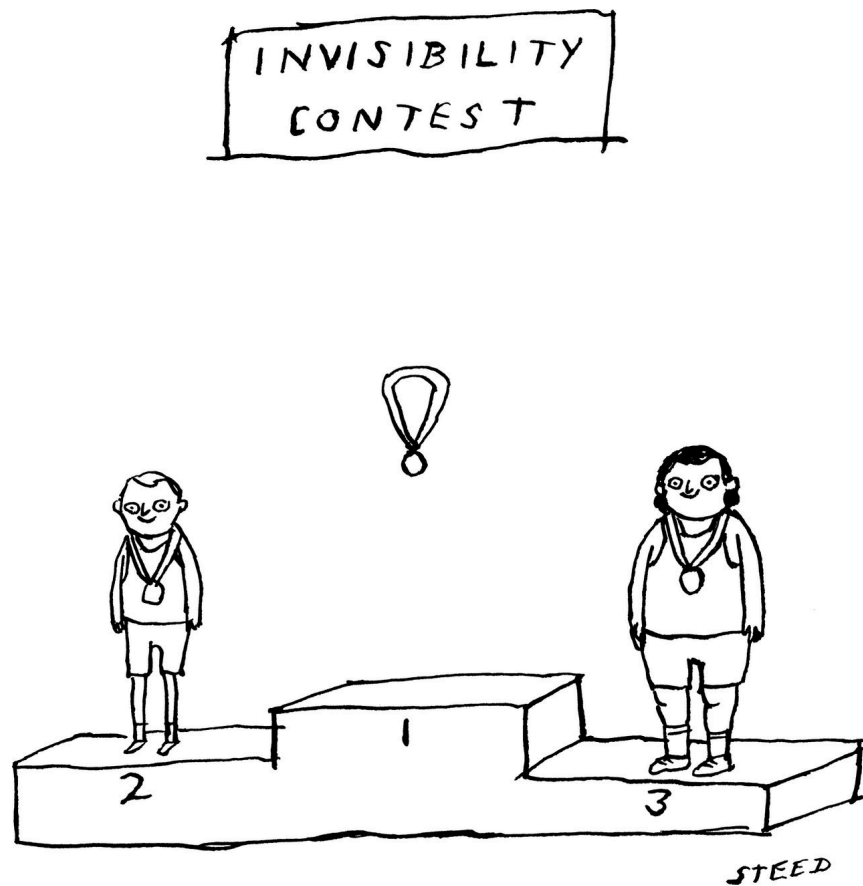
The modern anti-vax movement began, in large part, after *The Lancet* published a paper in 1998 suggesting that autism was caused by the M.M.R. vaccine. The study was found to be fraudulent; eventually, it was retracted entirely. But the confusion and fear that it unleashed was impossible to contain. Years later, the actress Jenny McCarthy popularized the idea that parental unease about vaccines was being dismissed by the medical establishment. During an appearance on “The Oprah Winfrey Show,” in 2007, she blamed her son’s autism on the M.M.R. vaccine and recounted telling her pediatrician, “I have a very bad feeling about this shot.” According to McCarthy, the doctor told her that she was being “ridiculous.” After the injection, she said, her son was changed: “Boom! The soul’s gone from his eyes.” She urged other mothers to listen to their “mommy’s instinct.”

The privileging of parental intuition over medical orthodoxy has become the emotional core of the *MAHA* coalition. Robert F. Kennedy, Jr., helped bring these concerns into the mainstream, first as an anti-vax activist, then as an independent candidate for President, in 2024. In a sign of his campaign’s fluid appeal, Democrats spent months trying to figure out whether his presence in the race helped or hurt their chances against Donald Trump. Then Kennedy dropped out and endorsed Trump. “Don’t you want a President that’s going to make America healthy again?” he said at a rally in Arizona. In return, when Trump took office again, he made Kennedy his Health and Human Services Secretary.

Many of the *MAHA* coalition’s goals are admirable: reversing chronic disease, studying chemical additives in the food supply. The movement is powerful partly because it cannot be reduced to a single tenet. “Two truths and a lie” is how I heard one Democratic strategist describe *MAHA*’s messaging. Vaccines do come with risks—there are rare adverse reactions—but they pale in

comparison to the diseases that vaccines prevent. Still, this fact is easily set aside when so many forces play on a parent's fears. Ultra-processed foods make up more than half of our daily calorie intake. Microplastics are in our water and in our bodies, and the consequences are unclear. Rates of autism are rising to previously unseen levels, owing largely to better detection and new diagnostic criteria, but the numbers are still disconcerting. Autoimmune conditions are becoming more prevalent, and we don't fully understand why. Pharmaceutical companies are driven by a desire for profits, not just the well-being of our children. Medical care is prohibitively expensive. Expert guidance is constantly changing: the theory that *covid* originated from a lab leak is disinformation, then suddenly it becomes the official stance of Joe Biden's F.B.I. and his Department of Energy. Tylenol is safe for pregnant mothers, then Trump says that it's not. It can be hard to know whom to trust.

MAHA promises answers. In the world of “crunchy” (alternative, natural) parenting—as opposed to “silky” (conventional, medicinal) or “scrunchy” (a hybrid)—there is a holistic remedy for almost any ailment. There is also genuine community and care and, tucked inside of that, a heady feeling of ascension: the knowledge that you have set yourself apart from a consumerist, toxic mainstream—or, as a group of social scientists studying vaccine hesitancy in Australia termed it, the Unhealthy Other. A mother in Virginia named Lindsay Logan told me that, when she was eight months pregnant, she attended a private screening, arranged by a mom friend, of “Vaxxed II: The People's Truth,” a movie produced by Kennedy. The theatre was cool and dark. Surrounded by like-minded mothers, watching footage of crying babies, she felt overcome by a certainty that, having chosen not to vaccinate, she was living the right way. “You're, like, ‘I'm so glad I've been enlightened,’ ” she told me. “I wasn't one of the sheep.”



Cartoon by Edward Steed

“Know better, do better” is a popular *MAHA* mantra, another way of saying D.Y.O.R., or “do your own research.” This means turning to the internet to learn about red dyes, additives, food as medicine, essential oils, and when to apply a garlic poultice to the bottom of your feet. It also means knowing how to read vaccine inserts, the technical fine print on vaccine packaging. On parenting forums, mothers remind one another that no one cares about your child more than you do. On Facebook, discussion groups foster the feeling of a countercultural underground. Pages are shut down for promoting misinformation, then reappear under new names. Conversation takes place under the veil of coded language: vaccines are referred to as “vak sees” or, more commonly, with a cupcake emoji.

The descent into a full-blown *MAHA* life style can be swift. Heather Lindstrom-Hamilton, a mother in Thousand Oaks, a wealthy city outside Los Angeles, was thirty-nine when her husband received a cancer diagnosis. He died six months later, and

Lindstrom-Hamilton was suddenly a widow caring for four children. Looking for answers about her husband's death, she was "low-hanging fruit for the anti-vax world," she told me. She came to believe that toxins had caused his cancer. She changed her diet and began telling her kids, "We don't eat cancer, and we don't drink cancer."

Soon, she fell in with a group of anti-vax moms. She recalled once driving to Ojai to pay a doctor around two thousand dollars for vaccine-exemption cards for two of her kids. She gave herself coffee enemas and took her children to a holistic chiropractor, who told her that, if their bodies were in alignment, they wouldn't be as vulnerable to illness. Chiropractors have asserted themselves as a *MAHA*-safe alternative to modern medicine. Lindstrom-Hamilton pointed me to the website of a prominent "pediatric and prenatal" chiropractor named Stanton Hom. He publicly calls himself "Dr Stanton Hom," even though he is not a medical doctor. (Hom did not respond to requests for comment.) On his website, new patients are directed to a video of Hom introducing himself by saying, "So let's be honest: if you're here, something fully isn't right."

Lindstrom-Hamilton left the anti-vax movement during the pandemic. Her moment of revelation came while tuning in to the live stream of a pastor she watched every night, Rob McCoy (the former pastor of Charlie Kirk), as he interviewed a plastic surgeon about *covid*. "I had this cognitive dissonance of, like, 'Wait a minute, we're in a pandemic, and I'm listening to a guy that does boob jobs?'" she told me. She began what she now calls "my unlearning phase." Years later, she still has a house full of expensive supplements that she no longer uses. When I asked her what she used to consume, she sent me a list of forty-three products and protocols. "It was exhausting," Lindstrom-Hamilton said.

It does not take long to notice that much of *MAHA* is trying to sell you something. A formerly vaccine-hesitant mother named Brandie Hadfield, who lives in Toronto, told me that her pursuit of natural

parenting involved spending about a decade of her life in a multilevel-marketing company called Juice Plus+, which sells capsules that it claims offer antioxidants from powdered fruits and vegetables. (Joe Schwarcz, a chemistry professor at McGill University, reviewed a study on Juice Plus+ and found that two of its capsules have the antioxidant power of only “about two to three bites of an apple.” A Juice Plus+ spokesperson said that the company’s products provide “added nutrition” but “aren’t meant to replace fruits and vegetables.”) *MAHA* encourages a certain entrepreneurial hustle. Heather Simpson, another mom who left the anti-vax movement, showed me a crew-neck sweatshirt that she had designed to sell to her followers, printed with key terms in millennial fonts: “*elderberry syrup*,” “*colloidal silver*.” The life style is up for sale on a grand scale, too. There are “agrihoods,” where families can live in healthful community with one another, including one in Georgia called Serenbe. Its founder recently claimed that none of the two hundred and forty children growing up in the community suffer from asthma, thanks to an emphasis on chemical-free living.

Lindstrom-Hamilton observed that the commodification of *MAHA* often involves rich women—in “perfect white farmhouses, with their perfectly dressed children in beige clothes”—selling their way of life to non-rich women online. After following one popular influencer on Instagram, I received an automated D.M.: “Hey friend 🤍 So glad you are here.” She had an arsenal of coupon codes to help me make a “clean swap” to a nontoxic household. While browsing, I could also watch a nine-minute video of her home birth.

This year, a D.C.-based nonprofit embarked on a study to understand what, exactly, *MAHA* has become. Among its findings was the fact that phrases like “the research shows” or “follow the science,” when deployed to combat *MAHA* talking points, are instead perceived as versions of “you think I’m stupid.” During a briefing about their study, the researchers charted the typical path

of a “worried mom” who goes online looking for answers. “The more beliefs she begins to adopt, the more the liberal community moves away/scorns her, the further she gets pulled down the pipeline,” the researchers explained. They called this phenomenon the “radicalization funnel.”

Michael and Leah met on the internet. He was living in northern Virginia and played bass in an eighties-metal cover band called Bad Habit. She lived in Texas and followed the band on MySpace. She sent him a friend request on Facebook, and he messaged her and told her that she was beautiful. In 2012, around the time that he turned twenty-one, he flew to Texas to meet her. He gave her a T-shirt that said “*Someone in Virginia Loves Me*” and, eventually, a one-way plane ticket to join him on the East Coast. As a couple, they looked like they’d arrived from another decade. Michael wore bell-bottoms, and his hair was long and curly, like Leah’s. He remembered thinking, *How often do you find people who are into old-school rock and roll?* They listened to the same records and went to shows together. “It was real simple, but that’s what we did,” Michael said. “It felt like love.” As far as he knew, Leah wasn’t particularly interested in health or wellness. But, from the start of their relationship, she was clear that the thing she wanted most in life was to become a mother.

Michael was not so sure about becoming a father. When he was born, he was given the name Gerald Lester Horrocks III, in honor of his father and his father’s father. But both men had problems with alcohol. His dad, who worked in construction, “drank heavy—real, real heavy,” Michael said. He decided that he wasn’t going to be the same way. After high school, he wrote a list of names next to a picture of himself in a notebook. He liked the name Rick, but he didn’t think he looked like a Rick. The only name that seemed to fit was Michael. He tried it out for a year, shortened Lester to Lee, then legally became Michael Lee Horrocks. He took whatever “crappy jobs” he could find. He worked at a plastics factory, a book press, a Home Depot distribution center. “I didn’t have a lot going

through my head back then,” he said. “It was more like ‘Where’s my next joint coming from? What’s the next record? Who are we jamming with?’ That was all I did. We’re talking about a person who thought he made it if he got his forklift license.”

Michael and Leah had an outdoor wedding in 2016, holding hands under an arbor draped in greenery. Leah was old-fashioned about most things in life, especially marriage and kids—her “dream and desire.” But she had begun to feel that facets of mainstream feminism were set up to mock that life style. Leah wanted to be a stay-at-home mother, and Michael was mostly supportive of the idea. “We had a ‘You name the babies, I name the dog’ kind of thing,” he said. Two years after they were married, Keith was born. Leah called him the “sunshine of my life.”

In our conversations, Leah spoke frequently about her “transformation, awakening, activation, whatever you wanna call it.” These shifts started during the pandemic, when she was pregnant with Donnie. Michael, who had been following the emergence of the virus in China through his favorite news source, a conservative aggregator called Citizen Free Press, thought that the pandemic “didn’t smell right” and that *covid* was “make-believe.” His work at gas stations continued during lockdowns, and he watched with bewilderment as people unquestioningly followed government mask mandates and as plastic barriers went up around the cash register where he bought cigarettes.

When the *covid* vaccine became available, he and Leah declined to get it. “Michael was the very first person in 2020 to have me questioning vaccines,” Leah told me. (Michael said that his concern was with the federal government pushing a relatively untested new vaccine, not with “the normal shit that we have all gotten for years.”) On Instagram, where Leah was a part of a “sixties-seventies hippie community,” some of the people on her feed were “screaming, ‘Wear your mask’ ”; others were saying, “Don’t vaccinate your kids.” Leah started to post about her vaccine

hesitancy. The more she did, the more polarizing her account became, which hardened her skepticism. Online, she met a woman who said that her son had started seizing and vomiting because of a vaccine. The woman claimed that, afterward, a doctor had pulled her aside and warned her that vaccines weren't as safe as they seemed. The story terrified Leah. When Donnie was born, she didn't vaccinate him.

Then, in the spring of 2021, Leah's elderly grandmother died. Before her death, she had received two doses of the *covid* vaccine. Leah blamed the vaccine for her death. "I know everyone dies eventually, but it didn't have to be right now," she wrote at the time. A few days later, she posted a picture mimicking pro-vaccine frames that people were adding to their Facebook profile pictures. Hers said "*PROUDLY UNVACCINATED*." In the caption, she reintroduced herself to the world, as if reborn: "I'm Leah. I'm a mother. I used to follow blindly and trust in the system with out question." She added, "Now I feel superhuman."

She quickly gained a following of anti-vaxxers. On TikTok, she held up a sign that read "*My body, my choice*." "I'm no longer your product," she wrote. "I am aware and ready to fight." She increasingly characterized her choice to be a stay-at-home mom as an act of defiance. Michael noticed that she began buying organic groceries and talking about the dangers that red dyes posed to their kids. "I'd get hollered at for giving them red lollipops," he said. "Then, all of a sudden, groceries were twice as much, because we're buying organic ketchup." Soon, pregnant with Star, Leah introduced herself to her followers once again, this time wearing a "*DEFUND FAUCI*" T-shirt. "I'm Leah," the post began. "Apparently now I am a 'raging conspiracy theorist' and an 'anti vaxxer.' "

At the time, Michael and Leah were living in a tiny, unincorporated community in West Virginia called Yellow Spring, set in a system of river valleys and forested ridges. Star was born on the couch in

the living room. By then, Michael was spending more time away from home, on his motorcycle. Leah was the parent who fed the children, changed their diapers, bathed them, and planned to homeschool them. Michael didn't question these choices. It wasn't until Donnie received a diagnosis of S.M.A., a few months after his second birthday, that Michael began to ask about the children's medical care. Donnie had started receiving an injection of a medication called Spinraza every four months. Before Spinraza's release, in 2016, S.M.A. was the leading genetic cause of infant mortality, and there was no approved treatment. The medicine was capable of stabilizing the disease—an actual miracle drug.

To be suddenly reliant on a medication “was very difficult, being somebody who is more natural-minded,” Leah said. She shared the news of the diagnosis with her followers: she remained a “‘crunchy’ mama,” she wrote, “but there is a time and place for modern medicine.” She still posted about raw milk, immune-boosting smoothies, and, as the 2024 election approached, R.F.K., Jr., and a coming “great awakening.” After Trump won, she defended those who had voted for him. She posted pictures of the sky, searching for chemtrails. “The rabbit holes run deep,” she wrote, “but once you know, you know and it all makes so much sense.”

In the spring of 2025, Michael noticed Leah using a messaging app that he didn't recognize. She seemed increasingly preoccupied with her phone, sometimes tucking it away when he approached. He thought that she was cheating on him. “I would have preferred that, honestly,” he said. “It would have been so much easier to explain.”

Late one night, he took Leah's phone to the garage behind the house and opened it. For months, he learned, she had been using WhatsApp to correspond not with a lover but with an unnamed woman who had been acting as some kind of spiritual adviser and healer. He thumbed through the messages, taking screenshots as he went.

The healer warned of “evil activities going on in the world” and offered various cleansings on Leah’s behalf. She volunteered a “protective juju” to intercept a “coming attack.” She promised to “wash the poison” from Leah’s body and talked of procuring fresh herbs with healing properties, along with a calabash for a “voodoo” to bury in the yard. Leah and the adviser called each other “sis” or “sister”; the adviser referred to Michael’s mother as a “witch.” Michael saw that the adviser had frequently asked for payments in bitcoin, ranging from fifteen to more than a hundred dollars, and that Leah, at the adviser’s request, had provided her financial-account information. In the messages, both parties referred to these payments as offerings. “It was instantly, like, ‘Whoa, what the fuck is going on?’ ” Michael said.

MAHA has many side quests, and adherents sometimes fall into multilevel-marketing schemes, buy supplements promising miracle cures, or take advice from A.I.-generated doctors and healers. Some diversions are more unorthodox. The world of spellwork scams has been documented at length on Reddit, where users report paying anonymous healers for palm readings and magical cleansings. On Etsy, self-described psychics and witches peddle spells promising success, luck, money, revenge, weight loss, and more specific outcomes such as “make him cry and beg for you” and “punish everyone who wronged you.” Leah told me that she had met her “spiritual guide” on social media. The money, she said, was never much, and anything she spent was for her children’s benefit. “I was trying to protect my kids,” she said.

To Michael, it looked like an “obvious scam.” In one exchange, Leah appeared to request help with something irritating Donnie’s skin:

Healer: Donnie is healing now

Leah: Okay I’m worried because he’s still really itchy and Michael is getting concerned and telling me to take him to be

seen.

In another, she seemed to be making a payment on Donnie's behalf:

Leah: Offering for Donnie 🙏

Healer: Offering received with thanks 🙏 I thought I said 20

Leah: You said yesterday whatever I could. I sent \$15 but there's fees for purchasing Bitcoin . . . I will be sending you more soon sister 🙏

Healer: What time tomorrow.

Michael was furious, most of all about the money. They were already facing foreclosure on their house. "My biggest enemy is right here in my back yard," he said. That same night, another crisis was unfolding. Keith had traces of blood in his urine. Michael told me that, early the next morning, he tried to sneak Keith out of the house for a doctor's appointment. But Leah caught them in the driveway, getting into a car with Michael's mother, who cursed at Leah. In response, Leah called her a witch.

By then, the couple's relationship was effectively over. That afternoon, Michael filed for an emergency protective order, claiming that Leah had struck him in the face during an argument. Later, according to court documents, Leah alleged that Michael had once "grabbed her by the neck and left a bruise on her hip." She told me that she also considered the relationship to be emotionally abusive, which Michael denies. (A report by a lawyer appointed to represent the children noted that there were no allegations of violence against the kids and that Child Protective Services had concluded that they were safe with both parents.) Regardless, for a period of sixteen days, Michael was given temporary custody. Leah was devastated. The separation was traumatic for her and, she feared, for the children. She told me that they had never spent a

night apart from her before. Star, then two years old, was still nursing.



"Wait, instead of Fifth Avenue, can you take an impossibly thin mountain ledge?"
Cartoon by Joe Dator

Divorce proceedings began, and, not long after, Michael started dating Brianna, whom he met through the Kneepatch page. She had her own spiritual interests and offered online tarot readings and consultations for energy awakenings and for “twin flame” connections—a type of “profound spiritual bond” between two people who share a “soul energy,” as her website says. Dating Bri, Michael said, was like having “a personal psychologist.” She helped him define his style as “free-range parenting,” as opposed to “helicopter parenting.”

Michael believed that the judge in his divorce case, who’d once worked as a registered nurse, would side with him. (Early on, she ordered that “neither party shall discuss witchcraft with the children.”) But the result was mixed. The judge ruled that Michael and Leah would share custody of the children. Michael would take the kids three weekends a month during the school year, plus various holidays and birthdays; they would spend the rest of the time with Leah. But, against Leah’s wishes, the judge ordered that Keith attend public school instead of being homeschooled. That meant meeting school vaccination requirements. The laws in West Virginia were strict. Leah couldn’t get an exemption.

According to the custody agreement, Michael and Leah were supposed to make medical decisions together. If they couldn’t

agree, they were to “follow the recommendations of the doctor.” But Michael and Leah couldn’t agree on what kind of doctor the kids should see, or when they should see one. Months later, when the red blotches appeared on Donnie’s face, Michael believed that this was exactly the kind of thing that he’d been fighting to prevent.

Nothing will test *MAHA*’s hold on so many Americans like the reëmergence of vaccine-preventable diseases. Last year, as measles cases increased, Lindsay Logan, the mom who attended the screening of “Vaxxed II,” became consumed with thoughts about her unvaccinated daughter being exposed to the virus. During family trips, while riding on public transportation or using a rest stop, she would think, *This is it. This is when we’re getting measles*. Earlier this year, she scheduled an appointment to get her daughter an M.M.R. shot. She kept it a secret from her *MAHA* mom friends, afraid of what they might think. As the date approached, she grew more and more fearful. The day before the visit, she took pictures and videos of her daughter—a record of her pre-vaccinated state—because, she said, “I was convinced that the next day, when she got the shot, I might not have the same child.”

Across the country, pediatricians have watched in horror as Kennedy’s H.H.S. has weakened the public’s faith in vaccination. He has released a new childhood vaccine schedule (which has since been blocked by a federal judge) that cut the number of recommended shots from seventeen to eleven. He has said that he personally ordered the C.D.C. to change its long-standing public guidance stating that vaccines do not cause autism. The agency’s website now says that this assertion is not “evidence-based,” because studies cannot definitively rule out the possibility that they do. Trump, meanwhile, has encouraged the vaccine debate. He recently signed an executive order calling for “maximal parental choice over vaccines.” At the signing, he spoke about vaccines in menacing terms, evoking images of “vats of vaccine” and “fluid”—“what seemingly looks like gallons”—being “pumped

into your child's body." The combined three-in-one M.M.R. shot, he claimed, can be "quite lethal" and "explosive."

This year, vaccination rates among kindergartners decreased across immunizations for measles, mumps, rubella, polio, diphtheria, tetanus, and pertussis. New parents are also increasingly declining a Vitamin K injection for their infants. The shot has been standard for newborns since 1961. A so-called black-box warning associated with the shot mentions adverse reactions and has become a major topic among crunchy-parenting groups online. But the warning refers primarily to allergic reactions in adults; only one case of an allergic reaction has ever been recorded in a newborn. There is virtually no downside to the injection apart from the transient pain of the needle, and the upside is tremendous. Babies are born with low amounts of Vitamin K, which is required to form blood clots. Without the shot, an otherwise healthy newborn can bleed to death internally, usually in the brain.

This is what Stefani Leavitt, a Ph.D. student in Washington State, learned after giving birth to her second child. She had decided to deliver the baby at a birthing center, to avoid the temptation of an epidural. At one of her preparatory appointments, she was handed a form about Vitamin K, which she soon forgot about. "I am not someone who refuses vaccines," Leavitt said. But she was overwhelmed caring for her first child, and never looked into it. When her second child, Olive, was born, no one mentioned the Vitamin K injection. Olive was about a month old when Leavitt noticed "little bruises" on her body and head. A few days later, she wouldn't wake up from a nap. Leavitt rushed her to the hospital, where doctors found that her skull was filling with blood. She nearly died. Today, Olive has autism and epilepsy, and experiences several seizures a week. Leavitt told me that she has empathy for mothers who are overloaded with medical choices. "I understand why it's happening," she said. "But I just want to be, like, 'Your child could die.' "

Some vaccine-preventable diseases are illnesses that today's doctors have never treated firsthand. Deborah Greenhouse, a pediatrician in South Carolina, saw several babies with fatal cases of whooping cough when she was a resident. One coughed and gagged until it turned blue. "You don't forget that," she said. Alexandra Cvijanovich, a pediatrician in New Mexico, once assisted with a case of subacute sclerosing panencephalitis—a rare, deadly form of brain inflammation that typically develops seven to ten years after a case of measles. The patient had caught measles as a baby, when he was too young to be vaccinated. Then, when he was twelve, his brain suddenly began to shut down. It was "the worst death I've dealt with in my career," Cvijanovich said.

Measles is one of the world's most contagious diseases. Infected people typically recover within about two weeks. The danger lies in how quickly it can turn. For every thousand children infected, between one and three die from respiratory and neurological complications. In most states, measles-vaccination rates have fallen below the level required for herd immunity. Last year, an outbreak in West Texas killed two children. Two more deaths, in Pennsylvania, were recorded late this August. Earlier this year, South Carolina became the site of the country's largest outbreak since the virus was declared eliminated, in 2000. It took nearly seven months to contain. In the meantime, another outbreak was under way in Utah—including in a small city called Vernal. One day, when a high-school student there reported that she was feeling feverish, her mother, a stay-at-home mommy blogger named Tamsyn Spackman, knew immediately that it was measles.

On her blog, Spackman describes herself as "a bit of a maverick" and "Dr Mom." She writes about practicing "natural parenting" with her eight children, who range in age from infancy to eighteen years old. Spackman was vaccinated, but none of her children were. Within weeks, seven of the kids were sick. Fever came, then Koplik's spots, then the telltale rash. Spackman spent about a thousand dollars on herbs, tinctures, and oils. These included

yarrow, feverfew, catnip, elderberry, burdock root, licorice root, valerian root, pleurisy root, redroot, and zinc.

The kids recovered, but Spackman herself soon got sick. She waited for the rash—“a sign that the body has won,” as she wrote on her blog—but it never arrived. Instead, she had a recurring fever for about four weeks. Spackman told me that measles itself wasn’t “that scary.” She believed that, with the right natural approach, the virus could pass through the body like a “cleanse.” But, after weeks of her managing the illness at home, Spackman’s husband finally asked whether she had any “emotions” that she needed to work through. She admitted that she was, in fact, afraid. “I talked about some of those things, and I cried a little bit,” she said. That night, she took a hot bath, administered an herbal enema, drank teas to help her sweat, wrapped herself in a cold, wet sheet, and then went to bed. The next day, she said that the “deep ache I’ve had in my bones” was gone. “I’m finally, finally on the mend.”

“If you or your child have measles, you can: Rest.” Michael came home from the urgent-care center with an informational packet that included this advice. It also advised drinking fluids, taking Tylenol, and staying in a cool, dimly lit room. But mostly, it seemed, he had to wait. The next day, he took Keith and Star to a pediatric urgent-care unit to be tested for measles. The medical staff told Michael that Star’s oxygen level was below ninety per cent—dangerously low. An ambulance was already on the way.

Star was placed on a tiny stretcher, with tubes hooked up to her wrist and nose. Doctors tended to her in face masks and isolation gowns. They told Michael that Star had pneumonia—a common measles complication—and RSV, another respiratory virus. Once she was evaluated, she was taken to a second hospital, in Leesburg, Virginia, where the doctors held her overnight. Michael was “stressed to the absolute max,” he said. That evening, he “slept like a cat at the foot of her little bed.”

The next day, Leah drove to the hospital to be with Star, while Michael returned home to take care of the boys. Keith had been improving, but Donnie started getting worse. He coughed small, weak coughs. It sounded like his lungs were full. One day, Michael said, Donnie woke up from a nap and was “burning hot.” Michael checked his temperature; the thermometer read a hundred and five. Then he checked his oxygen; the oximeter said eighty-one per cent. Michael grabbed him, rushed out of the house, and blew through several red lights on the way to the hospital. He left the truck running with the doors open in the parking lot. “I was panicked,” he told me. The doctors said that Donnie had pneumonia in one of his lungs. Because of his S.M.A., he didn’t have the muscle to cough out the mucus. Another ambulance arrived.

By then, the children’s illness had become the subject of a battle online. Leah’s mother had posted first. If Donnie had measles, she wrote, he got it “from the ‘vaccinated’ kids” who went to public school with Keith. “The doctors visits have been almost every week and yet they tell us vaccinated kids are healthier! Hum!” Michael responded in a lengthy post on the Kneepatch page, with screenshots of his text messages with Leah and a picture of Donnie staring at the ceiling, his arm folded on his tiny chest, his face covered in red spots: “Y’all send some prayers our way [for] Donnie today. He is currently being tested for measles. I have fought tooth and nail in court to get my children vaxxed especially Donnie.” He added, “I’m so upset it’s hard to get into words.” Comments accumulated, some torching Leah’s parenting. But, as the days went by, Michael didn’t post an update on the test results. “So,” one follower asked, “did they test positive for measles or not?”

What Michael didn’t say was that, sometime after Star’s hospital visit, the kids’ nose swabs had come back negative for measles. PCR tests for measles are considered generally reliable, though false negatives do happen. I asked several doctors to review an account of the children’s symptoms, along with a photo of Donnie’s

rash. They told me that the professionals who had treated the kids as if they had measles had been right to do so. But it's also possible that the kids had something else. Other illnesses can produce fever and rash: rubella, HHV-6, parvovirus, scarlet fever. Michael could have arranged for an antibody test, but he didn't pursue it. Even after the test results came back, he and Brianna believed that the culprit was measles. "There were 8+ doctors over the course of this situation, in VERY different hospitals, that ALL diagnosed them with Measles," Brianna eventually wrote to Michael's followers. "It would be VERY weird for it to be anything else." Her own three children—all vaccinated—had shared a house with Michael's for a few days at the beginning of spring break, and they never caught so much as a sniffle. Keith, who was vaccinated, had a milder case. What else, they reasoned, could explain this?

Leah was not moved by these arguments. She believed that Michael had seized on whatever explanation would benefit his custody appeal in court. "This came out of nowhere and you think this is a coincidence due to ME not vaccinating our kids?" she texted him. "No dude. Absolutely not." At the start of the ordeal, she had accused Michael of spiritual manipulation. "Sounds like your witches have been at work," she texted him. But she had also asked reasonable questions about how this could have happened when there were no confirmed cases of the illness in West Virginia at the time. "Logically speaking, I wouldn't think it's the measles if no one else has it, but who knows?" she wrote. When the tests came back negative, she felt vindicated. Now who didn't trust the science?

They had the test results, but little had changed. They were still living in two different realities, unable to agree on the truth. Donnie spent a night in the hospital, then was released. A couple of days later, the boys finally returned to their mom's house. Spring break was over.

What should be done when parents differ on whether to vaccinate a child? I spoke to several mothers who said that the more they committed to a *MAHA* life style, the more it strained their relationship. Lindsey Fergins, a forty-two-year-old mom in Ohio, told me that she almost lost her marriage as a result. “It caused a huge rift between myself and my husband,” Fergins said. Around 2019, it became the focus of their couples counselling. “It got to the point where, if I had found out that he went to take our daughter to get a vaccine against my will, I would have divorced him,” she said. During the pandemic, though, Fergins found that she was more scared of the virus than of the vaccine. She discovered a Facebook group for women who’d left the anti-vax movement. She sat her husband down, apologized, and told him that they needed to get their kids caught up on their vaccines. “He was just speechless,” Fergins said. “It was a turning point in our marriage.”

Other times, disagreements end in legal action. One such case, in 2017, centered on a mother in Michigan named Rebecca Bredow, who did not want to vaccinate her son. Her ex-husband, James Horne, did. Bredow’s lawyer signed a consent order on her behalf agreeing to vaccinate the child, but Bredow ignored it. Bredow was held in contempt and handcuffed, and spent five days in jail. She later claimed that Horne never cared about vaccines at all—he had just used the issue to secure a better custody deal. The case made Horne a target of the anti-vax community. Del Bigtree, an activist close to R.F.K., Jr., once followed Horne through an airport, filming as he asked questions like “Is your son’s health really what matters to you?”



"I'd like for you to stop referring to yourself as Vlad the People Pleaser. Is there anything else you're particularly good at?"

Cartoon by Meredith Southard

The central legal inquiry of any custody dispute involves determining what's in the "best interest of the child." This is a broad, flexible standard—and it's up to a judge to decide. Dorit Reiss, a professor at the University of California College of the Law, San Francisco, who studies cases involving vaccine disputes, told me that judges sometimes favor the pro-vaccine parent, but not always. "Family law is highly localized and very particular to the specific case," she said. More often, courts hesitate to override a parent who, up until a divorce, has been a child's primary decision-maker.

For all the years of Michael and Leah's marriage, that person was Leah. When I spoke to her recently, I found her to be open about her beliefs. Her sincerity, combined with her slow Texas drawl, had an unembarrassed, guileless quality to it. She told me that, even if a medical cure for Donnie's S.M.A. is never found, she hoped that "one day I can heal him from this." Leah seemed to understand the turns in her life as twists of fate that had set her on a different

“timeline.” “Whatever comes is meant to be,” she told me. She had not planned to become an anti-vaxxer, but she liked to keep an open mind; when arguments about the dangers of vaccines had arisen on the internet, she had accepted them into her way of viewing the world. If *MAHA* is a uniquely modern movement, born of fraying American systems, then Leah’s path reflected those same forces. She had sought community and identity online. Her experience of motherhood, the thing she valued most, had been transformed by pandemic-era fear and polarization. She had slipped away from the mainstream.

Leah was still waiting to hear whether Michael’s appeal would lead to a new family-court hearing. In the meantime, Donnie was scheduled to start public school in the fall. For a while, Michael believed that Leah would somehow try to circumvent the school’s vaccine requirements. At a recent pickup, he and Leah argued about one of the kids’ ear infections, while Michael, who was filming the interaction using a camera attached to his motorcycle, repeatedly asked, “Did you get Donnie set up for his vaccines for school?” He even considered taking Donnie to the doctor himself, without telling Leah. But, in August, Leah took the child to his first appointment. “It’s scary,” she told me afterward. “Anytime they get vaccines, or anything like that, I pray about it and make sure that they’re shielded in protection. That’s just the way I’m living.”

It was hard to imagine the two parents coming to an understanding. Michael was still frightened and disoriented by what had taken place over spring break. Whatever the kids had been sick with, he said, showed how risky this could be. “How are we going to make a sound decision if something goes crazy with Donnie?” he asked. To him, Leah had gone down a TikTok rabbit hole and never come out. “I feel like I’m living in crazy town,” he said on several occasions. Leah, for her part, had come to a serious, almost spiritual belief—reinforced by everything she saw online—in the fallenness of the medical establishment. How many well-meaning parents felt the same? It was clear to me that Leah, like the other

MAHA moms I met, was motivated by a real desire to protect her children. This was something that even Michael could admit. “She loves her kids,” he said. “You can’t take that away from her.”

When I visited Michael in Charles Town, all three of his kids had made a full recovery, though problems remained: persistent ear infections, a stubborn case of dermatitis. Michael still had the hospital discharge papers in his truck. It was a Saturday, and I followed him and the children to a playground made up of two large play structures in a sea of wood mulch chips. No one else was there. Michael, who sometimes encouraged Donnie out of his chair to help him build muscle and independence, placed him in the mulch chips near the base of one of the structures, where Keith and Star were already climbing. The sun was blazing. “Get your hands the right way,” he called to Donnie, who was scooting through the wood chips. “Fists or palms, O.K.?”

At a nearby table, he took out his cigarettes and lit one up. In the spirit of free-range parenting, Michael told me, he believed in letting the kids wander. “Just go out and play and be kids,” he said. He wanted to teach them how to swim and take them camping. Across the playground, Star climbed to the top of a slide, then got too scared to come down. Michael retrieved her. Donnie seemed content on his own. I tried not to talk too much about the illness in front of the kids. Brianna had told me that they had been “terrified” to be so sick. Today, though, they seemed happy to be enjoying an aimless afternoon at Dad’s.

After a couple of hours, Keith ran over and asked when they were leaving.

He held up a small, bent twig like a weapon: “He’s a bad guy. *Pew, pew, pew, pew, pew.*” He withdrew the twig, then said, “Now you’re a good guy.”

“Thank you,” Michael said.

Donnie was crawling over. Michael hoisted him up to the table with us. “I’m about to fall asleep,” Donnie said.

“O.K., lean on me here. You can sleep on me, O.K.?”

Star soon joined. “Meow,” she said.

The kids had already explored both play structures, said hi to a dog, and picked blades of grass beneath a tree. “Dad, when can we go home?” Donnie asked.

Michael loaded the children into the back seat and put Donnie’s wheelchair in the truck bed. “Star,” he said. “Seat belt, baby.” From the back seat, Star was asking for chicken nuggets, a treat that she associated with her father. Michael laughed. “Already?” he said. Star asked again. Michael said O.K. It was past lunchtime, anyway. They drove off to McDonald’s. ♦

Ruby Cramer is a staff writer at The New Yorker covering politics.

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/the-maha-custody-battle>

Fiction

- **“Lub Dub Lub Dub Lub Dub”**

By Helen Simpson | A sense of impending doom—that was how Weary had described the feeling many people got, like a heaviness in the chest.

Fiction

Lub Dub Lub Dub Lub Dub

By [Helen Simpson](#)

August 30, 2026



Photograph by Michael Raines for The New Yorker

“I wish I’d never read that piece about pacemakers,” Tracey said.

“You needed a new cooker, anyway,” Lois said. “You were saying your old one was about to give up the ghost.”

“How was I to know a plain electric hob would take forever to heat up?” Tracey fumed. “Then it gets too hot and it won’t turn down again and it burns everything. Disaster!”

“You did it for Adam,” Lois pointed out. “For his health.”

[Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.](#)

Old friends, they were in one of London’s myriad Costas for a quick flat white before Lois’s 10:07 train from Euston. She was off on her fortnightly trek to the Midlands to visit her ninety-two-year-old mother.

A shriek of laughter from the gaggle of school mothers in the sofa area temporarily silenced them. The clack of cleated cycling shoes added to the din as three furry-legged men in helmets clattered up to the counter. The air was already at blood heat outside, and the men were sweating freely.

“How’s it been since Adam retired?” Lois asked.

Tracey thought about this. It had been the right time for him to stop. I prefer to call it “badinage,” he’d said when challenged about his workplace banter.

“Four Dyno-Rod callouts to the house in the past two weeks about our drains not working with maximum efficiency,” she said. “He’s off at the gym now. Which is ironic, as the gym’s the reason I’ve got to go to an effing three-hour workshop on cardiac arrests this morning.”

Podcast: The Writer’s Voice

[Listen to Helen Simpson read “Lub Dub Lub Dub Lub Dub.”](#)

Adam had been working out at the gym when the man on the running machine next to him had toppled off it while watching a replay of the previous night’s Champions League highlights. The

gym's defibrillator had blasted into action, and now the man was recovering from a triple bypass. "Only fifty-seven," Adam had marvelled, shaking his head; he was sixty-five himself.

"Who knew an induction stovetop could mess with a pacemaker," Lois said, reverting to their cooker conversation.

"Don't get closer than two feet away or you might explode," Tracey said. "You'll need a mega-long wooden spoon to scramble your eggs if you're going to risk it, according to that pesky health magazine."

Adam's father had had a pacemaker, like a little matchbox under his collarbone, and heart trouble was often genetic. Tracey was anticipating Adam's need for one himself.

"It's how *my* father went," Lois said. "He didn't really know anything about it—he'd been telling a funny story at the time, and he just stopped. That was it. So long ago now."

His heart burst smilingly, Tracey thought, the shred of Shakespeare floating back across the decades. She'd done "King Lear" at school. Lately, all sorts of things she'd once read were reappearing.

"My mother's been on her own now for well over thirty years," Lois said. "She's indestructible. I do worry about what's going to happen, how it'll end. She won't have any help except from me, and her stairs are lethal."

"Have you noticed, though," Tracey said, "things don't generally go as expected. Something happens out of the blue. Think of the Berlin Wall."

"The Berlin Wall? I suppose so. Why didn't you go for a gas stovetop, by the way?"

“Oh, I know. You don’t have to tell me. I love gas for cooking. So responsive! But apparently it’s the same as having a small car belching exhaust fumes into your kitchen, and Adam gets asthma now and then.”

“You can’t win, can you. Oh, look at the time! I’ve got to rush.”

The two women embraced briefly but warmly and set off on their different days.

At the workshop, in a local church hall, Tracey found herself sitting next to a woman who’d already done the course once and had come for a refresher. In the same week that this woman had first done it, she told Tracey, quite by chance she’d gone round to friends for dinner, and, just as their host was carrying in the fish pie, he’d dropped it and crashed to the ground with a heart attack. She was able to administer CPR right away, freshly primed with the relevant knowledge; no, he didn’t survive. It had made *her* feel better about it, though, having a go herself.

The course leader gave them her name at the start—Welsh for “snow,” she told them, a Celtic name that sounded to Tracey like “Weary,” although surely it couldn’t be that, even if it did suit her.

Lub dub lub dub lub dub is the noise of the heart beating when you listen with a stethoscope.

It’s a four-chambered pump ceaselessly squeezing the blood through your body, and its hundred thousand beats a day are powered by self-generated electrical impulses. A cardiologist clearly had to combine the skills of both plumber and electrician, Tracey thought as she listened to Weary’s account of what tended to go wrong.

Your heart’s supply pipes could get furred up. They could narrow right down and sometimes be completely blocked—then you would

have to get stents or an ablation, and, if some really serious plumbing work needed to be done, the supply might be rerouted via some unblocked pipes borrowed from somewhere else. Often from your leg. Whereas when the electricians went wrong, when the rhythm of the pump fell out of kilter, a little generator, a pacemaker, could be wired in under the collarbone to put it right.

“When the heart stops for whatever reason,” Weary said, wearily, “whether it’s blocked arteries or electrical chaos, whatever—that’s what’s called cardiac arrest. After four minutes of no oxygen, the brain starts to die, but, if you keep the blood moving round the body with hefty chest compressions, you might gain a little more time.”

The workshop attendees shifted in their seats. Action at last.

“But, whatever you do, don’t try it if they’re breathing,” Weary added sternly. “Check if they’re breathing first.”

There was some uneasy laughter.

“I’ve seen relatives attempting to do CPR on someone while they’re trying to escape,” she continued, without smiling. “I’ve literally had to pull them off. So, how do you check? You check by getting your ear and cheek down close to their nose, their mouth, and feeling if there’s any breath coming out.”

Another scrap of Shakespeare appeared, longer this time, echoing down the corridor of memory. Lend me a looking glass; if that her breath will mist or stain the stone, Why, then she lives.

Tracey put her hand up.

“Would it work if you put a mirror to their mouth?” she asked.

“I have heard of that,” Weary said. “But, to be honest, most people don’t carry a mirror with them.”

More than ninety per cent of people who experience cardiac arrests outside of hospitals do not survive, they were told. Tracey stopped concentrating quite so hard when she heard this—what was the point?

A plastic torso and face was pulled from Weary's rucksack. "Little Anne," she said, tossing the demi-doll to the ground. With some effort, she got down onto her hands and knees to demonstrate how to do chest compressions.

"Arms straight. Push hard with your arms straight," Weary said, "*and* release. Keep this up to the rhythm of 'Stayin' Alive,' though you could go with 'Baby Shark' if you're too young to know about the Bee Gees. We don't advise 'Nellie the Elephant' anymore—it's too slow."

"How *hard* should you push?" the keen woman next to Tracey asked.

"*Pretty* hard," Weary said. "Some think if you don't break a rib, it's not hard enough. I wouldn't go so far as to say that, though, yes, I might well do some damage to the ribs, the cartilage. But if you don't push down hard enough their brain will die."

"Bloody hell," Tracey muttered.

"To be honest, it's very unlikely you'll get that heart beating again without a defibrillator," Weary said. "Which needs to be there within four minutes, ideally, if it's going to work. So, as you can see, it's *where* your cardiac arrest happens that matters most—I mean, at Heathrow you'd be O.K., or at the gym. But you might not be so lucky otherwise."

I'd be useless, Tracey thought. We are enfleshed—that's the mystery—but flesh is not all that we are. The body is important and

interesting, but it's not the whole story. Yes, when the heart stops beating, your light's switched off. But until then . . .

Once home, hunched over a Nespresso, Tracey attended to the buildup on her iPhone, saving Lois's WhatsApp voice note till last. Lois had had a falafel panini at the bus stop in Burton upon Trent, it seemed—not very nice but better than nothing—while waiting for the once-an-hour No. 9 to her mother's flat in Ashby-de-la-Zouch. She was reporting in now from her childhood bedroom. Her mother was having a nap while she, Lois, sorted through her bills and medical appointments. She, Lois, was looking forward to a better night's sleep, under her old candlewick bedspread, than she'd been managing recently; she was glad for her daughter that things were going well with the new boyfriend, but the walls were paper thin and she and William could hear everything; though, of course, she shouldn't complain, it wasn't her daughter's fault that she couldn't afford to move out at twenty-seven, and actually maybe she and William should think about downsizing, too, though they couldn't really afford to either if they wanted to stay near London, where their life was.

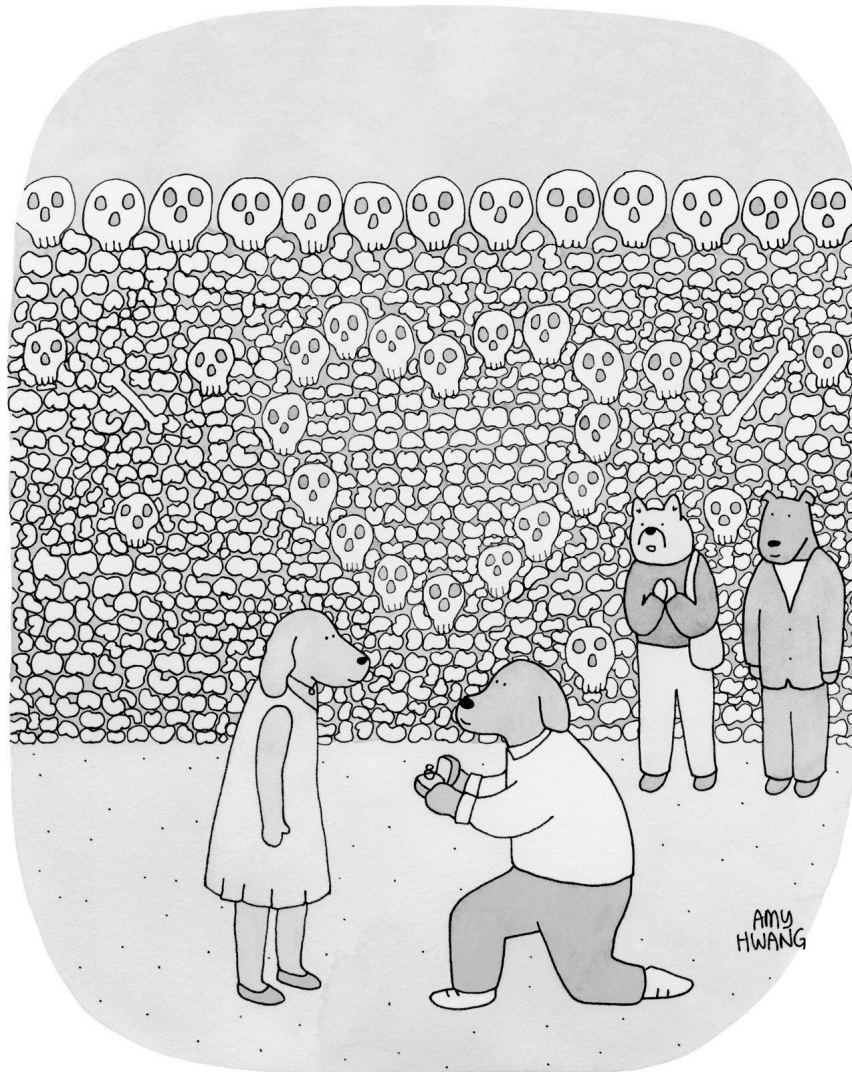
Tracey's voice note in response gave the morning's workshop highlights, including the rib-cracking part, and she volunteered that she thought her—Lois's—mother had been absolutely right to get her official D.N.R. statement framed and placed on the hall table, as otherwise any paramedics would be legally obliged to storm in and do goodness knows what, which seemed ridiculous. And, as for downsizing, she was just off now, as it happened, to view a flat with Ollie, the estate agent she'd told Lois about, the one who looked like Paul Mescal.

“It's deceptively spacious,” Ollie said, as he always did.

“Um,” Tracey said.

They gazed together at the melancholy little room. It smelled dispiritingly stale. A fine pelt of dust coated the brown furniture; dust motes circulated sluggishly in the single ray of light struggling through the layer of window grime.

“Probate job,” Ollie added.



“Paris is so romantic.”

Cartoon by Amy Hwang

“Phew, it’s hot,” Tracey said, mopping her forehead with a tissue.

“Yeah, climate change, what can you do,” Ollie agreed. “I’m on leave next week, and it’ll be forty-three in Corfu! But that’s cool—I just want to chill by the pool.”

“Yes,” Tracey said.

Another heat wave was on the way, the second this year, and it was still only early May. Having lived in Britain all her life, Tracey's thermostat was calibrated to milder days, and she didn't do so well now that the outside air had started to exceed blood heat by several degrees on a regular basis.

That's how they used to poach lobsters, she thought: alive, and slowly increasing the heat.

"How's business?" she asked Ollie.

"Good, good," he said earnestly, admiring his pointed brown shoes. Then he looked up at her and beamed. "They were saying at work, it's already started, the cascade effect."

"Cascade effect?" she asked, though she knew what it was. It was a phrase she kept hearing.

"Trillions!" he said with simple enthusiasm. "The greatest transfer of parent-to-child wealth in history, and all because of what's happened to property prices."

Tracey grunted her understanding of this.

"Our new sales initiative," he said, laughing. "We call it Downsize and Die."

Then he realized what he'd just said and blushed as red as a peony.

"Off the record," he muttered, frowning down at his shoes this time.

"Of course," Tracey said, soothingly.

At home, she smiled fondly at Downsize and Die, pausing to tap out a WhatsApp message to make Lois smile, too.

What was that piece of advice Ollie had given her last week, while he was showing her the basement flat on Harbinger Road?

“I always say, go with your gut, not with your heart,” he’d said mysteriously.

Go with your gut! Even as she was under sedation, the deep twisting sensation during her recent colonoscopy had made her groan. The long metal worm with its camera eye was like the one Dyno-Rod used on the drains. Adam didn’t yet know to leave well alone.

She turned back to the pile of novels she had been sorting through for Oxfam.

A sense of impending doom—that was how Weary had described the feeling many people got, like a heaviness in the chest.

It wasn’t as if you got to choose, though, Tracey mused, saving “In a Summer Season” and tossing “Under the Volcano” onto the giveaway pile.

Extraordinary that this Billy bookcase will outlive me, she thought. It’ll still be here years after I’ve gone.

Anyway, who cares? She’d had enough for one day. Death hath ten thousand several doors, get over it. Whichever way you go, it ends the same way. What would it profit me to be shot to death with diamonds or strangled with pearls? That wasn’t Shakespeare, was it? No, it was Webster.

Six o’clock. She turned the radio on. The slow chimes of Big Ben sounded, and then the newsreader’s solemn voice with the headlines.

Here was Adam at the door, back from his afternoon trip to the dentist.

She flicked off the radio and looked at him blankly.

“The world is run by awful old men,” she said.

“No debate there,” Adam said, unpacking some cans of beer from his man bag. “You won’t believe it when I tell you how much it’s going to cost for a root canal!”

His golden locks Time hath to silver turned. She was still getting used to the change in how he looked.

“I’m off to tennis in a minute,” he added.

“What, *again*?”

“*You* should take more exercise,” he said as he walked out of the room. “I don’t want you dying on me.”

“No,” she said.

“You know what I mean,” he said, putting his head round the door, then coming over to hug her. “I wouldn’t last long if you went. I’ll be having a drink with Pete afterward, by the way, so I’ll help myself from the fridge when I get back.”

“See you later,” she said.

Deciding that she’d have something from the freezer herself, she turned the oven on high to preheat. Good, there was an individual lasagna—just what she felt like. Tonight would be the first time she’d used the oven rather than the stovetop since the cooker’s arrival, last week, so this would be in the nature of a christening.

It certainly looked good, with the pasta’s bubbling béchamel clearly visible through the flawless glass door.

While she waited for her meal to heat through, she sat reading “In a Summer Season” at the kitchen table, enjoying the new oven’s industrious hum.

The next thing she knew, there had been a loud explosion.

Glass was everywhere—all over the table and floor, all over the kitchen, even caught in her clothes and hair.

“Bloody hell,” she said for the second time that day.

She waited for a moment before moving, and thought about it.

The oven must have blown up.

Yes, it was the oven door. It had burst into ten thousand diamond shards. It must have been made from some sort of tempered glass, she realized, for she wasn’t bleeding.

The lasagna was covered in glass jewels.

She crunched across the kitchen to fetch the oven’s manual. Nothing there.

She looked it up on her phone and, yes, how strange, oven doors did explode sometimes—it was a thing.

Not feeling quite ready to start clearing up yet, Tracey stood in the kitchen doorway and took a long, deep breath.

Then, while she waited for her heart rate to slow down, she WhatsApped her old friend Lois: “You’ll never guess what just happened.” ♦

Helen Simpson is a short-story writer whose six collections include “Hey Yeah Right Get a Life” and “Cockfosters.” She is a fellow of the Royal Society of Literature.

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/lub-dub-lub-dub-lub-dub-fiction-helen-simpson>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

The Critics

- **“The Disappearers” Stages the Pain and Pleasure of Jamaican Gay Life**

By Katy Waldman | Marlon James’s new novel follows a group of gay men who seek love, connection, and restitution after a bloody homophobic attack.

- **Has the Supreme Court Sandbagged Democracy?**

By Daniel Immerwahr | A new legal history argues that the Justices should be stripped of their power to overrule coequal branches of government. It arrives at an awkward moment.

- **Briefly Noted**

“The Black Shield,” “Endless Endings,” “Solstice,” and “I Was Bonnie & Clyde.”

- **Who’s Afraid of A.I. Music?**

By Kelefa Sanneh | When the rapper Fenix Flexin debuted a new accent on his single “Rubberz,” he stumbled into a century-old fight over musical fraudulence.

- **Matisse’s Ugliest Painting**

By Zachary Fine | More than a century after its incendiary début, “Woman with a Hat” remains wonderfully resistant to the dictates of beauty and taste.

- **In “Adults,” Gen Z Gets the Hangout Sitcom It Deserves**

By Inkoo Kang | The FX series, which is returning for a second season, won’t restore the genre to its normcore roots—but, happily, it has no interest in doing so.

Books

“The Disappearers” Stages the Pain and Pleasure of Jamaican Gay Life

Marlon James’s new novel follows a group of gay men who seek love, connection, and restitution after a bloody homophobic attack.

By [Katy Waldman](#)

August 31, 2026



James glues together the pulpy and the delicate, playing with the cartoonish nature of our most intense experiences.

Photograph by Donavon Smallwood for The New Yorker

Marlon James’s novels, though they range from historical fiction to high fantasy, share a distinct spiritual frequency—a mix of bravado and bereavement. They are heroic in their scope, ambition, length, extremity, variety, unclassifiability, and apparent impulse to wrestle an entire world of external phenomena and internal experience between two covers. Yet this muchness tends to orbit a central

absence. In James's third book, "[A Brief History of Seven Killings](#)," from 2014, a kaleidoscope of action and intrigue whirls around an artist known only as the Singer—a stand-in for Bob Marley—who departs from Kingston after an assassination attempt. The novel, a Talmudic compendium of multiplying, entangling plotlines, established James as a literary eminence, and made him the first Jamaican author to win the Booker Prize. In the wake of its success, he published two installments of a daring new project, a planned epic trilogy rooted in African mythology. James, invoking "[Game of Thrones](#)" as a touchstone, said that he'd been longing for "Black pageantry"; the works delivered verdant settings, Tarantino-esque blood spatter, and horseback riders in "flowing red robes, black armour, and gold crowns topped with feathers." But all this manifold spectacle is triggered by a quest for a boy, possibly of royal lineage, who has gone missing. The first line of the first book seems to void everything that follows. "The child is dead," the story begins. "There is nothing left to know."

Does loss cancel out the life happening around it, or can life and loss coexist? James's books are explicit and sensational, full of graphic depictions of sex and violence. There's a sense of abundance and duplicity: the sprawling casts feature raving soliloquists, undercover agents, and tricksters who pepper their seductions with asides about literature and philosophy. James, who publicly came out as gay in his forties, after the publication of "[A Brief History](#)," is alert to the spectrum of manliness—how aggression can give way to an unprotected softness, and how virile swagger can veer into camp. He glues together the pulpy and the delicate, seesawing at times between shock value and earned emotional devastation, playing with the cartoonish nature of our most intense experiences. In his newest book, "[The Disappearers](#)" (Riverhead), a son congratulates his father on probably being the first parent to wish that his child was raped in high school. The father offers, "What I shoulda done is kill you in your sleep."

[What We're Reading](#)

Discover notable new fiction, nonfiction, and poetry.



James is also evocative on the sentence level—in the same novel, a desolate character standing on a balcony hears a “little blue amoeba of pool” whispering to him from below. Phrases are turned a few degrees tighter than you’d expect from a writer who so rejects the cult of the single exquisitely resonant detail (why not a blizzard of details, some of which undermine one another?), and who has such an ear for speech. James’s dialogue fountains down the page, as if a tap has been opened. Life pours from him. There’s that vibrancy and, on the other side of the ledger, dead boys, ciphers, unfinished or unfinishable quests.

“The Disappearers” immediately showcases its author’s signature math of plenitude plus lack. It follows a group of gay men in Jamaica who seek love, connection, and restitution after a bloody homophobic attack. The explosion of malice effaces them in different ways, and James traces the mechanisms of their vanishing, examining how a person’s life can be compressed into smaller and smaller spaces. He seems preoccupied throughout by the simultaneity of having and losing. During a particularly ghastly scene, a character who’s dying of *AIDS* quotes “The Rime of the Ancient Mariner”: “Water, water, every where, / Nor any drop to drink.” In its bleakest moments, the novel suggests that the ordeal of being gay in a venomously bigoted society negates its bounty.

Masculinity and its discontents are dominant themes for James, things that he’s explored with nuance and sensitivity in his almost etiological studies of violence. Gay desire has been more peripheral to his work, and is usually shadowed by danger. Queer characters filled out “Brief History”’s taxonomy of social types, including Weeper, a ruthless enforcer and cocaine addict who slept with men

in prison. Sent to oversee drug operations in New York City, Weeper discovers the East Village's queer scene. It's a netherworld of male-on-male hookups, adjacent to gangland and haunted by what one character calls "the gay cancer"—a veiled, subterranean setting that James uses to emphasize the mingling of invisibility, death, and pleasure.

If gay life and homophobia were once merely part of the Jamesian tapestry, "The Disappearers" puts these elements center stage. The book unfurls, playlike, in five acts. Each section has the feel of a dramatic monologue. James seems to be easing the reader in with Act I, a series of journal entries composed by the earnest, good-natured nineteen-year-old Eddy Porteous, who sees a coded flyer for a theatrical production and decides to audition. (It turns out that no auditions are necessary; just enough men have shown up for the director to cast the play.) The year is 1988, and the director, the stage manager, and the six performers offer a cross-section of that era's gay life. Eddy hails from uptown; the director, Titus Havelock, was educated at Oxford; and the designated "top queen," with blown-out hair and skin "smoother than the lotion he uses," lives in a neighborhood where houses "look like shipping containers stacked together." His name is Orrin, and he bears some resemblance to one of the main characters on "Get Millie Black," from 2024, a Jamaican crime drama that James created for HBO.

The play that they will be staging is "Fortune and Men's Eyes," by the Canadian director John Herbert, about a community of incarcerated men. "Yes, there will be violence. Yes, there will be tenderness. Yes, there will be rape," Havelock warns. Eddy, though, is more interested in his castmates, especially an acerbic college dropout and fellow comics connoisseur named Jordan Brown ("high, loose, curly hair . . . dimples") and a guarded office worker who gives his name as Matt Chin. ("Brown. Tall. Half-Chinese-looking. Wide grin. Wow.")

Eddy is a classic Nick Carraway bystander type, observant yet sweetly unaware of his magnetizing effect on the other characters. He's stamped with the Jamesian trademarks of a smart mouth and pop-cultural fluency, dropping rat-a-tat references to Prince, Sinéad O'Connor, Bret Easton Ellis, "The Cosby Show," and Bruce Springsteen (who owns "the biggest boss bulge in rock and roll"). Crucially, Eddy is also the only one of the players who can pass for white; when his journal entries end, so does the book's innocence.

The chattiness of Eddy's dispatches does little to conceal that the novel's Jamaica is a grim place for gay men. A local university burns mattresses out of a fear of *AIDS*; even Eddy's best girlfriend tosses off slurs. In the book's second act, that malevolence erupts. A mob of men ambushes the players—minus Eddy, who isn't there—at rehearsal, killing one actor and maiming the others. James roves among the attackers' perspectives before and during the event, his experimental style, psychological acuity, and ragged lyricism on display. ("Lock yourself in a room let the dark and the heat boil you into a stew, let the heat go from fire in your skin to fire in your mind and blame that on them too blame them for even the dark.") Also evident is the lurid hyper-violence that has occasionally caused critics to reach for words like "sadism" and "pornography" to describe James's work. "I could make a charm bracelet out of all the teeth scattered on the floor," one assailant jokes. A victim's face acquires "two small wet holes that seem big like outer space; two bloody black holes where him eyes supposed to be."



“Trade you my lunch for access to your family’s myriad political and financial connections?”
Cartoon by Lars Kenseth

The rest of the book is aftermath. Upon being released from the hospital, two men disappear. Jordan, the dimpled college dropout, pursues vengeance, attempting to visit on the perpetrators of the assault what they instilled in him; James, as if stressing that the revenge plot constitutes its own gruesome genre, inflects Jordan’s story line with horror. For others in the cast, there’s respectable daytime Jamaica: church, work, loneliness. Havelock neither retreats to the closet nor holds out hope for resolution via vigilante justice. He moves into a hillside cottage—“the nearest neighbour is nearly a mile downhill”—and most days doesn’t “actually speak until the afternoon, if at all.” He reads, thinks, goes into town to earn a paycheck. “A quiet life,” he writes to a friend, before amending himself: “A sad life.”

In James’s hands, these branching options can seem to amount to distinctions without a difference. They appear to reflect the limitations of a world—Jamaica in the eighties—that disallows the

happiness of gay people. Or Black gay people, at least. Eddy has been spared the worst violence; the novel casts his racial privilege as a kind of metaphysical exemption. The attack compounds his sense of exclusion, his already guilty conscience. Jordan, to whom scorn comes more naturally than grace, accuses him of envying the rest of the troupe's ennobling misery. Do all Jamaican gay men, or possibly all nonwhite Jamaican gay men, have the same tragic story?

In the prison and in the play, "The Disappearers" finds two potent figures for gay life. The threat of the prison is that you're targeted and unfree, packed into a queasy, pressurized intimacy with the most dangerous parts of yourself and others. The threat of the play is that you assume a role that obscures who you truly are. James, a sensitive diviner of both anxieties, chronicles how the inhospitality of the social world sends gay men into hiding. "We doing battyman hater work for them," an elder observes. ("Battyman" is an offensive word for homosexual.) "Now it's we who making sure we vanish." What it means to collaborate in your own oppression—to use the master's tools to add an annex to the master's house—is a preoccupation for this author, who wrote, in "Brief History," that "maybe is a ghetto thing where even if another man don't destroy you, you going destroy yourself."

But "The Disappearers" isn't straightforwardly about self-contempt. Many of the characters don't shun their homosexuality; rather, they see it as beautiful. Jordan says, in a kind of ecstasy, "I want to lick a nipple with thick hair around it, get my tongue stuck between two ass cheeks clamping down on it, shove my hand down either the front or the back of his pants and come away with the same funk, lick tobacco or mint off his tongue, inhale the breath that he snorts out like a bull, wrap my hands around his cock while he wraps around mine and we yank and pretend like it don't hurt a little bit." In James's telling, a gay lover is a "bewitchment"; homosexual desire becomes a prison only when it causes you to be flattened and homogenized by suffering. During the cast's first real

rehearsal, the men struggle to articulate why they're interested in theatre. One wants to feel brave, one wants to try something new, several seem defiant or to imply that they're lonely. What they're fumblingly vocalizing is a sense of possibility tied to the adoption of a new identity—a promise of self-creation that the mob manages to invert. Violence diminishes its victims, forcing everyone to play a single thankless role. “This attack,” Eddy tells Matt. “It changed you. It changed all of you.” When Matt points out that Eddy is stating the obvious, Eddy clarifies, “I mean it changed all of you into the same person.”

As the book proceeds, James blurs his actors together, in slightly eerie ways. Their stories aren't interchangeable—some have endured a near-mythic amount of hardship, and others' difficulties feel more ordinary—but the repetition underscores their commonalities: their repressive fathers, their chilly mothers, their vicious or bewildered classmates. Like James himself, the men are clever and bookish, writing letters or diaries, reading voraciously, and imagining themselves into tales of romance and Biblical comeuppance. They even speak one another's lines. Matt lusts after “a runner whose living bulge bounces off one thigh then the other.” Jordan asks, in the middle of an ode to men's bodies, “You ever watch a boy run, how everything flops on right thigh, then left?”

These overlapping, semi-porous characters search for one another, their paths intersecting. The questing and the keeping-tabs develop a mystical dimension; it's as if the men have lost an incommunicable piece of themselves that they endlessly look for among their peers. Matt, whose perspective is largely withheld, remains the most enigmatic of the group, and the one most desperately sought after. James loans him elements of his own biography—memories and material that he's talked about as part of his coming of age.

Still, the novel properly belongs to Jordan, a creation as canny and protean as the story itself. He's a conflicted force of nature whose

narration demonstrates James's ability to execute rapid tonal shifts within paragraphs, to whipsaw into armored zingers from the heights of dreamy introspection. When Jordan first appears, during rehearsals, he comes off as self-protective, bright, and exasperating. After the attack, his witty, vulnerable voice holds together a chaotic and increasingly hallucinatory downward slide. He spies one of his attackers, a closeted man named Gareth, at a clandestine gay bar, and resolves to insinuate himself into his life, with the goal of eventually exposing him. The two start ambivalently sleeping together, and then dating each other. Throughout, terms like "anger" and "revenge" fail to express Jordan's actual afflictions: the unbearable intimacies of identification, the ravages of sexual need. "Revenge never told me what revenge is supposed to be," he says. "It just sits there like a fucking word."

There's a dark and delirious symmetry to the way Jordan and Gareth mirror each other's self-hatred and desperate longing. The effect is claustrophobic, but, as with James's other doublings, it's also erotic, entrancing, and even freeing. The terror and the beauty of Jordan and Gareth's assignations are that both men stop being able to tell themselves apart. Unsettlingly, the roles of victim and perpetrator bleed together. Who is seducing whom, and does it matter? Who is punishing, and who is being punished? These passages yield some of the book's best writing. Likewise, James's descriptions of cruising feel oddly creative, fluid, and primordial: at night, in a thicket of trees, it's "all darkness and shadow and all touch and smell and taste," Jordan thinks, and "a tongue is in my mouth before I say anything," and "the hands refuse to stop grabbing, rubbing, and squeezing." The fungibility of the hands is a reprieve from the book's scenes of violence and its fallout, from the endless assigning of blame and the apportioning out of mercy or destruction.

In a tenderly melancholic moment, Jordan imagines a sexual encounter between two of his castmates—the novel's tentative version of fulfillment. He pictures one of the boys thinking, mid-

hookup, that “this shit is unreal” and seeking confirmation that “all of this is not some dream.” Of course, it is unreal, a play that Jordan is putting on in his mind. But it’s a play in which, unlike the larger drama that he and his fellow-actors have unwillingly been thrust into, the pain of being gay doesn’t nullify the pleasure. The role you inhabit can steal your future and imprison you in the past; it can also usher you into decent society at the cost of your soul (and it’s no accident that one of the narrowest closets in the novel turns out to be evangelical Christianity). But the permeability of James’s protagonists suggests that more than just these parts are possible. “The Disappearers” uses the tricks of fiction to pull off something extremely difficult: giving full weight to tragedy and injustice without implying that some lives are over before they’ve begun. ♦

Katy Waldman, a staff writer, has written about books and culture for The New Yorker since 2018.

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/the-disappearers-marlon-james-book-review>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

Books

Has the Supreme Court Sandbagged Democracy?

A new legal history argues that the Justices should be stripped of their power to overrule coequal branches of government. It arrives at an awkward moment.

By [Daniel Immerwahr](#)

August 31, 2026



These days, as Congress passes fewer laws, the judicial battleground is shifting away from the legislature, toward the President's furious tempest of executive orders.

Illustration by Till Lauer

The liberal list of Republican offenses is long—so long, indeed, that the outrages blur. That time [Ted Cruz shut down the government](#) for two weeks seems like a century ago, and, if anyone was ever angry about the White House promoting Melania Trump's jewelry line, I can't remember. One wound still festers, though: the

Senate's refusal in 2016 to consider Barack Obama's Supreme Court nominee, Merrick Garland.

Even before Obama named a candidate to fill the seat left vacant by Antonin Scalia's sudden death, Republicans had announced their opposition. "Mr. President, you will not fill the Supreme Court vacancy," Mitch McConnell, the Senate Majority Leader, declared. By nominating Garland, a moderate with admirers on both sides of the widening aisle, Obama offered Republicans a gamble: take Garland now or face whatever Pan-African, gender-free communist Hillary Clinton would summon from the judicial depths when she stepped into the Oval Office in 2017.

Republicans decided to risk it, insisting that eight months before an election was too soon to consider an outgoing President's nominee. Blocking Garland helped their flailing candidate, Donald Trump. He boiled his pitch to hesitant conservatives down to two words, shouted at rallies: "Supreme Court."

What We're Reading

Discover notable new fiction, nonfiction, and poetry.



Supreme Court. Trump lost the popular vote but won the election. Extraordinarily, this allowed him to appoint three Justices: Neil Gorsuch to fill Scalia's seat, Brett Kavanaugh to fill that of the retiring Anthony Kennedy, and Amy Coney Barrett, whom Republicans rushed to confirm after Ruth Bader Ginsburg died, at eighty-seven, less than two months before the 2020 election. Trump increased his impact by selecting youthful appointees. If they last as long as Ginsburg did, the oldest, Kavanaugh, will serve through

2052, and the youngest, Barrett, until 2059. “No plausible definition of democracy makes this situation reasonable, let alone desirable,” Erwin Chemerinsky, the dean of U.C. Berkeley’s law school, has written.

Chemerinsky isn’t the first to gape at the Supreme Court’s undemocratic features. The Court is often described as “counter-majoritarian”; its composition doesn’t shift with the political winds. There’s an argument for this. Insulated from elections, Justices can guard against the frenzies that occasionally seize the voting public. Judicial power allows “Philip sober to control Philip drunk,” as Justice David Brewer famously put it in 1893.

Essentially, the Supreme Court is our democracy’s appointed buzzkill. In the early nineteen-thirties, it swatted down New Deal legislation passed by congressional majorities. In the fifties and sixties, it overturned segregationist laws enacted by state and local legislatures.

The Supreme Court is like ranked-choice voting or Jdate: how you feel about it depends on whether it’s delivering what you want. Which makes today’s situation confusing. A lawless President is asserting boundless authority, a Republican Congress is playing along, and it’s unclear, from case to case, where the Court will land. The Harvard law professor Cass R. Sunstein’s new book, “[Separation of Powers](#)” (M.I.T.), compares this state of affairs to the Nazi era and calls for a strong, independent judiciary. Trump won the popular vote; if there were ever a time for Philip sober to splash cold water on an inebriated majority, this would be it.

Except Philip is serving bottomless mimosas, the Court’s detractors claim. Yes, the Justices struck down Trump’s tariffs and preserved birthright citizenship. But they also gutted the Voting Rights Act, blocked federal remedies to fix extreme gerrymandering, permitted the President to fire commissioners of most regulatory bodies at will, and granted him broad immunity from criminal prosecution

for acts undertaken in his official capacity. The last ruling, the three dissenting Justices have warned, “effectively creates a law-free zone around the President,” rendering him immune even if he “organizes a military coup” or “orders the Navy’s Seal Team 6 to assassinate a political rival.”

Two of Sunstein’s Harvard colleagues, Nikolas Bowie and Daphna Renan, take a different approach. In their formidable, sharply argued book, “[Supremacy](#)” (Norton), they distinguish two often conflated powers. The power of vertical review allows the Supreme Court to invalidate state and local laws that, in the Justices’ view, contradict federal ones. The power of horizontal review allows the Court to overrule a coequal branch of government and strike down federal laws or regulations. Few make this distinction today, but it reveals a pattern, Bowie and Renan contend: vertical review cuts both ways for liberal democracy, but horizontal review reliably serves regressive ends.

Most critics of judicial supremacy stumble over the fact that a strong Court sometimes benefits their side. Bowie and Renan, by identifying a consistently conservative power of the Court, vault that obstacle. Their case is then straightforward, albeit provocative: using horizontal review, the Supreme Court has sandbagged democracy. The thing needed, even in the days of galloping authoritarianism, is to cut the Court down to size.

Although the Supreme Court’s power to overrule Congress is now broadly accepted, it was bitterly contested for more than a century. Scholars have long known this, and Bowie and Renan’s book follows the tracks of important works like Larry D. Kramer’s “[The People Themselves](#)” (2004), Keith E. Whittington’s “[Political Foundations of Judicial Supremacy](#)” (2007), and Barry Friedman’s “[The Will of the People](#)” (2009). What Bowie and Renan add is that the loudest protests against horizontal review historically came from abolitionists, labor organizers, suffragists, and civil-rights activists.

As those critics noted, the Constitution doesn't expressly authorize the Court to overturn acts of Congress. That right was supposedly established by *Marbury v. Madison*, in 1803. President John Adams, after losing his 1800 reelection bid, used his lame-duck period to fill the judiciary with sympathizers. But some orders commissioning justices of the peace, though signed by Adams and sealed by his Secretary of State, went undelivered. The Court had to decide whether Thomas Jefferson's Administration could be forced to turn them over, under the Judiciary Act of 1789.

It was a bizarre case, reflecting the era's anything-goes atmosphere. John Marshall, the Chief Justice, had been the Secretary of State who'd sealed those commissions and been responsible for their delivery. Jefferson, his cousin, tried to block the case by signing a federal law that prevented the Court from meeting for fourteen months. Marshall then used *Marbury v. Madison* to proclaim the Court's ability to invalidate federal laws that it deemed unconstitutional. Bowie and Renan point out that Marshall (perhaps intentionally) misread the statute that he was invalidating, making the whole thing a turducken of judicial folly.

Because the Court lacked a permanent abode, Marshall read out the ruling from the steps outside Stelle's Hotel, on Capitol Hill. As with most impassioned avowals made on hotel steps, Congress ignored it. The *Marbury* decision didn't compel anyone to do anything, so Marshall's assertion just hung in the air.

Judicial assertions meant less back then. In ways that are hard to conceive of now, early-nineteenth-century politicians simply defied the Court. States regularly declined to appear before it when ordered. "Virginia's highest court refused to concede that the Supreme Court had the authority to review its decisions," Friedman writes. "Georgia actually hanged a man in the face of a Supreme Court order to the contrary."

Within this rowdy milieu, there was nonetheless a growing constituency for “Philip sober” guardrails. The most eloquent plea for protections against zealous majorities came from the South Carolina statesman John C. Calhoun. His “[Disquisition on Government](#),” published posthumously, in 1851, captured the view of the imperilled minority to which Calhoun himself belonged: slaveholders.

It is, of course, Noah’s-flood-on-your-wedding-day ironic that slaveholders would see themselves as oppressed. But a population boom in the North and the mainstreaming of antislavery politics there raised the threat of a legislative majority abolishing their property. Passions ran especially hot over slavery in the territories, where federal law held sway. The President elected in 1856, James Buchanan, swore that the “great object” of his Administration would be “to arrest, if possible, the agitation of the slavery question.” Buchanan secretly pressed the Court to take the divisive issue out of politicians’ hands. The Chief Justice, Roger B. Taney, obliged. In *Dred Scott v. Sandford*, his Court held that Black people lacked U.S. citizenship and that congressional bans on territorial slavery were unconstitutional.

Dred Scott, decided in 1857, was the Court’s first use of horizontal review since *Marbury* and its first substantial use of the power ever. It is widely regarded as the Court’s worst decision—a “hell-black judgment,” the abolitionist Frederick Douglass called it. But Douglass didn’t take *Dred Scott* as settled law; he took it as an invitation to challenge the Court’s authority. Outrage at Taney’s power grab filled the sails of the antislavery Republican Party and ultimately propelled Abraham Lincoln to the Presidency. In his Inaugural Address of 1861, he declared that permitting robed Justices to settle major disputes would mean that “the people will have ceased to be their own rulers.”

And so, like many before him, Lincoln defied the Court. After eleven slaveholding states seceded to form the Confederacy,

Republican lawmakers passed and Lincoln signed a bill that flouted Dred Scott by prohibiting slavery in the territories. Bowie and Renan view this as a heartening reminder that the elected branches of government needn't defer to the judiciary.

Taney remained Chief Justice until 1864, when he died. During the Civil War, he watched impotently as the Lincoln Administration brushed off rulings on habeas corpus, Black citizenship, and, of course, slavery. "There was no sadder figure to be seen in Washington," the journalist E. V. Smalley wrote. "He had outlived his epoch, and was shunned and hated by the men of the new time."

The reign of Republicans during the Civil War and Reconstruction was a democratic breakthrough in two senses. First, legislative majorities overrode the Court, repeatedly ignoring its rulings and adjusting the number of Justices to prevent its interference. Second, those majorities abolished slavery, extended citizenship, and guaranteed equal protection to all Americans. The historian Eric Foner, in "[The Second Founding](#)" (2019), describes this as the country's "first attempt, flawed but truly remarkable for its time, to build an egalitarian society on the ashes of slavery."

The Court struck back. Toward the end of Reconstruction, it began regularly overturning federal legislation. "By the end of the century, the Supreme Court undid nearly every major law Congress passed to protect multiracial democracy in the South," Bowie and Renan write. It then turned to opposing labor unions, farmers' organizations, and capitalism's other foes.

This was the context for Justice Brewer's remarks about Philip sober restraining Philip drunk. Judicial sobriety, for Brewer, meant protecting the respectable white man from "the anarchist, the socialist, and every other assassin of liberty." The "eager and earnest protest of the Anglo-Saxon" was for "individual freedom and absolute protection of all his rights of person and property," Brewer explained, in 1893. Two years later, he joined a majority in

finding the federal income tax unconstitutional. (It would take a constitutional amendment to restore the government's power to tax incomes.)

Between 1890 and 1936, using both horizontal and vertical review, the Court invalidated more than two hundred progressive statutes, state and federal. Historians call this the *Lochner* era, for *Lochner v. New York*, a 1905 case holding that a New York law limiting working hours violated the Fourteenth Amendment. In a characteristic turn, the Justices redeployed protections intended for Black citizens to benefit business owners.

Even establishment politicians like Teddy Roosevelt balked. He proposed allowing voters to overturn judicial decisions by ballot. If the spirit of *Lochner* were to prevail, he warned, “we should not only have a revolution, but it would be absolutely necessary to have a revolution.”

Such mutinous talk only heightened conservative Justices' sense that the barbarians were storming the gate. “I must stay on the court in order to prevent the Bolsheviki from getting control,” Chief Justice William Howard Taft wrote to his brother, in 1929. As President, Taft had blocked Arizona and New Mexico's joint bid for statehood because Arizona's proposed constitution would have allowed voters to recall judges. As Chief Justice, he persuaded Congress to move the Court from its rooms within the Capitol to a dedicated marble edifice with bronze doors weighing six and a half tons apiece.

It was a “magnificent structure,” the columnist Howard Brubaker remarked upon its opening, with “fine big windows to throw the New Deal out of.” Indeed, after Democrats won the Presidency, the House, and the Senate in 1932, the largely Republican-appointed Supreme Court stood as a citadel of *laissez-faire* capitalism against the national zeal for economic controls.

The familiar understanding is that F.D.R. subdued the conservative Justices by threatening to enlarge the bench and swamp it with his appointees. This is a myth; they started to yield before he made that threat. And, in a way, the standoff reflected the judiciary's growing authority. Unlike its nineteenth-century critics, F.D.R. had implicitly accepted horizontal review; his challenge had been to the Court's orientation, not its powers. Once that orientation changed, the marble-ensconced Court was supremer than ever.

By the time F.D.R. died, in 1945, he had appointed seven of the Supreme Court's nine Justices. This inaugurated a golden age of liberalism and a break with the Court's theretofore conservative history. When Earl Warren presided, from 1953 to 1969, the Court helped make voting fairer, establish rights for criminal defendants, and dismantle Jim Crow. The Warren Court's watershed decision of 1954, *Brown v. Board of Education of Topeka*, which rejected segregation in public schools, is revered with the same intensity that *Dred Scott* is reviled.

Brown was a moment of both moral clarity and jurisprudential mystification, Bowie and Renan maintain. The lawyers for the plaintiffs, including the future Supreme Court Justice Thurgood Marshall, had grounded their argument partly in a Reconstruction-era federal statute, the Ku Klux Klan Act. The case could be understood, then, as a straightforward matter of striking down state laws that violated a national one. It's far from clear that the Court saw it this way, though; its unanimous opinion didn't mention the Klan Act. Bowie and Renan lament the omission. Although the Court was, in their view, merely enforcing Congress's will, it "gave the impression, whether intentionally or not, that it was acting alone, regardless of what Congress wanted."

This is a crucial plank in Bowie and Renan's argument. A Supreme Court lacking the power of horizontal review could still have issued the *Brown* decision. Most of the Warren Court's admirable activism, they say, was in fact vertical review, targeting state and

local statutes. They are correct. Of the twenty-four landmark Warren Court decisions listed by the legal website [Justia](#), none overturned an act of Congress. If the Warren Justices had a bone to pick with legislators, it was with the state and local ones upholding Jim Crow.

To be sure, overturning a federal law is rare during any era of the Court. The Justices' daily business involves resolving ambiguities, clarifying jurisdiction, harmonizing conflicting statutes, and adjudicating conflicts in special jurisdictions. And of the 1,514 laws that the Supreme Court struck down from its inception to mid-2017, only a hundred and eighty-two of them—twelve per cent—were federal. The Warren Court's relative respect for federal laws was thus noticeable but not startling.

Although there haven't been many federal invalidations, Bowie and Renan rightly observe that they account for some of the most regrettable decisions in Supreme Court history. In horizontal-review mode, the Court has struck down laws limiting slavery and child labor, establishing income taxes and minimum wages, and restricting corporations from tilting elections or firing workers for union activity. Horizontal-review success stories include invalidating the part of the Defense of Marriage Act defining marriage as exclusively between a man and a woman; few others come to mind. The triumphs are “dwarfed” by the “vastly larger” set of disasters, Bowie and Renan write.

The Warren Court had little need for horizontal review, Bowie and Renan believe, but it clung to that power nonetheless. A decision mandating school desegregation in Little Rock, Arkansas—signed by every Justice, for boldface emphasis—insisted that the Court's supremacy over the other branches in interpreting the Constitution had been accepted since Marbury as “permanent and indispensable.” As history, this was ludicrous. The Warren Court, while making substantively democratic rulings, cemented a procedurally undemocratic arrangement.

Yet it was hard to mind back then. This was the heroic era of “[12 Angry Men](#),” “[Inherit the Wind](#),” and “[To Kill a Mockingbird](#),” of principled men defending the law against racists and religious zealots. The Court seemed noble to progressives—maybe even cool. In 1970, Warren, recently retired, addressed a packed quad at the University of California, San Diego. The school had been roiled by protests, so when students unfurled a banner Warren’s supporters feared the worst. But the banner said “Right On, Big Earl!” and the crowd roared.

In gratifying the left, the Warren Court debilitated the long tradition of opposing judicial supremacy. Just how debilitated it was became clear in the deadlocked Presidential contest between George W. Bush and Al Gore. In a similarly close nineteenth-century election, between Rutherford B. Hayes and Samuel J. Tilden, Congress had taken charge and no one had “ever dreamed of trying to resolve it in litigation,” Larry D. Kramer notes. Yet, in 2000, the dispute went through the judiciary as a matter of course. After the Supreme Court decided for Bush, who’d lost the popular vote, Democrats acquiesced. “While I strongly disagree with the Court’s decision, I accept it,” Gore said, adding that the process had shown the “strength of American democracy.”

Late-twentieth-century politicians had grown comfortable with the Court’s authority. They could accept a view of politics as a turn-based game: the checks that they abhorred when they were in power, like horizontal review and the filibuster, became crucial when they were out. Counter-majoritarian arrangements insured that democracy didn’t devolve into two parties taking turns tyrannizing each other.

Democrats, with their signature concern for minority rights, had additional reasons to distrust straightforward majority rule. The legal theorist Lani Guinier argued in the nineteen-nineties that winner-take-all elections endangered Black individuals like her, who made up only ten per cent of voters. Thinking along the lines

that John C. Calhoun once had, she considered alternative voting systems that could guard against “the tyranny of the majority.” Guinier’s more exotic ideas stirred controversy. (“Loony Lani,” right-wingers called her, among other things.) But she argued that minority protections made intuitive sense. She noted that her four-year-old son, Niko, had spontaneously proposed some when adjudicating which game a group of children should play.

That four-year-old, Nikolas Bowie, is now a Harvard law professor and in a different mood. His book with Daphna Renan vigorously defends majority rule against institutional impediments. The two authors cling to Congress, which they deem “more democratic than the Supreme Court.” For all its flaws, it “*is* our institution for translating the people’s power into enacted law.”

Bowie and Renan’s view fits a growing liberal discontent with the Court, no doubt stemming from Democrats’ recent failures to fill its seats. In principle, the Supreme Court supplies general drag, forcing whichever party is in power to contend with Justices appointed by previous Administrations. But the friction coefficient is now far greater in one direction. In the span of the Presidencies that yielded today’s Court, Republicans won the popular vote less than a third of the time but have appointed two-thirds of the current Justices.

In the first half of Joe Biden’s Presidency, Democrats controlled the White House and Congress yet faced a conservative Court, thanks partly to the Merrick Garland mishegoss. This was the exasperating moment when Bowie and Renan started publishing their critique of judicial supremacy and their demand to “reclaim the authority of Congress.” Biden called for reforms, too, in his final year, recommending that the Court’s Justices be limited to eighteen-year terms, staggered so that Presidents could appoint one every two years.

The Republican House Speaker, Mike Johnson, declared Biden's proposal "dead on arrival." Certainly, Biden's planned announcement of his Court-reform scheme was drowned out by his less planned announcement, the same month, of his withdrawal from the 2024 Presidential race. At that point, Biden's talk of mandatory retirement for aging officeholders hit awfully close to home.

Bowie and Renan want elected officials to reassert their authority over appointed Justices. Although the model they point to is Republicans in the eighteen-sixties, the most prominent case of this today is Israel. Its Supreme Court has rejected draft exemptions for ultra-Orthodox Jews and overturned a law legalizing settler homes built on private Palestinian land. That, in turn, has led Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's right-wing parliamentary majority to announce [plans to overhaul the judiciary](#), including removing its horizontal-review power. (Unsurprisingly, the Supreme Court has struck down a law that would have constrained its ability to strike down laws.) Netanyahu's allies present their ongoing judicial-reform campaign as a defense of the popular will.

Donald Trump shares Netanyahu's impatience with meddling judges. Whereas his recent predecessors grouched about the Supreme Court's decisions yet acknowledged its larger usefulness, Trump, a *YOLO* President, is ready to napalm whatever obstructs his immediate interests. After the Court gave his birthright-citizenship executive order a skeptical hearing, he blasted his own appointees as "fools and lap dogs" and threatened to "PACK THE COURT!" Trump's Vice-President, J. D. Vance, has warned of an "effort by the courts to quite literally overturn the will of the American people." He's admonished the Supreme Court to be "extremely deferential" to decisions "made by the people's elected President."

Trump and Vance worry that the Supreme Court will thwart executive actions. Although Congress doesn't pass many laws these

days, the White House has been a furious tempest of executive orders. And so the judicial battleground today isn't between the Court and Congress but between the Court and the Presidency.

The Supreme Court's self-granted power to declare executive actions unconstitutional hardly appears in Bowie and Renan's history. But it's hard to see how this power could be legitimate by their logic. If the Court is trammelling democracy when it overturns acts of Congress, isn't it doing the same when it overrules a popularly elected President?

Bowie and Renan's book, imploring politicians to defy the Court and obey the people, would have fit a Kamala Harris Administration perfectly. Trump's reelection, however, makes their "popular will versus injustice" framing harder to nod along with. Democrats could once take comfort in the notion that theirs was the popular side, with only the vagaries of the Electoral College and the iniquities of corporate campaign donations preventing them from permanently occupying the Oval Office. Yet in 2024 Trump, despite being significantly outspent, not only won the popular vote but did especially well with the working class. If the people had a will in that election, it was for deportations, tariffs, and cage matches on the South Lawn.

The Supreme Court has been a fitful friend to Trump in his second term, alternately enabling and impeding him. Much of its aid has come in unsigned rulings on the emergency docket—ostensibly temporary and non-precedent-setting judgments that nevertheless carry serious consequences. Horizontal review hasn't yet seen much play. But, given that the Republicans now control both houses of Congress and the Presidency, curbing Trump might require firing that torpedo.

Bowie and Renan's compelling history doesn't lead one to expect much there. The Court has been persistently reactionary in its dealings with other branches, using horizontal review to protect

enslavers from abolitionists, bosses from unions, and tycoons from tax collectors. Justice would have been better served, historically, by the Justices butting out.

Still, is now the time to desupremify the Court? Trump has been losing both support and inhibition. He's likely to turn desperate as he finishes his second term, and he has threatened to seek a third. This is precisely the scenario that defenders of judicial supremacy have long warned about: Philip on a drunken rampage.

It is, as the grocers say, a pickle. Philip sober has been no friend to democracy. These days, though, he might be its best hope. ♦

Daniel Immerwahr, a contributing writer at *The New Yorker*, teaches history at Northwestern University and is the author of "[How to Hide an Empire: A History of the Greater United States](#)."

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/supremacy-nikolas-bowie-daphna-renan-book-review>

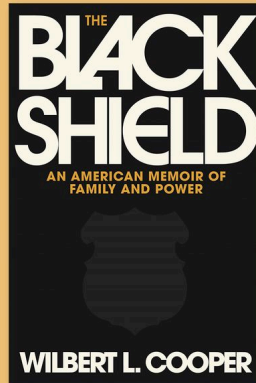
| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

Books

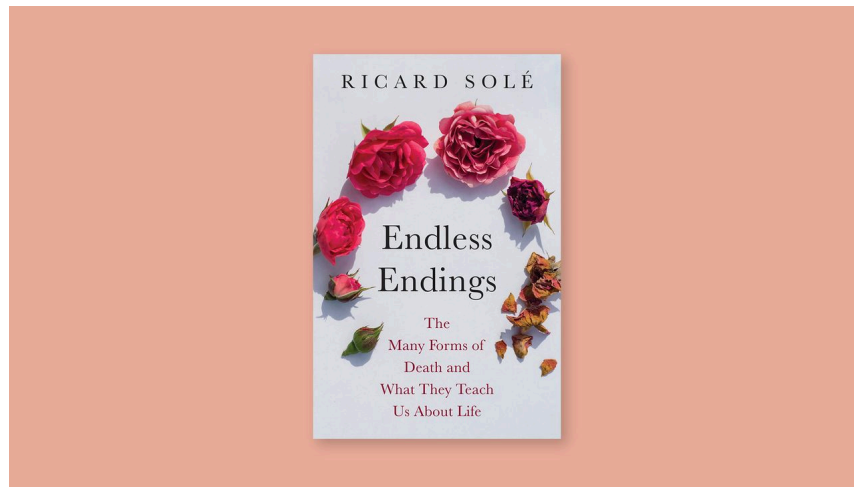
Briefly Noted

“The Black Shield,” “Endless Endings,” “Solstice,” and “I Was Bonnie & Clyde.”

August 31, 2026



The Black Shield, by Wilbert L. Cooper (Farrar, Straus & Giroux). In this multilayered work, a journalist examines a Black police organization, known as the Black Shield, that emerged in Cleveland in the nineteen-forties, alongside his own parents’ membership in it. Cooper assesses the notion that Black communities are “safer and served better” when the police who surveil and discipline them are Black, too. In theory, he writes, the Black Shield offers opportunity for young people living in the economically distressed community where it is based, but he concludes that the group is less focussed on justice than on “getting the same lack of accountability that White officers enjoyed.” His ultimate indictment is nuanced, and has shades of appreciation—for his parents, and for the badge that “shielded my family.”



Endless Endings, by Ricard Solé, translated from the Spanish by Eduardo Aparicio (Princeton). A single cell serves as the starting point for this lyrical exploration of death. From a consideration of apoptosis—the orderly elimination of damaged or unnecessary cells—Solé moves on to failing machines, eroded memories, vanished languages, brittle digital archives, and more. His overarching idea is that organisms, minds, technologies, and cultures survive by sustaining flows of matter, energy, or information; their final deaths occur not when a single constituent part disappears but when the processes holding the larger system together falter. Solé reveals a paradox: death is not merely life’s opposite but also one of its organizing forces, a constant cycle of removal and renewal through which complex systems are preserved.

What We’re Reading

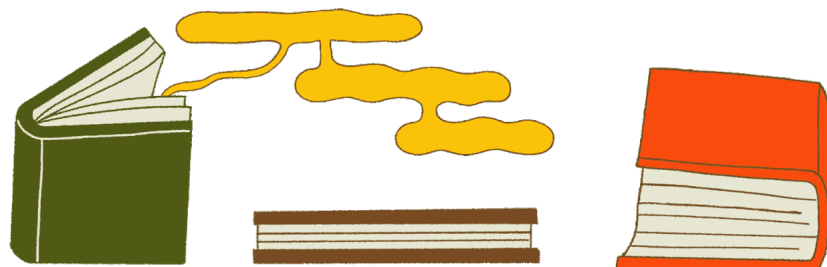
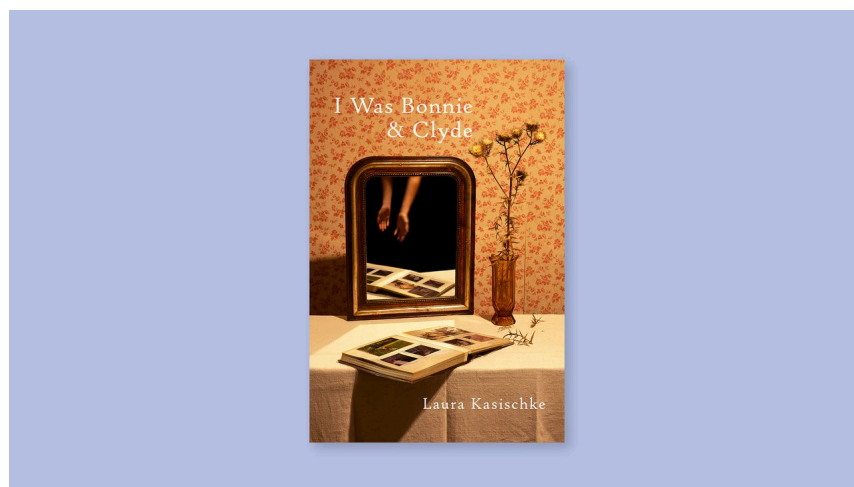


Illustration by Henri Campeã

Discover notable new fiction, nonfiction, and poetry.



Solstice, by *Carol Gilligan (Random House)*. This tender novel of intimacy and its risks begins in Boston in 1969, as Eve, a dancer, commences an affair with a colleague—an indiscretion that spurs her husband, a journalist named Gabe, to cheat, too. Under the influence of their era’s changing sexual mores, they soon reconcile. But then, in the eighties, Gabe returns from a reporting trip to the Middle East having taken up with a much younger woman. By this time, the couple share decades of history, along with three children. Gilligan’s portrait of their relationship is a study of how time binds people together. “There was a membrane now stretching between them,” she writes, “encompassing the two of them and enclosing them, fragile and yet impermeable.”



I Was Bonnie & Clyde, by *Laura Kasischke (Copper Canyon)*. The wily, beguiling poems in this collection probe selves and stories as sites of rupture and refraction. The book’s eponymous

poem, for instance, begins, “You were Friday & Death. / I was Jekyll & Hyde. / You were my mother. / I Alive.” Throughout, Kasischke’s images ricochet off one another—suggesting narrative while resisting its confines, evoking stereotypical ideas and expectations of Western womanhood only to upend them. In a voice at once biting and contemplative, eerie and funny, Kasischke crafts poems in which nothing is ever stable or resolved. There is only “The confusion of the past / as fireproof as ash. // The follies of the future / as bulletproof as water.”

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/the-black-shield-endless-endings-solstice-i-was-bonnie-and-clyde>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

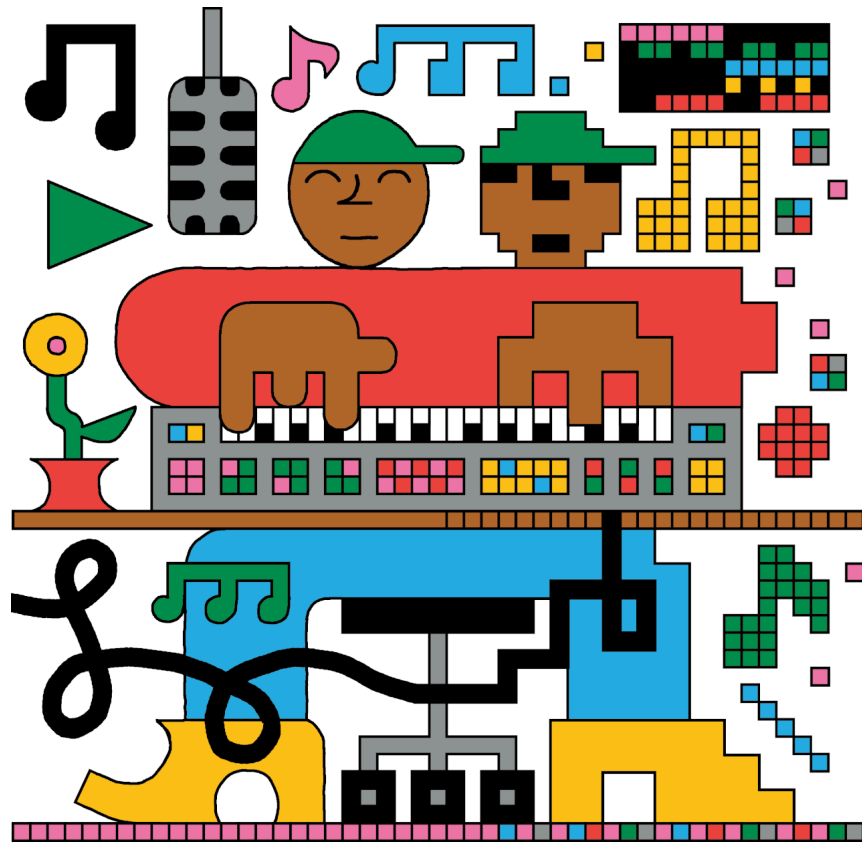
Pop Music

Who's Afraid of A.I. Music?

When the rapper Fenix Flexin debuted a new accent on his single “Rubberz,” he stumbled into a century-old fight over musical fraudulence.

By [Kelefa Sanneh](#)

August 31, 2026



Startups including Suno allow users to create songs with A.I., and some A.I. entities have started to attract followings on Spotify.

Illustration by Mathieu Labrecque

Earlier this summer, a small night club in Passaic, New Jersey, hosted a brief performance by one of the year’s most talked-about musicians. A post on Instagram had promised attendees “an unforgettable night,” although not necessarily a long one: the only assurance was that the Los Angeles rapper known as Fenix Flexin would be “performing his viral hit ‘Rubberz’ live!” Until recently, Fenix was known for high-spirited and slightly mush-mouthed hip-

hop tracks, but “Rubberz,” which was released in June, marked a dramatic change: it was sad but sprightly synth pop, like an unheard outtake from the nineteen-eighties; the vocals were crisp, with a hint of vibrato and a faintly British accent. Listeners seemed to delight in the incongruity—a semipopular rapper suddenly sounded nothing like himself.

Plenty of people thought they knew why. They guessed that the song had been created with artificial intelligence, which makes it trivially easy to generate a realistic song using nothing more than a brief description. Perhaps the voice on the track didn’t belong to Fenix, or, in fact, to anyone at all. The rapper appeared to deny this. When the YouTube journalist Andrew Callaghan asked Fenix whether he wanted to clear up misconceptions about “Rubberz,” he declined. “Oh, like the A.I. shit?” he said. “Nah. Shit is recorded like any other song.” He also sang some of the words for Callaghan, although neither the sound of his voice nor the lyrics he delivered were an exact match. “The watch is getting quicker,” he crooned; on the recording, it’s “The watch is *moving* quicker.”

On this night in New Jersey, no one seemed inclined to conduct a forensic investigation into the authenticity of the song, which Fenix performed twice, singing along with a prerecorded version of it and reproducing the slightly weird pronunciation: “Money talk is much louder now,” he sang, stressing the second syllable in the line. “Hatin’ that I’m able,” he sang, pronouncing the sharp “t” in the first word, rather than softening or eliding it, the way most Americans would. He even did a few lines a cappella, which might have been a message to the doubters, or else a concession to tradition: suffice it to say that Fenix Flexin is not the first rapper to find himself in a night club, at 1 A.M., performing a notably imprecise rendition of his own hit single.

All summer long, as “Rubberz” was becoming harder to ignore, so, too, were questions about A.I. in music. When Kanye West released the album “Bully,” in March, fans tried to figure out whether

certain tracks had been created with A.I., a technology West had previously praised. (West was later sued by a producer who claimed he had helped the artist create A.I. vocals on “Bully” and its predecessor, “Vultures II.”) Startups including Suno allow users to create songs partly or wholly powered by A.I., and some A.I. entities have begun to attract followings: Eddie Dalton, an old-school soul singer who corresponds to no physical human being that we know of, has half a million monthly listeners on Spotify—about as many as Clarence Carter, who died in May, at the age of ninety. In June, an Australian producer and d.j. named Josh Fawaz made it to No. 4 on the *Billboard* Hot Dance / Electronic Songs chart with an A.I. version of “Like a Prayer.” And HUGEL, a popular French d.j. and producer, has one of the summer’s biggest dance hits with “Movin’ to the Sun,” which seems to be a remix of an A.I. track that was originally associated with a social-media account said to belong to a Reiki healer from Hungary known as Imael Angel. The new version is jointly credited to HUGEL, Imael Angel, and the legendary house-music singer Ultra Naté, who apparently lent her human voice to this transhuman collaboration.

It would be an understatement to say that the growing prominence of A.I. music is generating backlash—sometimes it seems this music generates nothing *but* backlash. A producer named Medasin made a video arguing, convincingly, that Fenix and his collaborator Purps on the Beat had used an A.I. program called Treblo to make “Rubberz,” and he showed how easy the process might have been. (Using simple prompts such as “synthwave 80s” and “lyrics that are resemblant of a rapper lifestyle,” Medasin got the app to spit out a distinctly “Rubberz”-like song.) Afterward, Fenix changed his story. “Never said I didn’t use AI,” he wrote on Instagram, adding, “ain’t nothing wrong w using new technology as a tool keep up w the times or get left behind.” When a puckish British electronic duo known as Two Shell talked, in a recent interview, about using A.I., Tom Breihan, a senior editor for the music site *Stereogum*, delivered an unambiguous verdict that summed up the general

mood: “No! Wack! Fuck that shit!” A month ago, a rapper named Tyga released a synth-pop album of his own, and he spoke freely about using A.I. to make it. His reward was a score of 0.0 from *Pitchfork* (the site’s first zero rating in nearly twenty years), and a similarly harsh review from the pop star Doja Cat: “Tyga is a penis for making an A.I. album.”

Sometimes this backlash concerns the ethical implications of A.I., which produces music by drawing from preexisting songs, often without compensating the humans who made them. (“I feel like I’m at war because of A.I.,” the singer SZA said, in a recent interview.) But even more people seem concerned about the way A.I. lowers the barriers to musical entry, allowing would-be musicians to skip the step where they learn a skill or express a feeling. Many listeners—and not a few musicians—regard the process of making a song with A.I. as not just uncreative but anti-creative, and maybe anti-human, too. Earlier this year, the musician and producer Jack Antonoff posted a brief manifesto online, which said, “To everyone who is gassed up about the new ways you can fake making art, by all means drive right off that cliff.” To Antonoff and others, A.I. music seems neither good nor bad but something else altogether: fraudulent.

The fight against musical fraudulence has a long and illustrious history. The current battle dates at least to 1906, when John Philip Sousa testified before the House Committee on Patents. Sousa, who wrote military marches such as “The Stars and Stripes Forever,” was perhaps the most popular composer America ever produced, and he had come to deliver a warning. “These talking machines are going to ruin the artistic development of music in this country,” he said, of a device that was a few decades old and growing in popularity—the phonograph. In an essay published the same year, Sousa referred to phonographic cylinders and disks as “canned music,” a degraded form that could never, he said, capture or transmit the qualities that make music special. “Music teaches all that is beautiful in this world,” Sousa wrote. “Let us not hamper it

with a machine that tells the story day by day, without variation, without soul, barren of the joy, the passion, the ardor that is the inheritance of man alone.” Sousa’s concern was not entirely aesthetic: part of his complaint about what he called “infernal machines” was that phonograph manufacturers paid no royalties to composers; his testimony helped inspire the 1909 Copyright Act, which changed that. In 1930, when theatres were replacing live orchestras with prerecorded soundtracks, the American Federation of Musicians launched a new campaign against “canned music,” buying a series of newspaper advertisements to decry the “corruption of an art by soulless mechanization.” One image depicted a man playing guitar flanked by a robot playing a banjo, and the text made an argument that many A.I. skeptics repeat today: “Where there is no feeling, no emotional capacity, there can be no music.”

Of course, this canned music was composed and performed by humans; “mechanization” referred only to the technology that allowed the performances to be recorded and played back. Aldous Huxley, in his novel “Brave New World,” from 1932, imagined, instead, a “synthetic music machine” able to autonomously create an endless soundtrack; around the same time, a company called Muzak was commissioning instrumental recordings that it delivered, via telephone wire, to workplaces and homes, creating a non-stop stream of background music. (In this magazine, in 1947, a Muzak executive described his product as “music you can eat to, shave to, work to, but not listen to.”) Muzak was a corporate success, although it swiftly became a cultural punch line—people used “Muzak” as a pejorative term for anything dull and low-quality. Starting in the eighties, the company began to supplement its library with original recordings of popular songs: a slightly less canned version of canned music. The company abandoned the name Muzak in 2013, by which time most of us had long stopped noticing the omnipresence of background music in our daily lives. Sousa was wrong to imagine that America might be able to resist

the lure of the phonographic disk and its successors, but he was right to imagine that the recording industry would transform our ideas about what music is, while more or less killing off the tradition of the after-dinner sing-along and all but eliminating pianos from the nation's living rooms. In popular music especially, the authentic artifact is now the recording, while a live performance is typically an ancillary experience.

As recording studios became more sophisticated, and more central to popular music, artists occasionally sought to reassure fans that they were really hearing what they thought they were hearing. The self-titled début album from the band Queen, from 1973, included in its instrumental credits a stern disclaimer: “. . . and nobody played synthesizer.” The rock band Boston issued a similar statement (“No Synthesizers Used”) in a 1978 album, and so did Rage Against the Machine in 1992 (“*NO SAMPLES, KEYBOARDS OR SYNTHESIZERS USED IN THE MAKING OF THIS RECORDING*”), and the White Stripes in 2003 (“No computers were used during the writing, recording, mixing or mastering of this record”). By contrast, Stevie Wonder seemed proud to tell listeners that his 1972 album, “Music of My Mind,” contained both Moog and ARP synthesizers, which were then a novelty. He emphasized that his album was “virtually the work of one man”; technology was making it easier for musicians to work alone, helping them to create records that could be touted as *more* personal. Many pioneers of electronic pop acknowledged this tension by making music that was self-consciously robotic, like Kraftwerk paying tribute to “the man-machine” or Ultravox singing, deadpan, “I want to be a machine.” And yet these synth-pop musicians were nevertheless eager to insist that their music was *real* music. In a documentary about the synthesizer era, Andy McCluskey, from the English electronic-pop group Orchestral Manoeuvres in the Dark, described his creations in terms Sousa might have appreciated: “It was all written by real human beings, and it was all played by hand.”

It may be no coincidence that “Rubberz” drew inspiration from this period in particular. (It sounds a little bit like “If You Leave,” an O.M.D. hit from 1986.) The song is a pastiche of a form of musical innovation that now sounds quaint, precisely because of its perceptible artificiality; the sharp backbeat and arpeggiated synthesizers remind us of an earlier and perhaps simpler time. By the end of the eighties, discussions of musical authenticity usually centered on the use of prerecorded sounds. In hip-hop and other genres, producers were using snippets of other people’s records; courts often ruled that this was a form of theft, although hip-hop fans tended to see it as righteous theft. And, onstage, pop musicians frequently performed alongside recorded tracks, which audiences tolerated—to a point. In 1990, the German duo Milli Vanilli was exposed for having lip-synched both onstage and, in effect, on record, as the two ostensible members of the duo had nothing to do with its music. This, everyone seemed to agree, crossed a line; the group eventually disbanded, and in the aftermath of the scandal the state of New Hampshire passed a law requiring concert promoters to inform audiences when they know, in advance, that “all the lead vocals consist of played recordings rather than the actual singing of those vocalists.” (New York recently enacted a similar law, aimed at A.I., requiring companies to notify the public if advertisements feature “synthetic performers,” although this law explicitly excludes movies and other “expressive works”—presumably including songs.) Nowadays, most big concerts include at least some prerecorded elements; one duty of a touring drummer is to play in time with a click track, which keeps the music onstage in synch with the music on tape. Since so much modern popular music consists of electronic elements, it’s not always clear what it might mean to play these songs “live.” Often, what a concert offers is the undeniable thrill of being in the same room as the person who made the music, regardless of the precise meaning of “made.”

Museumgoers generally agree that a great artist need not wield a paintbrush. They understand that some celebrated artists have

assistants, or studios full of them, while others incorporate found or readymade objects into their practices; indeed, the word “practice” encourages viewers to think holistically about the creative process, instead of fixating on the final product. Avant-garde composers have sometimes built work out of noise or silence, or they’ve written scores that consisted only of instructions, some of which may remind contemporary audiences of A.I. prompts. (La Monte Young, “Composition 1960 #13”: “The performer should prepare any composition and then perform it as well as he can.”) In the world of popular music, different genres tend to have slightly different rules. Outside songwriters are esteemed in pop and country but less so in hip-hop; outside producers are celebrated in hip-hop but less so in house and techno, where the producer *is* the artist. As the process of music-making has grown more electronic, and therefore more mysterious, the human voice has become more central to ideas of musical authenticity. (Or, rather, the semi-human voice—singers in just about every genre have learned to love Auto-Tune.) Usually, we can treat the person or the group on the album cover as the album’s author, but not always. In the old days, record companies sometimes packaged albums with little or no input from the artists themselves, and K-pop fans still argue over how much creative control their favorite idols really have. Britney Spears is an extreme case: her last three albums were released while she was subject to a legal conservatorship; she later said, of some of the music, “I wasn’t into it.”

Part of the reason for the A.I. backlash is that people worry that this complicated system of attribution will be overwhelmed by a tide of interchangeable, computer-generated songs that weren’t really made by or for anybody. I think that’s unlikely. Most A.I. music tends to be disdained by listeners as inauthentic slop—sometimes because it lacks quality, and more often because it lacks context. On its own, A.I. music is bootleg music—not “bootleg” like an unauthorized live album but “bootleg” like a knockoff pair of sneakers, widely and cheaply available. It hasn’t been claimed by

an artist people love or authenticated by a brand that people care about, and so it's not the real thing. As the Muzak corporation discovered, decades ago, people don't like to think of themselves as consumers of undifferentiated slop. They want "real" music for the same reason they want "real" Nikes: because they want to feel connected to a tradition, a narrative, a perception of quality, a person.

Sometimes, of course, a bootleg can become authentic. This past summer, when the Knicks won the N.B.A. Finals, a flood of bootleg Knicks T-shirts engulfed the city; years from now, collectors might distinguish a genuine 2026 bootleg (purchased, perhaps, on Seventh Avenue, on the night of the championship) from a worthless knockoff of a knockoff. The designer Dapper Dan, who helped invent hip-hop fashion, was originally known for his high-fashion knockoffs, but consumers came to view him as a brand unto himself. Anyone who hopes to use A.I. technology in a singular and memorable way faces a similar question: How do you make valuable slop?

One answer is: you don't. Righteous refusal has often been a compelling musical strategy, and sometimes an effective political strategy, too. In the nineteen-forties, the American Federation of Musicians fought for higher royalty rates by going on strike, forbidding its members from making new commercial recordings for more than two years. Today's pop musicians don't have that kind of union power, but the A.F.M. is currently suing two of the big labels, Universal Music Group and Warner Music Group, over their deals with A.I. companies. In the meantime, we may see more acts pledging, Queen-like, that their albums contain no A.I., although this disclaimer might be hard to define. Few people seemed to mind when Charli XCX and her producers talked about having used an A.I.-enabled plug-in to stitch together sampled sounds in a recent song. (Especially with instruments, it can be hard to draw a line between A.I.-enhanced and A.I.-generated.) Queen eventually changed its policy on synthesizers—the group's

eighth album, “The Game,” from 1980, began with the eerie, spiralling sound of an Oberheim OB-X. Most listeners have no idea how their favorite songs were made, but, if A.I.-powered musical tools continue to proliferate, eschewing A.I. might soon be less like eschewing synthesizers and more like eschewing electronics altogether: possible, but only for musicians who really want to make a point.

At the other extreme, audiences may learn to love A.I.-generated songs. Pat McAfee, a top sports commentator, recently released a country album, and one of his collaborators, a bona-fide country singer-songwriter named ERNEST, said that the process began with McAfee “chanting” original lyrics into Suno. The album is awful, but pop history is full of examples of memorable music arising from unpromising circumstances; perhaps a celebrity with a more distinctive lyrical sensibility, or a better ability to identify an exceptionally catchy Suno melody, will use these same tools to build a pop career. In music, as elsewhere, curatorial skill may grow more valuable, along with the ability to write a creative A.I. prompt. (If this sounds to you like a musical dystopia, then you can imagine how Sousa would have felt if he’d learned that d.j.s would eventually conquer the world.) Yet outmoded musical expectations have a way of sticking around: listeners still love the sense that their favorite performers are working hard for them. And so anyone who manages to reliably generate popular A.I. songs will be incentivized to act like a musician—to go out and put on some kind of performance, giving audiences a live version of music that was canned to begin with.

That, more or less, was the fate of Fenix Flexin this summer; after about fifteen minutes on the microphone in New Jersey, he headed to Queens for his second club gig of the night. He has been mercilessly roasted online, but the months of non-stop discourse have given “Rubberz” a kind of historical authenticity. The song is now indelibly tied to this summer, a time of excitement and anxiety over A.I.; it is also indelibly tied to the artist behind it, even if he

didn't actually sing it. But, despite its seeming ubiquity, "Rubberz" has been only a modest hit. It peaked at No. 58 on the *Billboard* Hot 100, and remains notably less popular on YouTube and Spotify than the hip-hop hits Fenix Flexin used to be known for. The anti-A.I. movement seems driven by a worry that people will be fooled by slop, but the listening public tends to have strong and rather unpredictable tastes, and also an insatiable hunger for personal connection. It has grown dramatically easier to make a song in the century since Sousa sounded the alarm about proliferating music technology. But it hasn't grown any easier to make a song that sticks. ♦

Kelefa Sanneh has been a staff writer at The New Yorker since 2008. He is the author of "[Major Labels: A History of Popular Music in Seven Genres](#)."

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/whos-afraid-of-ai-music>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

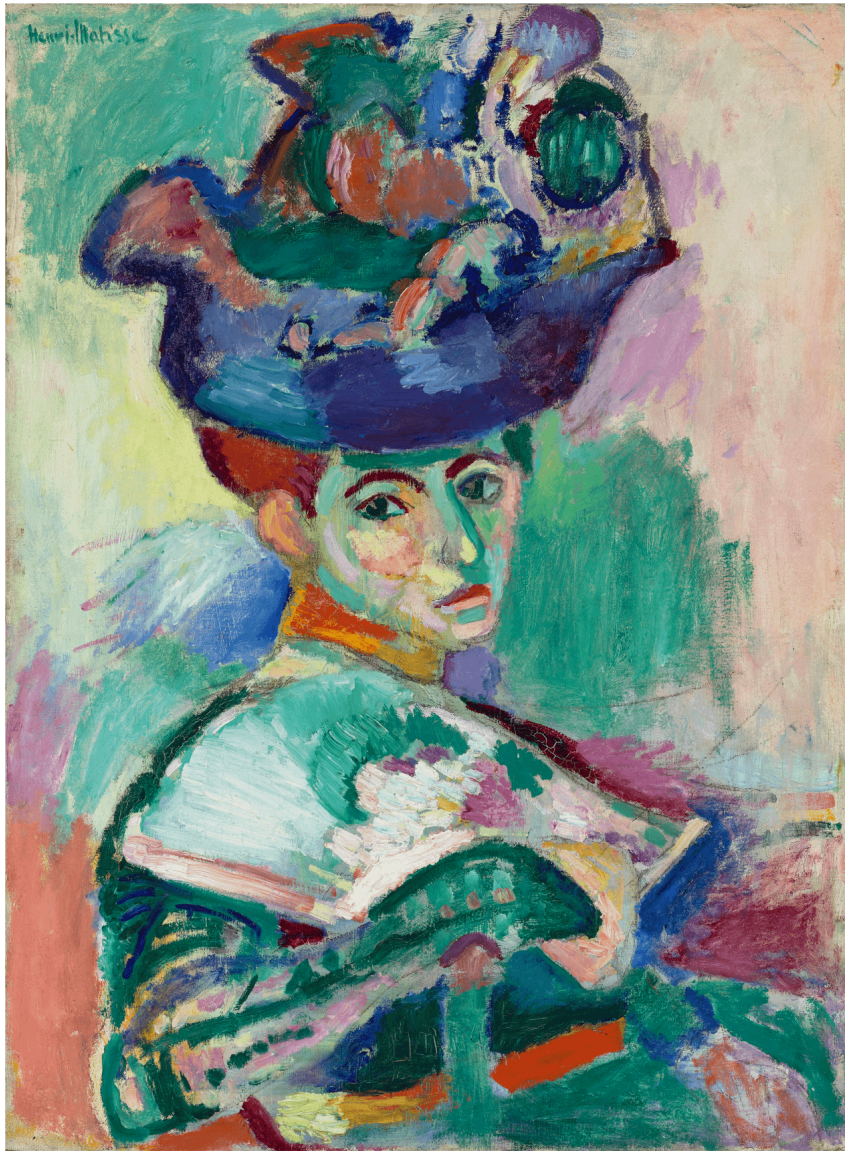
[The Art World](#)

Matisse's Ugliest Painting

More than a century after its incendiary début, “Woman with a Hat” remains wonderfully resistant to the dictates of beauty and taste.

By [Zachary Fine](#)

August 31, 2026



“Femme au Chapeau” (1905).

Art work by Henri Matisse / Courtesy San Francisco Museum of Modern Art; Photograph by Glen Cheriton

Matisse's "Femme au Chapeau" (1905), or "Woman with a Hat," is a strong contender for my least favorite masterpiece of the twentieth century. When it was first exhibited, in Paris, waves of journalists ridiculed it, viewers laughed and jeered, and at least one person tried to scratch it with their nails. More than enough time has passed to wise up to its charms, but I still can't reconcile myself to the shock of its ugliness. The painting looks like a box of melted saltwater taffy that's been churned together and encouraged to express itself as a chic fungus. Leo Stein, the brother of Gertrude, called it "the nastiest smear of paint I had ever seen." That might sound like an insult, but it's not. After negotiating with Matisse, the Steins bought the painting at full price.

"Matisse's Femme au Chapeau: A Modern Scandal," at the San Francisco Museum of Modern Art, looks at how a single work sparked a mini-revolution in art. The exhibition's main room partially re-creates the infamous Gallery VII at the 1905 Salon d'Automne, in the Grand Palais, where Fauvism—the gallery was described as the "*cage aux fauves*," or "cage of wild beasts"—first congealed into a movement. The room included fifty-five pieces by ten artists, all in their twenties or thirties, most of whom had traded the delicate particles of Impressionist brushwork for meaty strokes of absurd color that corresponded not to reality but to the painter's own soul. (Or so they implied.)



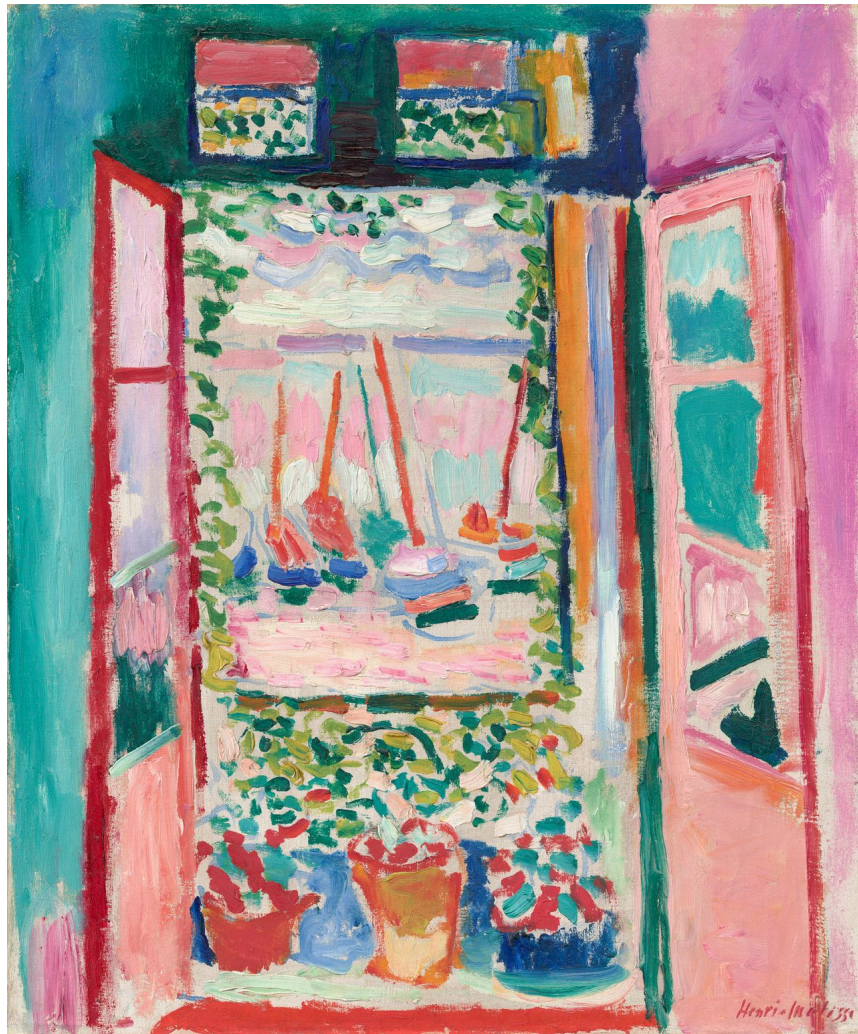
*“Henri Matisse” (1905), André Derain’s portrait of the artist.
Art work by André Derain / Courtesy ARS / Tate*

The entire gallery was a scandal, but the cause célèbre was “Femme au Chapeau”: technically a portrait of Matisse’s wife, Amélie, at age thirty-three. Other Fauves deployed bright, acid colors and sharp contrasts, but their work was either too cozy with Post-Impressionism, as in the wriggling outlines of Maurice de Vlaminck, or too subdued in subject matter, like André Derain’s landscapes, to provoke as much attention. A portrait typically ennobles a sitter—certifying a social rank or commemorating a fondness. When Derain painted Matisse during their fateful sojourn in Collioure, a small coastal village where, in the summer of 1905, they cracked open their palettes and set Fauvism in motion, he gave him warm, peachy skin and a dignified pipe. Not so with Matisse’s

portrait of Amélie, whose face is mostly a seasick green. Her spade-shaped jaw and cartoonish eyes barely amount to a likeness. In one sense, “Femme au Chapeau” is a painting *about* painting: a portrait of someone being devoured by paint, not represented by it. But it’s also a portrait of a hat.

Matisse was no stranger to hats. His grandmothers were hatmakers, his aunts were hatmakers, his mother was a hatmaker, and so, too, was Amélie. She opened her own shop in Paris, on Rue de Châteaudun, the year after she and Matisse married, and they lived in the attic above it. One can imagine the kitchen table littered with bobbins, pins, and feathers, as the paraphernalia of the milliner’s life floated up into their private quarters. These were hard years for Matisse: years of professional failure and doubt, when his father shamed him for being an artist and cut off support; years of bronchitis and insomnia, when Amélie would stay up until dawn and read to him; and years of financial strain, when her trade effectively subsidized his. The hat business sustained Matisse and their three children, at least until 1903, when Amélie, in poor health, was forced to close the shop.

Matisse couldn’t have felt neutrally about Amélie making crowns for the same class of wealthy patrons who refused to support him. In the portrait, there’s more than a touch of resentment in the object on her head (*Enough with the hats, Amélie!*)—it’s ridiculous even by late-Belle Époque fashion standards—and there’s some lingering resentment, too. As a law student in the eighteen-eighties, Matisse lived on the sixth floor of a cheap hotel in Paris and would use a glass peashooter to fire little balls of putty at the hats of people on the street below. Even before he was “bitten by the demon of painting,” he chafed at the constraints of bourgeois respectability while feeling compelled to uphold them. Hats were a convenient target.



"Open Window, Collioure" (1905).

Art work by Henri Matisse / Courtesy © 2026 Succession H. Matisse / ARS / National Gallery of Art

In "Femme au Chapeau," at least a third of the composition is *chapeau*—and this particular hat is more of a mangled fruit basket, in which nothing is decipherable. The purple tongue sticking out of the top might belong to an iris, and the lobes of reddish orange could be an apple, but they likely aren't. We're looking through the eyes of someone who doesn't want to actually see the hat. Matisse's project was to wrench the appearance of things, particularly their colors, away from reality, and to let them entertain a new internal correspondence guided by his expressive whims. It's a childish way to thank the world for its visual bounty, but he knew that. Reminiscing about his summer with Derain, Matisse said, "We were at that point like children before nature, and we let our temperaments speak. . . . I spoiled everything on principle, and worked as I felt, only by color." The desire to spoil,

to transgress on principle, to *épater le bourgeois*—those are the words of the avant-garde artist.

There's a well-manicured story about Matisse becoming a modern painter—the drift from conservative academies and salons toward eccentric splinter groups; the pixelated brushwork transmitted through Paul Signac; the seductiveness of Cézanne; the plunges into southern light in Corsica, Saint-Tropez, and Collioure—but I worry that this sketch has numbed us to the specific case of “Femme au Chapeau,” which is much more temperamental and, well, *freakish* than what the artist made before and after. Matisse spent months working on a different painting for the 1905 Salon d'Automne: a landscape, filled with formulaic dashes and carefully modulated color contrasts, called “The Port of Abail.” He tossed it aside and in a matter of weeks whipped up “Femme au Chapeau” as a substitute—the brilliance of one painting released by the frustration of another. In the years on either side of “Femme au Chapeau,” Matisse painted two Arcadian fantasies, “Luxe, Calme et Volupté” (1904) and “Le Bonheur de Vivre” (1906), that show his style trending toward flat, simplified forms and liquid arabesques. Those paintings affirm Matisse's reputation as modern art's ultimate pleasure-seeker—the man who famously said that art should be like a “good armchair,” and whose studios had a tendency to evaporate the clothes of women.

The portrait of Madame Matisse, by contrast, is an anxious smear job. Generally, a painting's Fauvist credentials rely on at least three factors: the use of nonmimetic color (e.g., no worldly skin tones or blue water); the contrast of complementary colors to balance the picture (red and green, orange and blue, etc.); and the flat application of “pure” color, as opposed to subtle shades, with each patch marking a Cézanne-like shift in plane (i.e., hue, more than line, structuring the space). What's odd is that Matisse's painting doesn't abide by any of these rules, at least not entirely. Unlike his other high-Fauve entry in the 1905 salon, “Open Window, Collioure,” which uses a palette of pinks and mint greens to

establish clean contrasts, “Femme au Chapeau” permits no easy pleasures. The painting is filled with inconsistencies and bizarre compensatory moves. Its attitude can be summarized by a single square inch at the base of Amélie’s neck, where one finds eight colors in competition: orange, yellow, blue, white, teal, apricot, pale brown, and some black, as underdrawing.

Matisse takes every opportunity to disturb passages of chromatic balance. The red hair that connects with the green of Amélie’s temple? It’s interrupted by a few strokes of magenta, to increase the tension. The blue of the hat’s brim? A splash of teal agitates its roundness. While some of the color contrasts do articulate planar shifts, such as the candy-stripe lips (red for upper, pink for lower), many of the touches are arbitrary splotches that neither bolster a shape nor set another off. I have to imagine that Matisse was tickled by his decision to put a large tract of green in front of Madame’s face and, instead of extending it all the way to her throat, suddenly introduce a purple goatee.

The aspect of the painting that troubles me most, though, is the sleeve of Amélie’s dress. Fauvism was supposedly characterized by the phasing out of the Neo-Impressionist *tache*, or uniformly pointillist stroke—abundant in “Luxe, Calme et Volupté” and “The Port of Abail”—in favor of broader patches of color, but the green sleeve, with its cobra-headed cuff, is a creepy disturbance to the brushwork elsewhere. Compared with the thick smudges of white on the fan that Amélie is holding, or the broad, lush strokes of the background, the sleeve is fidgety. None of its marks seem to maintain their integrity for more than an inch or two without being fretted or spoiled. There’s a slight air of death around it, as if the arm is deteriorating in front of us.

Part of the greatness of “Femme au Chapeau” is the endurance of its ugliness. Most ugly things are easy to assimilate or neutralize in time. But Matisse made sure to create enough visual friction to prevent that from happening. The composure of Amélie, and the

decidedly wild and clownish manner in which she's painted, can't be tamed into order, elegance, or beauty. There's also no golden picture frame or change in fashion that will make the painting's bourgeois genre (portraiture) comport with its over-the-top accessory (the hat). The hat is destined to be hideous and interesting, and the painting is determined to be *too much*—too colorful, too self-conscious of its own materials, “excessively modern,” as one person put it. That was in 1905. Lucky for us, the painting still is. ♦

Zachary Fine, a contributing writer at The New Yorker, is the Kim-Frank postdoctoral fellow in criticism at Wesleyan University.

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/matisses-ugliest-painting>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

[On Television](#)

In “Adults,” Gen Z Gets the Hangout Sitcom It Deserves

The FX series, which is returning for a second season, won’t restore the genre to its normcore roots—but, happily, it has no interest in doing so.

By [Inkoo Kang](#)

August 27, 2026



“Adults” is part of a Zoomer revamp of a time-honored format—one that, until recently, had all but disappeared from the TV landscape.

Illustration by Calum Heath

The twentysomething protagonists of the Gen Z hangout comedy “Adults” understand that growing up sometimes requires an intervention. In the first episode of the new season, which premieres this week, five housemates gather in their living room to conduct what they’ve dubbed the Scrub: the act of identifying and

erasing their most employment-endangering social-media posts, under the credo that you must “bury your past before it buries you.” A clip of Samir (Malik Ellassal) as a teen-ager, comforting a female celebrity through the power of dance after Trump’s first election? Delete. A YouTube video of Issa (Amita Rao) counting down the “top ten worst accents”? *Definite* delete. “It’s not our fault we got the internet when we were our most horny and stupid,” Samir protests. Yes, it’s an exercise in humiliation—but it’s the kind of lesson you’d rather get from your nearest and dearest than from an H.R. department. And it fits right into the time-honored sitcom tradition of needing a little help from your friends.

Television’s great crowd-pleasers used to hinge on such chemistry and warmth. In the early nineties, the writers David Crane and Marta Kauffman pitched NBC on the then relatively novel insight that “when you’re single and in the city, your friends are your family.” The result of this epiphany was “Friends,” a ratings juggernaut that remains improbably popular three decades later. The formula that show cemented—of idealistic urbanites, often with more education than experience, getting mired in low-stakes high jinks—led to such notable successors as “How I Met Your Mother,” which debuted in 2005, and “New Girl,” in 2011. Eventually, the young-people-doing-nothing format got the prestige treatment, with 2012’s “Girls” (which admittedly owes as much to “Sex and the City”) and 2014’s “Broad City.” These edgier entries reflected the dominant cultural forces of their era: cringe comedy and exuberant feminism, respectively.

Since then, the hangout sitcom has suffered a precipitous decline. Its native structure, the twenty-two-episode season, has become a rarity in the industry, as has its default lightness. But the genre is mounting a comeback. “Adults” is part of this Zoomer revamp, along with Rachel Sennott’s pricklier “I Love LA”—the “Seinfeld” to “Adults” ’s “Friends”—and Mindy Kaling’s creakier “Not Suitable for Work.” Whereas Rachel and Monica’s misadventures in “Friends” ultimately spanned a decade or so in the city, “Adults”

seems hyper-focussed on that fabled sliver of one's twenties before ambition or even romance sets in—when life is composed almost entirely of side quests, and deciding on a main quest is still a few years away. The show's central quintet reside in the childhood home of Samir, whose semi-retired parents are on an apparently indefinite tour of the national parks. Samir allows his friends to live with him for free while he works as a food-delivery driver—a gig that he's happy to put on pause when the opportunity arises to play video games with some teen-age boys who've used the app to order beer. Guests—defined loosely as anyone from a random hookup to Julia Fox to a surprisingly chill raccoon—drop by the house with regularity, creating a zippy blend of the mundane and the serendipitous.

The married creators of “Adults,” Ben Kronengold and Rebecca Shaw, seem well aware of the lineage of their series. (At one point, a character played by the “Girls” star Zosia Mamet asks one of the protagonists, “You think you’re the first people to be young and adorable in New York?”) Perhaps that’s why the pair has striven to create fresh archetypes. The most fully realized personalities are Anton (Owen Thiele), a compulsive charmer who needs to make every passing acquaintance feel as though they’ve forged a lasting connection, and Billie (Lucy Freyer), a former overachiever who’s lost without the structure of school. (Offscreen, Billie may be singlehandedly keeping the gifted-child-meme industry alive by liking every post about smart kids who never live up to their potential.) But other characters verge on parody. Issa, an overconfident blusterer whom Samir and Anton met in college, seems to be stuck doing a one-note Ilana Glazer impression; her boyfriend, Paul Baker (Jack Innanen), who’s always referred to by his full name, is distinguished only by being Canadian, sexually fluid, and nice.

“Adults” won’t be the hangout show that restores the genre to its normcore, network-friendly roots—if such a return is even viable in the current comedy landscape. Happily, it’s not trying to be. Its

politics lean unapologetically left; like “Girls” and “Broad City” before it, “Adults” features an irreverent abortion subplot. It also eschews the heteronormativity of its predecessors: Anton is gay, Billie sleeps with both men and women, and the show’s primary will-they-won’t-they couple is queer. One half of that would-be pairing is Paul Baker, whose softboi credentials come into question when it emerges that he has a second, markedly straighter friend group—a pack of testicle-slapping bros promptly labelled the Shame Friends.

The divide sets up the kind of ethnography at which “Adults” excels. In the Season 2 première, a riotous piece of generational social taxonomy, this other crew tries haplessly to cater to the tastes and mores of the main group, with one dude donning a “directed by Greta Gerwig” T-shirt and later declaring, “I have mental health!” But there’s also a subtle rejection of the earnest wokeness of years past. The diversity of the core ensemble—a far cry from Hannah Horvath’s all-white friend group—is rarely remarked upon by the characters, except as part of a bit. The show itself acknowledges their identities only obliquely, as in an episode where an exhausted Anton forgets to code switch at his corporate job and praises a colleague’s presentation by chirping, “Cunt alert!” Naturally, the rest of the plot focusses on his elaborate scheme to get out of hot water by normalizing the word in his office.

Each successive generation since “Friends” has seen its sitcom youths diminished in their circumstances. Rachel and Monica’s West Village sublet gave way to Hannah and Marnie’s Greenpoint apartment—an address that might be considered laughably unattainable by the broke twentysomethings of today. The most original element of “Adults” is its setting: a cozy single-family house in outer Queens, filled with the décor choices of a middle-aged mom, all floral patterns and ornately carved furniture. Though the home is a haven for Samir and his friends, it is pointedly not theirs. “Adults” doesn’t dwell on the contingency of the characters’ housing situation, but economic struggle is the show’s

unmistakable backdrop. It's evident in the sheer number of scenes that take place in the living room or the kitchen. While earlier sitcom crews met up at a coffee shop or a bar, young people like Billie—who spends her days submitting dozens of job applications without a single reply—are scarcely in a position to treat the city as their playground.

Such worries are more prominent in the superior second season, which finds some of the friends engaging in that perpetual hobbyhorse of the young: fretting about no longer being as young as they used to be. Billie's anxieties about her lack of accomplishments at twenty-five are exacerbated by meeting the infinitely cooler girl who now uses her old fake I.D., and the typically even-keeled Anton can't help regressing into a shrieking brat in the presence of his older sister (Raven-Symoné). These story lines add a sense of urgency and progress to a series that was a little too comfortable being amiably aimless. The shift feels like the show finding its footing in a more traditional sitcom register.

Kronengold and Shaw rarely falter in coming up with unique plotlines and sharply observed jokes. But, compared with its forebears, which gradually accrued emotional power as their characters matured together, "Adults" seems strangely reluctant to delve into the inner lives of young people whose hearts may never again be so open or vulnerable. In the first season, for instance, Billie's fear that she peaked in high school leads to an ill-advised fling with her middle-aged journalism teacher. The relationship ends in calamity, of course, but the series spends little time wondering what she gleaned from the experience. When the friends do divulge deeper secrets to one another, they often instruct the hearer to "mind wipe": to listen to the revelation, then pretend as if they never did. Like the Scrub, it's a self-protective gesture, designed to mitigate risk. But we can get to know the characters only so well when they're doing their best not to know themselves. ♦

Inkoo Kang, a staff writer, has been a television critic for The New Yorker since 2022.

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/adults-tv-review-fx>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

Poems

- **“Just Kidding”**

By Rita Dove | “A priest, a rabbi, and a poet walk into a bar / and we’re laughing already, calculating their clashing philosophies.”

- **“Horse Song of a Nightmare”**

By Joy Harjo | “It is raining, raining, raining. / The sky is falling, falling, falling.”

Poems

Just Kidding

By *Rita Dove*

August 30, 2026

A priest, a rabbi, and a poet walk into a bar
and we're laughing already, calculating their clashing philosophies
—

New Testament, the Torah, W. B. Yeats—all
the earnest sacraments undertaken in the name of world harmony:
loaves & fishes, bitter herbs, the spread offered at the free buffet.
We've even uploaded their wardrobes
(dog collar, skullcap, jeans & elbow-patched tweed)
as we wait for the next line's classic setup for ridicule,
because we know the poet's gonna be the one to rip
this sucker apart; it's always the last one through the door
who gets the biggest laugh.

But we've forgotten the bar! There it stands,
waiting to be leaned on, a gleaming walnut shoulder
anointed with Scotch and spittle. Poor bar!
Elbowed, drooled over, kicked and beslobbered,
its whisky-ring tattoos a parade of evenings
lost to sorrow, to rage, the occasional pickup—

Are you uncomfortable yet? Itching in your seat,
muttering, *Where's the fun in this? It's the poet's doing—
they can turn bread into zwieback, wine into vinegar,
claim edification in the name of one lousy epiphany.*
When's it coming, the goddam punch line?

Oooof! There goes one to the gut.
A priest, a rabbi, and a poet at the bar. What'll it be?

Old-Fashioned, Negroni, Moscow Mule—you decide.
They don't speak. They aren't acquainted. They just
happen to need something stronger than what's out there
and enter the same establishment at the same time—10 *p.m.*—

where the bartender, wiping away some previous patron's
ablutions,
asks: "What's your poison?"—to which
the priest thinks: *Angel's Envy*,
the rabbi murmurs: *Killer Whale*,
the poet sighs: *I've drawn a blank, just fill me up*—
and the bartender sets down their drinks with a half-mast salute
to these disparate, desperate creatures
who already know they're the butt of the joke
and gamely take the hit.

Rita Dove is a Pulitzer Prize winner and a former U.S. Poet Laureate. Her books include the collection "[Playlist for the Apocalypse](#)." She teaches at the University of Virginia.

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/just-kidding-rita-dove-poem>

Poems

Horse Song of a Nightmare

By [Joy Harjo](#)

August 30, 2026

It is raining, raining, raining.
The sky is falling, falling, falling.
I never, never, never.
Saw this would happen, happen, happen.
As in any flooding, flooding, flooding.
The earth is breaking, breaking, breaking.
All the sorrow, sorrow, sorrow, kneeling.
Inside the loss and anger kindling.
Set forth the burning, burning, burning.
On this earthly star shining, shining, shining.
Then we lost our footing, footing, footing.
Again the falling, falling, falling.
Into a nightmare running, running, running.
On black horses riding, riding, riding.
Through darkness in the raining, raining, raining.
Then there we were standing, standing, standing.
On the grassy hump of dawning, dawning, dawning.
Over the mountains rainy, rainy, rainy.

The clouds leaned down to sing.

This is drawn from “[Cloud Runner](#).”

Joy Harjo served three terms as U.S. Poet Laureate. Her books include the poetry collection “[Weaving Sundown in a Scarlet Light](#)” and the memoir “[Girl Warrior](#).”

<https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/09/07/horse-song-of-a-nightmare-joy-harjo-poem>

| [Section menu](#) | [Main menu](#) |

Puzzles & Games

- **[The Crossword: Monday, August 31, 2026](#)**

By Brooke Husic | A challenging puzzle.

Crossword

The Crossword: Monday, August 31, 2026

A challenging puzzle.

By [Brooke Husic](#)

August 31, 2026

Loading game...

[Brooke Husic](#) is the crossword editor at *Puzzmo*.

<https://www.newyorker.com/puzzles-and-games-dept/crossword/2026/08/31>